

The Nightingale



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF KRISTIN HANNAH

Kristin Hannah spent the early years of her life in Southern California before her family relocated to Washington in 1968. As a child, Hannah traveled a lot; her father was always in search of adventure, and he took the family along with him in a Volkswagen bus. One year, the Hannah family made it all the way up to the Kenai River in Alaska, a region they fell in love with. Later in her life, Hannah graduated from the University of Washington, and for several years she worked for an advertising agency. Later, she would graduate from the University of Puget Sound law school and become a practicing lawyer. While in law school, Hannah's mother was diagnosed with cancer, which would eventually kill her. During this difficult period of her life, Hannah and her mother began working on a novel together. Although the book was never published, it sparked the beginning of Hannah's extensive writing career. Hannah published her first novel, *A Handful of Heaven*, in 1991 and would publish nine more novels over the next decade. The novel that made Hannah a literary star, *Firefly Lane*, arrived in 2008; it has since sold over a million copies and was turned into a Netflix series. In 2015 Hannah published *The Nightingale*, her most critically and commercially successful novel. It sold over 4.5 million copies and is currently being adapted into a film. Hannah's most successful works, including *Firefly Lane*, *The Nightingale*, and [The Great Alone](#) are works of historical fiction. Today, Hannah lives in Washington with her family.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

The Nightingale takes place during World War II. Its main characters are French citizens who watch as German soldiers rapidly take over their country. France entered World War II in September 1939 following the German invasion of Poland. For many months, France heavily defended what is known as "the Maginot Line," a line of fortifications built along the border between France and Germany. However, the Maginot Line fell in May 1940, and German forces quickly advanced through France. By the middle of June, the Nazis reached and began to occupy Paris. At this point, the French government surrendered, and the Nazis took control of France. Although the Vichy government (France's governmental body at the time) ostensibly controlled the free part of France, they had little power over the Germans and primarily acted as collaborators. The war was brutal on French citizens; many men were sent to Nazi labor camps and not allowed to return home. Meanwhile, many wives were left to fend for themselves and their children. German soldiers often kept the best food

and resources for themselves, and the French population experienced widespread starvation and sickness. France suffered the horrors of the Nazi occupation until August 1944, following the liberation of Paris.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

The Nightingale is a work of historical fiction. In particular, it is a novel about World War II. Many contemporary fiction writers have written about World War II including, Anthony Doerr ([All the Light We Cannot See](#)), Heather Morris ([The Tattooist of Auschwitz](#)), and Markus Zusak ([The Book Thief](#)). One recent novel, Mark Sullivan's [Beneath a Scarlet Sky](#), shares a special affinity with *The Nightingale*. Both novels take place in Nazi-occupied countries and feature characters who help persecuted groups escape into neutral territories. The primary difference between the two novels is that *The Nightingale* is set in France while [Beneath a Scarlet Sky](#) takes place in Italy. *The Nightingale* is also a work of feminist literature, emphasizing relationships between women and their children. In this way, *The Nightingale* is similar to Emma Donoghue's [Room](#), which Kristin Hannah lists as one of her favorite books. Additionally, the themes in *The Nightingale*—particularly those related to war's mental and physical impacts—are a mainstay in Hannah's bibliography. Another Hannah book that probes these themes in depth is [The Great Alone](#), which deals with the toll war can take on an individual's mind.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** The Nightingale
- **When Written:** 2014
- **Where Written:** Bainbridge Island, Washington
- **When Published:** 2015
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary
- **Genre:** Novel, Historical Fiction
- **Setting:** France, 1939–1945
- **Climax:** The Nazis capture Isabelle and torture her for information about The Nightingale. To save his daughter, Julien sacrifices himself by turning himself in and claiming he is The Nightingale. As a result, Julien is executed, and Isabelle is sent to a concentration camp.
- **Antagonist:** Von Richter
- **Point of View:** Third Person and First Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Move Adaptation. Currently, *The Nightingale* is being adapted into a movie starring real-life sisters Dakota and Elle Fanning,

who will play Vianne and Isabelle, respectively.

Book of the People. *The Nightingale* won the Goodreads award for Best Historical Fiction and the People's Choice Award in 2015.



PLOT SUMMARY

The Nightingale begins with an unnamed narrator looking at some old objects in her attic that date back to World War II. It is currently 1995, and the narrator lives on the Oregon Coast. Her son, Julien Mauriac, asks her about the objects, but she is evasive. Suddenly, the novel goes back in time to August 1939. The setting is Carriveau, France, a provincial town, where Vianne Mauriac lives with her husband, Antoine, and her daughter, Sophie. Although they live an idyllic life, Vianne and Antoine are worried because war is on the horizon. Vianne's father, Julien Rossignol, fought in World War I, and she knows what war can do to the human soul. Vianne is now estranged from her father because of how the war impacted him. Eventually, Antoine is called to fight, and Vianne is left home alone with Sophie.

Meanwhile, Vianne's younger sister, Isabelle, gets kicked out of her third school and is forced to return to Paris to live with her father. On the train to Paris, Isabelle is nervous, fearing that her father might not accept her. Although Julien takes Isabelle in temporarily, it is clear that he does not want to. A few months later, the Nazis invade France. Before they can make it to Paris, Julien sends Isabelle out of the city to go live with Vianne. Although Isabelle protests, she does as she is told.

Isabelle's journey to Carriveau is perilous. Many people are fleeing Paris, and she is forced to walk most of the way on foot. On the way, she meets a handsome young man named Gaëtan who has just been released from jail. Gaëtan implies that he was jailed because he is a communist rebel. Isabelle immediately falls in love with Gaëtan, and they travel together to Carriveau. Although Gaëtan promises to take Isabelle with him to join the resistance after they stop in Carriveau, he instead leaves Isabelle behind with a note that says, "You are not ready."

Although Vianne is happy to see her sister safe, their relationship is strained. Vianne feels guilty that she was not there for Isabelle after their mother died and their father virtually abandoned them. Vianne's life becomes even more complicated when a German soldier, Beck, is assigned to live in her home. Isabelle treats Beck—and any other German she meets—rudely, and Vianne worries that she will put Sophie's life in danger.

Isabelle continues her rebellious streak by joining the local resistance. In the night, she secretly passes out flyers that contain anti-German sentiments. Eventually the resistance

asks her to travel to Paris to deliver a message and act as a point of contact. Before departing, she lies to Vianne and says she is leaving to be with a boy. Vianne believes Isabelle and chastises her for her seemingly irresponsible actions. Once in Paris, Isabelle convinces Julien to let her live with him.

Vianne's life with Beck is mostly comfortable. Although he is a German soldier, Vianne thinks that he is a good man. He treats her and Sophie with kindness and respects their property. Additionally, he does Vianne a favor and looks into Antoine's status. As it turns out, Antoine is in a POW camp and isn't allowed to come home. One day, Beck asks Vianne to write down the names of all the Jewish people who teach at Vianne's school. Vianne is hesitant but ultimately does what Beck asks because he promises to send Julien a care package. The list gets Vianne's best friend, Rachel, fired from her job for the crime of being Jewish. Vianne angrily confronts Beck who tells her that he did not know what the list would be used for and that he was just following orders. Vianne is unsure whether to believe him.

For some time, Vianne has a difficult time trusting Beck. However, one day, while Vianne is with Rachel, Beck shows up and tells them to make sure that Rachel cannot be found the following day. His implication is that something will happen to her because she is Jewish. Vianne trusts Beck. That night, she attempts to take Rachel and her children, Sarah and Ari, to the Free Zone of France. However, while standing in line to pass through a checkpoint, a Nazi soldier begins firing into a crowd of people, and a stray bullet hits Sarah, killing her. Vianne, Rachel, and Ari flee back to Vianne's home. Vianne recovers Sarah's body and buries her while Rachel and Ari hide in a secret space Isabelle created below Vianne's barn.

The next day, however, authorities show up and arrest Rachel and put her on a train headed for Germany. Rachel leaves Ari with Vianne. When Vianne returns home with Ari, Beck informs her that soon Ari won't be safe either, but he promises to do what he can to help. Eventually, Beck manages to secure identity papers for Ari that say his name is Daniel. From that point on, Vianne raises Ari like her own son.

In Paris, Isabelle becomes a key figure in the resistance. She also learns that her father has been acting as a member of the resistance all along. In fact, he wrote the pamphlets she delivered all over Carriveau. Not long after arriving in Paris, Isabelle spearheads an effort to transport British fighter pilots across the Pyrenees and into Spain. Over time, she rescues dozens of pilots this way. Along the way, she picks up the code name "**The Nightingale**" and becomes a notorious figure among the Nazis. Additionally, she reunites with Gaëtan, who is also part of the Paris resistance.

One day, Isabelle returns to Carriveau for a resistance meeting. On her way to the meeting, she sees a fighter pilot go down and quickly moves to rescue him. She takes the pilot to Vianne's barn and hides him in the secret space. Beck is put in charge of

finding the down pilot and is frustrated when he cannot. While Beck is away, Vianne sees the barn door open, goes to investigate, and finds Isabelle and the fighter pilot. Vianne chastises Isabelle for putting her life and Sophie's life in danger once again. Isabelle apologizes and promises to leave as soon as possible. Just then, Beck comes home and starts searching the property. Just before he checks the space in the barn, Vianne hits Beck in the head with a shovel, killing him. As she does so, Beck's gun goes off and a bullet strikes Isabelle, wounding her. Immediately after, Gaëtan shows up to help. He promises Vianne to get rid of the bodies and help Isabelle.

Gaëtan gets rid of the bodies and nurses Isabelle back to health. While acting as Isabelle's nurse, Gaëtan and Isabelle fall in love and begin a sexual relationship. However, after a few weeks of romance, Gaëtan goes to join a group engaging in guerilla warfare, and Isabelle returns to escorting pilots. Not long after, Nazis capture and torture Isabelle. They want to know the identity of "The Nightingale," which Isabelle refuses to give up. Julien, wanting to protect his daughter, turns himself in to the Nazis, claiming that he's the Nightingale. The Nazis execute Julien in front of Isabelle and then ship her to a labor camp in Germany.

Meanwhile, a new Nazi, Von Richter, moves into Vianne's house. Von Richter is a savage who is cruel to Vianne and her children. Vianne increasingly worries for her family's safety. One day, Vianne sees a Jewish woman being shepherded onto a train with her child. The woman gives Vianne her child and asks her to save him. Vianne takes the child to her local church leader, whom she trusts, and begs her for help. Mother Superior, the church leader, promises to help Vianne, and together they secure identity papers for the child and keep him safe. At this point, Vianne becomes an active part of the resistance and starts helping numerous children in similar ways, all with help of Mother Superior.

One day, Vianne comes home and finds Von Richter with a horrifying smile on his face. He tells Vianne that he knows Ari's true identity and asks her what she will do to keep that information from getting out. Vianne tells him that she will do anything, and so he rapes her. Von Richter repeatedly rapes and abuses Vianne; months later, she discovers she is pregnant. Not long after, the German troops pull out of Carriveau, and Antoine returns home having escaped from the camp he was held in. Vianne decides to have sex with Antoine right away and pretend that the child is his.

While Vianne is dealing with Von Richter and her pregnancy, Isabelle struggles to survive in a labor camp. She manages to survive until American troops come and liberate the camp. She returns home to Carriveau a sick and broken woman. Vianne cares for Isabelle the best she can, although it is clear that Isabelle will soon die. Before Isabelle dies, Gaëtan returns to Carriveau and sees her one last time. Isabelle dies in his arms. The novel ends with the unnamed narrator from the beginning

attending a reunion in Paris. The novel reveals that the narrator is Vianne, and she is attending the reunion on behalf of Isabelle, and many fighter pilots who Isabelle saved as well as their families attend the event. Gaëtan is also there, as is Ari, who moved to America to live with his relatives after the war. Vianne attends the conference with her son, Julien (who is actually Von Richter's child). Although Julien learns a lot about his mother's past at the conference, Vianne never tells him who his real father is—that is one secret she wants to keep hidden.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator) – Vianne Mauriac is the mother of Sophie and Julien Mauriac, the wife of Antoine Mauriac, and the sister of Isabelle Rossignol. Antoine and Sophie are Vianne's entire life, and she does everything she can to protect them. Vianne also loves Isabelle, although their relationship is strained. Vianne feels bad that she was not more present in her sister's life following the death of their mother. At the time, however, Vianne was only a child herself and did not know how to cope or be a good sister. At the start of World War II, Vianne keeps her head down and does anything she can to protect Sophie. She chastises Isabelle for her small rebellions and does not want to take an active part in resistance efforts. However, as the war drags on, Vianne is forced to choose a side. Eventually, she begins actively helping Jewish children escape Nazi persecution with the help of her church. Later in life, she regrets that she did not do more to help earlier on in the war. She wishes she could've been more like Isabelle, who resisted from the very start. At the end of the novel, readers learn that Vianne is that unnamed narrator who appears throughout the narrative. It is also revealed that Julien, her son, is the offspring of Von Richter, a cruel Nazi who raped Vianne while living in her home.

Isabelle Rossignol – Isabelle Rossignol is the sister of Vianne Mauriac and the daughter of Julien Mauriac. From a young age, Isabelle is a rebel who does not do well in school and does not like acting like a lady. She rejects the role the gender norms that society forces on her, and when war comes, she is eager to sign up for the resistance. Isabelle is brave but also reckless, and her carelessness frequently endangers her loved ones. Isabelle's actions regularly upset Vianne. Ultimately, though, Isabelle's bravery outweighs her negative attributes and, although she can still be headstrong, she largely grows out of her reckless nature over the course of the novel. In fact, she becomes an active part of the French resistance and, in doing so, saves the lives of hundreds of people. Isabelle is a war hero and the novel's title is a reference to her codename, "**The Nightingale.**" Toward the end of the novel, the Nazis discover Isabelle's resistance efforts and send her to a Nazi labor camp. There, she experiences brutal torture that breaks her physical body—but

never her spirit. Isabelle survives the camp just long enough to reunite with her lover, Gaëtan, and with Vianne. She dies at the novel's end.

Gaëtan – Gaëtan is a French resistance fighter as well as Isabelle's lover. He is a strong and brave man who does everything he can to thwart the Nazis. At first, Gaëtan actively avoids a relationship with Isabelle; he loves her but knows that one of them could likely die in the war and doesn't want to make life harder than it already is. However, eventually he gives in to his feelings, and he and Isabelle start a passionate relationship. Shortly after, their resistance efforts force them apart, and they do not see each other for a long time. After the war is over, Gaëtan manages to return to Carriveau to reunite with Isabelle one last time before her death.

Julien Rossignol – Julien Rossignol is the father of Vianne Mauriac and Isabelle Rossignol. He is a World War I veteran who came back from the war a changed man. After the death of his wife, Julien essentially became estranged from his daughters. During World War II, Julien is a key member of the French resistance. He provides fake papers for those who need them and writes anti-German pamphlets. In the climax of the novel, he claims that he is the **Nightingale**, effectively sacrificing himself to spare Isabelle's life.

Rachel de Champlain – Rachel de Champlain is the wife of Marc de Champlain and the mother of Ari and Sarah de Champlain. She is also Vianne Mauriac's best friend. Rachel is a loving mother and a good friend. However, because she is Jewish, she is persecuted by the Nazis. She is fired from her job and eventually sent to a labor camp for being Jewish. After the war, Vianne learns that Rachel died while in the labor camp.

Captain Beck – Captain Beck is a Nazi soldier who is assigned to stay in Vianne's home. Although he is polite, Vianne doesn't know whether to trust him. Eventually, Vianne realizes that he is a good man who is simply on the wrong side of the war. He does not approve of the actions of his superiors and is doing his best to get through the war. Vianne kills him because he is about to discover a fighter pilot Isabelle has hidden in her barn. In the aftermath of his death, she struggles to come to terms with her role in his death.

Julien Mauriac – Julien Mauriac is the son of Vianne Mauriac and Von Richter. However, Julien thinks that his father is Antoine Mauriac because Vianne refused to tell him otherwise. Julien is completely unaware of what his mother went through during World War II until the end of the novel when he attends an event with her in Paris.

Ari de Champlain – Ari de Champlain is the son of Rachel and Marc de Champlain. After Rachel gets sent to a concentration camp, Vianne takes him in and raises him as her own son. At the end of the war, Ari is sent to America to live with his relatives. Decades later, he reunites with Vianne in Paris and expresses his gratitude.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Antoine Mauriac – Antoine Mauriac is the husband of Vianne Mauriac and the father of Sophie Mauriac. He is a brave man who is captured while defending France and sent to a Nazi labor camp. Toward the end of the war, Antoine successfully escapes the camp and returns to his family.

Sophie Mauriac – Sophie Mauriac is the daughter of Vianne and Antoine Mauriac. She is a kind and brave girl who matures well beyond her years over the course of World War II. She dies in 1980 from cancer.

General de Gaulle – General de Gaulle is the leader of the resistance in France. Isabelle never meets him in person, but she is inspired to join the resistance because she hears him speak on the radio.

Sarah de Champlain – Sarah de Champlain is the daughter of Rachel and Marc de Champlain. She is also Sophie's best friend. Sarah gets shot and killed by a stray bullet while the de Champlains are attempting to flee to the Free Zone of France.

Henri – Henri is a French resistance fighter in Carriveau who recruits Isabelle. He also helps Vianne get identity papers for the Jewish children she is hiding from the Nazis. Henri is killed after the Nazis discover he is a resistance figure.

Levy – Levy is a French resistance fighter. He was a regular patron of Julien Rossignol's bookstore before the war and immediately recognizes Isabelle when she joins the resistance.

Micheline Babineau – Micheline Babineau is an old friend of Julien Rossignol. She helps Isabelle smuggle fighter pilots into Spain.

Eduardo – Eduardo lives on the border between France and Spain. He helps Isabelle take fighter pilots across the Pyrenees.

Von Richter – Von Richter is a barbaric Nazi who moves into Vianne's home after Captain Beck's death. He repeatedly rapes Vianne and eventually impregnates her with Julien Mauriac.

Mother Superior – Mother Superior is the head of Vianne's church. She helps Vianne hide Jewish children from the Nazis.

Marc de Champlain – Marc de Champlain is the husband of Rachel de Champlain and the father of Ari and Sarah de Champlain. He is captured during the war and dies in a Nazi labor camp.

Madame Allard – Madame Allard is the headmistress at Isabelle's school. She expels Isabelle because of her poor behavior.

Christophe – Christophe is a young man in Paris whom Isabelle is friends with. He tells her that women belong at home while men are off fighting in wars.

Anouk – Anouk is a French resistance fighter. She is the first member of the resistance whom Isabelle meets in Paris.

MacLeish – MacLeish is the first fighter pilot Isabelle rescues.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



MORALITY AND IMPOSSIBLE CHOICES

The Nightingale takes place during World War II, when the horrific circumstances of war caused many people to betray their moral sensibilities.

Vianne Mauriac, one of the two novel's two protagonists, is a mother who must constantly sacrifice her sense of what is right in order to protect her daughter, Sophie, and her husband, Antoine. Toward the beginning of the novel, after German soldiers take control of her town, Vianne is forced to allow a Nazi, Beck, to stay in her home, knowing that to resist would put her life or Sophie's life in danger. One day, Beck asks Vianne to make a list of all of the Jewish people who work at her school. Vianne doesn't want to do what Beck says, but he promises her that he will send a care package to Antoine, who is trapped in a POW camp. Ultimately, Vianne complies with Beck's demands to protect her family, even though she knows the Nazis will likely use the list for sinister purposes.

Later in the novel, Vianne's choices become even more complicated as she witnesses the horrors of the Nazi regime firsthand and realizes what they are capable of. One day, she finds her sister Isabelle hiding a British pilot on her property. Vianne knows that if Beck finds the pilot, then she will be killed along with Sophie and Isabelle. Unfortunately for Vianne, Beck is specifically charged with searching for the pilot. When he later realizes that Vianne is hiding something, he searches the premises for the pilot. Beck is nearly successful; the only thing that stops him from finding the pilot is Vianne smashing the back of his head with a shovel and killing him. In a split second, Vianne must make the impossible choice to kill Beck to prevent him from discovering the pilot and to protect herself and her family. Further complicating Vianne's choice is the fact that she actually liked Beck and thought he was a good man, despite his position in the Nazi party. Throughout the novel, Vianne's need to protect herself and her family pushes her to act in ways that harm others. In highlighting the impossible choices Vianne's circumstances repeatedly force her to make, *The Nightingale* suggests that war often forces people to compromise their personal morals in order to protect themselves and their loved ones.



ANTISEMITISM AND ACTIVE RESISTANCE

The Nightingale is a novel set during World War II. A

central feature of World War II was the Holocaust, a genocide that the Nazi regime carried out against Jewish people. In order to justify their actions, Hitler's Nazi party spread antisemitism to demonize the millions of Jewish people whom they ruthlessly slaughtered. At the start of the novel, characters like Vianne are unwilling to acknowledge the problem that is growing all around them. Vianne sees antisemitic posters around town and even writes down a list of Jewish people who teach at her school for Beck, a German soldier. At this point, there are not overt signs of hostility directed toward Jewish people, so Vianne does not think it necessary to resist.

However, as conditions worsen, Jewish people, including Vianne's best friend Rachel, are the first ones to experience direct persecution. Toward the end of the novel, the Nazis gather all of the Jewish people throughout France and send them to labor camps in Germany. It is only after Vianne witnesses a Nazi shoot Sarah, Rachel's daughter, and watches Rachel herself get sent away on a train that she realizes the cost of her refusal to act. Now aware of the indescribable evils of which the Nazis are capable, Vianne makes it her mission to save as many Jewish children as possible from Nazi persecution. Although she puts her life and Sophie's life in danger, Vianne manages to save 19 Jewish children. Even though most people would consider her a war hero, the past haunts Vianne; she feels she could have done more to stand up to the Nazis like Isabelle did. Here, the novel becomes a parable about the virtues of resistance in the face of pure evil. Although remaining inactive to protect oneself and one's family is understandable, Vianne's lingering guilt suggests that only active resistance can provide a clear conscience.



GENDER ROLES

The Nightingale focuses on the role women played in the resistance effort during World War II. One of the novel's protagonists, Isabelle, is a young woman

who is frustrated with the role society has given to her because of her gender. She is constantly told to act like a lady, but she has no interest in doing so. When the war begins, she immediately wants to run off and fight with the men. Her hero is Edith Cavell, a female war hero from World War I. Knowing that she will never fight on the front lines, however, Isabelle finds other ways to fight back. Eventually, she becomes involved with a resistance group that is attempting to return downed British fighter pilots to England. Over the course of war, Isabelle saves the lives of dozens of pilots by carrying out escort missions. Much of her success comes from the fact that she is a woman. Her appearance makes her inconspicuous to the Nazi soldiers and allows her to carry out missions right under their noses without ever being caught.

In sharp opposition to Isabelle is her sister, Vianne. Before the war, Vianne occupied the traditional feminine role of taking

care of her child, Sophie, and her home. For the most part, this role does not change when the war begins. Vianne still spends most of her time cooking, gardening, and taking care of Sophie. After the war begins and the Nazis seize control of Vianne's town, however, her role becomes more complicated. Because she doesn't want her best friend Rachel's son, Ari, to be sent to a death camp (Rachel and her family are Jewish), she adopts him and pretends to be his mother. Shortly afterward, Vianne begins helping a number of Jewish children to escape persecution by joining forces with the church. Throughout the war, Vianne retains her traditionally feminine sensibilities and acts as a mother to many children who desperately need one, yet at the same time, the bravery she exhibits as she risks her life to rescue Jewish children challenges sexist assumptions that women ought not to participate in the war effort. Vianne and Isabelle manage to undermine the Nazis not in spite of their gender but because of it. In its positive portrayal of femininity, the novel challenges traditional gender roles and flawed assumptions about women's capacity to assist in war efforts.



LOVE AND WAR

Love and war are a timeless pairing, precisely because of the complexity that one engenders in the other. In *The Nightingale*, both main characters are in love. Isabelle loves her fellow resistance fighter, Gaëtan, and Vianne loves her husband, Antoine. However, the war complicates both romances. For the majority of the novel, Antoine is in a prisoner-of-war camp, meaning that Vianne can only love him from afar. Nonetheless, Vianne loves Antoine and spends much of her free time thinking of him. The fact that he is alive provides Vianne with hope; no matter what the Nazis do, she can look forward to Antoine coming home one day. Meanwhile, Isabelle is in near constant contact with Gaëtan. The two of them regularly partake in romantic rendezvous and spend each night together like it is their last. Because Isabelle and Gaëtan are both resistance fighters, they know that their lives could end at any moment. Yet in the moments they are together, the war is temporarily put on pause, and they effectively use each other and their romance to escape the horrors that war has brought to their everyday lives. Although love is far from a remedy for war in *The Nightingale*, the novel shows how love can inspire hope and alleviate suffering during war and in other times of hardship.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



THE NIGHTINGALE

"The Nightingale" is Isabelle Rossignol's code name, which symbolizes her fundamental spiritual purity.

Nightingales have a long literary history dating back to ancient Greece, and it also appears in the works of romantic poets such as Samuel Taylor Coleridge and William Wordsworth. In romantic poetry, the nightingale often represents the righteousness of nature. However, it also has some darker connotations, such as in John Keats's famous poem "Ode to a Nightingale." In Keats's poem, the nightingale is still connected to the natural world, but it is also associated with death. This dual meaning carries over into Hannah's novel. Isabelle is a source of fundamental good in the world, but she is also a tragic figure. For the majority of the novel, she is a fierce member of the resistance responsible for saving hundreds of lives. She carries out many escort missions at night, which partly explains the name "Nightingale." However, the name's more profound and tragic symbolism only becomes clear in the novel's final chapter, when Isabelle dies shortly after returning home from a concentration camp.



SCRAPS OF CLOTHING

In *The Nightingale*, scraps of clothing represent the uncertainty of fate. Throughout the novel, Vianne ties scraps of clothing to a tree in her yard. Each of these scraps belongs to a loved one whose fate she does not know. These scraps are subject to the forces of nature; they blow in the wind, freeze in the cold, and get drenched by the rain. Similarly, the individuals who wore the scraps are subject to the whims of fate. For characters like Antoine and Rachel, who are in concentration camps, survival is mere luck. Like the scraps of clothing, they have no control over their future—instead, they are subjected to the elements and whatever else the Nazis decide is appropriate. In the end, some of the owners of the clothing, like Antoine, come home; others, like Rachel, do not.



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the St. Martin's Griffin edition of *The Nightingale* published in 2017.

Chapter 1 Quotes

☞ If I have learned anything in this long life of mine, it is this: In love we find out who we want to be; in war we find out who we are.

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator) (speaker), Isabelle Rossignol, Gaëtan, Julien Mauriac, Ari de

Champlain

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 1

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from the beginning of the novel. In 1995, the novel's present, the unnamed narrator (Vianne Mauriac) juxtaposes love with war. To Vianne, love is an idealistic notion, while war reveals harsh truths. As such, Vianne seems to suggest, love and war are at odds with each other and thus cannot coexist harmoniously. The novel explores this theme throughout its epic story, examining the problems love creates in times of war. Vianne's sister Isabelle, for instance, falls in love with fellow resistance fighter Gaëtan, but the highly dangerous nature of their missions dooms their relationship from the start. Though Gaëtan has feelings for Isabelle, he initially refuses to start a relationship with her, knowing the heartache they'd each feel if the other were to die.

On the other hand, love also gives people something to fight for. Although Vianne's initial formulation is somewhat cynical, she will change her mind by the novel's end and create a positive spin on these opening lines. Her transformation occurs after attending a reunion for *passeurs* in Paris, where she reunites with Ari and Gaëtan. After speaking with them and reflecting on her relationship with her son, Julien, Vianne decides that love transcends war because while war ultimately ends, love can last forever.

💬 If I had told him the truth long ago, or had danced and drunk and sung more, maybe he would have seen me instead of a dependable ordinary mother. He loves a version of me that is incomplete. I always thought it was what I wanted: to be loved and admired. Now I think perhaps I'd like to be known.

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator) (speaker), Julien Rossignol, Julien Mauriac

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 5

Explanation and Analysis

In 1995, an unnamed narrator (Vianne) reflects on her life after World War II. In particular, she is concerned about her relationship with her son, Julien. Vianne never told Julien anything about her war experience, which fundamentally shaped who she is as a person. In this quotation, Vianne lays

out her dilemma, and it seems that most of her life has involved sacrificing her happiness (her desire "to be known," or for others to see her as she truly is) so that her son could live a "ordinary" life. From her examples (dancing, drinking, and singing), it seems like Vianne never relaxed in front of Julien in fear that he would see her flaws.

It makes sense that Vianne would be afraid of such activities because she does not want to repeat her father's (Julien Rossignol's) behavior. Following World War I, Vianne's father regularly drank to cope with the horrors he experienced during the war, and this caused him to neglect his daughters. However, in her old age, Vianne realizes her restraint might be a mistake, as she acknowledges that Julien's "ordinary" upbringing came at the price of her happiness. In a way, she, like her father before her, suppressed her past and so created distance between herself and her child.

Vianne's decision to conceal the truth is consistent with one of the novel's central themes: the difficult decisions that war faces a person to make. Vianne's position is unenviable; on the one hand, if she reveals the truth about her past to Julien, she risks fundamentally altering her relationship with her only living child, possibly for the worse. On the other hand, if she continues to hide the past from her child, she risks living out her life profoundly alone and mentally isolated from someone she loves.

Chapter 2 Quotes

💬 "But ... but ... you're a postman."

He held her gaze and suddenly she couldn't breathe. "I am a soldier now, it seems."

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator), Antoine Mauriac (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 14

Explanation and Analysis

This conversation takes place between Vianne and her husband, Antoine. In this scene, Antoine reveals that the French government drafted him and that he'll soon leave to fight in World War II. Although Vianne feared this news was coming, it is still a shock to her. The repeated ellipses after "but" suggest that she can barely speak, perhaps because she doesn't know what to say. As her response indicates, Antoine is merely a postman; he has no business fighting on the frontlines of a war. Nonetheless, that is exactly what he

must do. During World War I and World War II, most people did not have a choice; they had to enroll in the military or suffer severe consequences. In World War II alone, France suffered over 200,000 military deaths, despite fighting for less than a year.

Antoine and Vianne's relationship demonstrates the dangers of love during wartime. Although love makes people strong and gives them something to fight for, it also causes an immense deal of pain. In this quote, Antoine's news literally takes Vianne's breath away; it is as though the mere thought of his immanent departure shocks her life force from her body.

Chapter 4 Quotes

☞ “Ah. Consequences,” Madame said. “Perhaps now you will see that they should be considered.”

Related Characters: Madame Allard (speaker), Isabelle Rossignol

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 31

Explanation and Analysis

Madame Allard has just informed Isabelle that she's expelling her from her etiquette school and sending her back home to Paris. Isabelle doesn't want to return to Paris because she doesn't know if her father will take her in. Here, Madame Allard explains to Isabelle that she should have thought about that before she talked back to teachers—that her actions have consequences. Madame Allard's advice sheds light on Isabelle's character at the novel's start; she does not think before she acts. And once the war begins, her carelessness will lead to far more serious consequences.

Although Isabelle's actions are immature, they are not altogether unreasonable. The people Isabelle rebels against the most—such as Madame Allard—are authority figures who try to make Isabelle comply with social standards she feels are unjust or inhumane. For instance, teachers chastise her because she does not act ladylike. Meanwhile, Vianne and Beck criticize Isabelle because she rebels against the Nazi party's rules and regulations. As time passes and Isabelle grows more mature, she learns to strike a balance between doing what's right and avoiding taking needless risks that could place herself and her loved ones in danger.

☞ “I'm just tired of the war talk. And it's a fact that women are useless in war. Your job is to wait for our return.”

Related Characters: Christophe (speaker), Isabelle Rossignol

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 34

Explanation and Analysis

This quote appears in a conversation between Isabelle and her male friend, Christophe. Christophe interrupts Isabelle to make this statement while she is reading a book about Edith Cavell, a British nurse and female war hero from World War I. Christophe's statement irritates Isabelle because it is untrue and dismissive. Isabelle has proof directly in front of her face; she is reading about a female war hero who did not stay at home and leave everything else to the men. In fact, Edith Cavell was responsible for saving hundreds of lives, and her enemies executed her as a result.

Edith Cavell is Isabelle's hero, and she spends the rest of the novel rebelling against the traditional ideals that Christophe espouses in this quote. Not only do Isabelle's later activities with the resistance prove that women can fight in wars, but her success also demonstrates that her gender is actually an asset to the resistance effort, allowing her to sneak by undetected. In an ironic twist, then, Christophe's dismissive stance toward women ends up working in Isabelle's favor: her identity as the Nightingale goes undetected because nobody believes a woman could possibly carry out the Nightingale's dangerous missions.

Chapter 6 Quotes

☞ “Something like that. But like I said, a nice girl like you wouldn't know anything about survival.”

“You'd be surprised the things I know, Gaëtan, There is more than one kind of prison.”

Related Characters: Isabelle Rossignol, Gaëtan (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 54

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from one of the first conversations

between Isabelle and Gaëtan as they travel to Carriveau. Isabelle is eager to head off to war, but Gaëtan is unsure she is ready. Gaëtan has spent time in prison and knows something of the world's dangers. He takes Isabelle for granted and assumes she is a "nice girl" who does not know about traditionally masculine spaces of war and rebellion.

In response, Isabelle is determined to show Gaëtan that she is just as experienced as him, even though their experiences differ because of their respective genders. Gaëtan has been confined in a literal penitentiary, while the "prison" Isabelle references is patriarchy. Isabelle's response conveys her sense that she's subject to gender norms that elevate and free men but entrap women and does not let them stray beyond their traditional roles. Gaëtan can do whatever he wants within the bounds of the law without facing social repercussions. Meanwhile, Isabelle must attend etiquette school and sit out the war. Although rebellion is not impossible for Isabelle—indeed, she spends much of the novel rebelling—it carries a social cost that Gaëtan does not understand.

Chapter 7 Quotes

☹☹ The smell preceded them. Human sweat and filth and body odor. As they neared, the miasma of black separated, peeled into forms. She saw people on the road and in the fields, walking, limping, coming toward her. Some were pushing bicycles or prams or dragging wagons. Dogs barked, babies cried. There was coughing, throat clearing, whining. They came forward, through the field and up the road, relentlessly moving close, pushing one another aside, their voices rising.

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator), Isabelle Rossignol, Rachel de Champlain, Antoine Mauriac

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 68-69

Explanation and Analysis

Not long after Antoine leaves to fight in the war, Vianne and Rachel are walking home from work when they see a crowd of refugees approach Carriveau. Most of the refugees come from Paris—and though Vianne doesn't know it, Isabelle is somewhere among them. Historically (and in the novel), many people evacuated Paris right before Germans occupied the city on June 14, 1940. As such, the roads out of Paris quickly flooded with people making it difficult to drive, bike, or even walk along the roads.

The sight of the crowd is Vianne's first taste of what is to

come as the war escalates. Indeed, it is a sickening sight. The people move as though they are all one black mass of sadness and despair. No one is clean, and everyone is hungry and scared. Largely, the crowd looks so haggard because the Nazis bombed them on their way out of Paris. The descriptive language the book uses in this passage paints a vivid picture of war's capacity to wound and damage people. Though it's clear that the people in the crowd are suffering, Vianne has no idea what is going on, and so the sight of the crowd seems to instill in her more fear than sympathy. Indeed, her perception that the crowd is "coming toward her" portrays the suffering, wretched mass as a threat to her safety rather than people who need her help.

Chapter 8 Quotes

☹☹ She had no idea how to respond to this stranger who dressed like the enemy and looked like a young man she might have met at church. And what was the price for saying the wrong thing?

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator), Captain Beck, Antoine Mauriac

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 104

Explanation and Analysis

Vianne observes Captain Beck, the Nazi officer assigned to stay in Vianne's home, when he first enters her house. What strikes Vianne most about Beck is how ordinary he seems. Beck is one of the most ambiguous characters in the novel because he is the most ambiguous. On the one hand, he is a Nazi who regularly carries out the sadistic and antisemitic orders his higher-ups give him. However, on the other hand, he is a kind family man who just wants to get home to his wife and child; in this regard, he's not all that different from Vianne's own husband, Antoine. Beck's appearance contradicts his demeanor: though he's "dressed like the enemy," his manners directly contradict everything Vianne knows and has heard about the Nazi party.

One of Vianne's central conflicts throughout the first half of the novel is figuring out if she can trust Beck. This conflict ties into one of the novel's primary questions: the difficult decisions that war forces people to make. Here, Vianne anguishes over whether she can trust someone who seems kind but who ultimately remains her enemy. And making the wrong decision about Beck could lead to serious consequences. Vianne knows that trusting Beck when she

shouldn't could result in her death—"the price of saying the wrong thing."

Chapter 9 Quotes

☹☹ Vianne had been so helpless after Maman's death. When Papa had sent them away, to live in this small town, beneath the cold, stern eyes of a woman who had shown the girls no love, Vianne had . . . wilted.

In another time, she might have shared with Isabelle what they had in common, how undone she'd been by Maman's death, how Papa's rejection had broken her heart.

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator), Isabelle Rossignol, Julien Rossignol

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 110

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes just after Vianne and Isabelle fight over Isabelle's treatment of Beck. Vianne wishes she had more authority over her sister and realizes that she has none now because she was not there for Isabelle when Isabelle was a child. Here, Vianne describes her younger self as fragile; the word "wilted" suggests that she was delicate like a flower and unable to maintain herself, let alone someone else. Vianne knows that war—in conjunction with her mother's death—is responsible for making her childhood so loveless and lonely and for making her become so "wilted." And now that war is here again, she does not know what to do about her broken relationship with her sister. Vianne does not want to act like the "cold, stern" woman who cared for her when her and Isabelle's father could not, but at the same time, she does not think that the onset of a new war is the right time to revisit the past with Isabelle, as the new challenges that war brings must take precedence over one's inner personal battles, and so she chooses to set her emotions aside and postpone making amends with Isabelle.

Chapter 10 Quotes

☹☹ "There are some things a man does around the house. You are much too fragile to chop wood."

"I can do it."

"Of course you can, but why should you? Go Madame. See to your daughter. I can do this small thing for you. Otherwise my mother will beat me with a switch."

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator), Captain Beck (speaker), Antoine Mauriac

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 123

Explanation and Analysis

This quotation is a conversation between Beck and Vianne. Beck spots Vianne chopping wood outside and insists that he take over because it is a man's job. Vianne hesitates but ultimately does as Beck asks. Beck is genuinely trying to be helpful, but Vianne does not trust him. She does not want to owe him anything, and she feels uncomfortable with the idea of Beck doing the chores "a man does around the house," symbolically filling Antoine's role. Vianne's discomfort with this relationship is why she pushes back and tries to do the work herself despite Beck's offer to help.

But Beck's insistence is a reminder that the division of labor depicted in the novel was a standard both men and women upheld. After all, Beck says that his mother, not his father, would discipline him for failing to perform his manly duties. However, not everything Beck says here is accurate; Vianne is not "much too fragile" to perform the task. If she had to, she could chop the wood, just as she does when Beck is not around. However, for both Beck and Vianne, there is comfort in conforming to traditional gender roles, even (or perhaps especially) under such odd and extreme circumstances.

Finally, this passage also further complicates Vianne's sense of Beck's character. Though he is her enemy, here he acts in a conventionally gentlemanly manner and goes out of his way to help Vianne, even though he doesn't have to.

Chapter 11 Quotes

☹☹ She was certain suddenly that she shouldn't have done this. But what choice did she have? He was in control of her home. What would happen if she defied him? Slowly, feeling sick to her stomach, she wrote the last name on the list.

Rachel de Champlain.

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator), Rachel de Champlain, Captain Beck, Antoine Mauriac

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 152

Explanation and Analysis

Beck has just asked Vianne to create a list of all the Jewish people who work at her school. Vianne does as Beck asks because he promises to send a care package to Antoine, whom the Nazis are holding in a prisoner-of-war camp. Writing the list is the first tough decision Vianne makes in the novel. On the one hand, the information she gives Beck is readily available in many other places. However, on the other hand, physically writing the list of names, especially Rachel's name—Rachel is Vianne's best friend—feels like a betrayal.

This quote exposes the power dynamic in Beck and Vianne's relationship. Although Beck is often kind and helpful, and Vianne usually enjoys his company, they are not equals. Beck has implicit and explicit "control" over Vianne, and although he is cordial when he asks Vianne to write the list, they both know he does not have to be—and that he might not remain so cordial if Vianne refuses his request. Beck never resorts to the barbarism of his compatriots, but the threat that he might always is in the air. This implicit threat informs Vianne's difficult decision to write the list, which includes Rachel's name.

Chapter 12 Quotes

💬 "Don't think about who they are. Think about who *you* are and what sacrifices you can live with and what will break you [. . .] Isabelle will have her crisis of faith in this, too. As will we all. I have been here before, in the Great War. I know the hardships are just beginning. You must stay strong."

Related Characters: Mother Superior (speaker), Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator), Isabelle Rossignol, Julien Rossignol, Rachel de Champlain

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 165

Explanation and Analysis

Vianne visits Mother Superior, her local church leader, to express her guilt about following Beck's order to write a list of the Jewish residents of Carriveau. She feels terrible because the Nazis fired Rachel and the other Jewish people at Vianne's school after Vianne made the list, and Vianne feels responsible. Vianne's "crisis of faith" stems from the fact that Beck forced her to make an impossible decision that compromised her morality. In following Beck's order and writing the list, she betrayed her best friend and the

town's other Jewish residents. But refusing Beck's order could have put herself and her family in harm's way if Beck chose to retaliate against her. In this quote, however, Mother Superior assuages Vianne's guilt, suggesting that Vianne shouldn't see her betrayal of Rachel as a moral failing—in fact, war puts everyone in situations where they must compromise their personal morals and do things they're not proud of in order to survive.

This quote also foreshadows the "crisis of fate" that Isabelle later experiences after the Nazis capture and torture her to try to extract information about the Nightingale (Isabelle's codename, though the Nazis don't know this) from her. When Isabelle refuses to give away information that could compromise the resistance, her father Julien steps in, claiming that he's the Nightingale in order to save his daughter. Isabelle's "crisis of fate" occurs, then, when her choice to protect the resistance results in her father's execution.

Chapter 14 Quotes

💬 How can I possibly go without remembering all of it—the terrible things I have done, the secret I kept, the man I killed . . . and the one I should have?

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator) (speaker), Captain Beck, Julien Mauriac, Von Richter

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 192

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is from Chapter Fourteen, one of the few chapters that takes place in 1995. Vianne's mention of "the terrible things" she did during the war alludes to Beck's death and Von Richter's abuse, though readers have yet to learn about these events. However, on a first read, Vianne's words are cryptic for a number of reasons. First, at this point, readers don't yet know that Vianne is the unnamed narrator. Additionally, readers don't yet know about Beck's death or Vianne's role in it; though the death happened during the war, readers don't learn of it until Chapter Twenty-Five. The "secret" Vianne mentions is that Von Richter, the Nazi who stayed in her house after Beck's death, is the father of her son, Julien (Von Richter repeatedly raped Vianne when he lived with her), though readers won't learn this until much later.

Vianne's choice to refer to these past events in vague terms creates tension, making readers even more interesting in

who the unnamed narrator is and what “terrible things” she did during the war. Meanwhile, her inability to think about the past in detail suggests her struggle to come to terms with the war and all the impossible choices it forced her to make.

Chapter 16 Quotes

💬 “You are a foolish girl. Thank God your maman did not live to see who you have become.”

Isabelle hated how deeply that hurt her. “Or you Papa,” she said. “Or you.”

Related Characters: Isabelle Rossignol, Julien Rossignol (speaker)

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 226

Explanation and Analysis

This quote occurs at the end of a conversation between Julien and Isabelle, where Isabelle tells Julien she wants to reopen his bookstore. At the end of the conversation, Isabelle makes a crude sexual jab at her father’s expense, which results in this exchange. Here, the novel lays bare the core of Julien and Isabelle’s fractured relationship; they despise each other because neither is over the death of Isabelle’s mother.

Julien’s words sting Isabelle because he knows how dear Isabelle’s mother was to both of them. Meanwhile, Isabelle’s jab hurts Julien because Julien believes he has remained loyal to the memory of Isabelle’s mother and is insulted that Isabelle would suggest otherwise. However, although Julien and Isabelle’s remarks come from pain, they also come from love. The fact that Isabelle hates how much the comment hurts her demonstrates that she still cares about what her father thinks. Likewise, Julien would not have made the comment in the first place if Isabelle—someone he loves—had not hurt him first.

Finally, Isabelle’s suggestion that Maman wouldn’t be proud of the person Julien has become underscores the lasting effect Julien’s experience in the war has had on him. It’s also a comment on Julien’s decision to sell books to German officers—Isabelle is implying that Maman would disapprove of Julien cooperating with the enemy. (Of course, Isabelle later learns that this is just a front: in fact, Julien is a member of the resistance and actively working to undermine the Nazis.)

Chapter 20 Quotes

💬 She felt conspicuous in her ragged, snagged brown pants and woolen coat. Her cheeks were windburned and scratched and her lips were chapped and dry. But the real changes were within. The pride of what she’d accomplished in the Pyrenees had changed her, matured her. For the first time in her life, she knew exactly what she wanted to do.

Related Characters: Isabelle Rossignol

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 285-286

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes after Isabelle’s first escort mission where she successfully leads three RAF pilots safely into Spain via the Pyrenees. After the pilots reach safety, Isabelle takes a train home to France and thinks about her accomplishment. This quote emphasizes Isabelle’s haggard appearance. Up to this point in the novel, everyone—especially men—focuses on Isabelle’s good looks. However, Isabelle places little value on her beauty. In fact, in this passage, she likes her “ragged” appearance and considers it an outward sign of her resistance efforts, which she cannot openly take pride in because the Germans would arrest her if they knew about her work with the resistance. Part of Isabelle’s happiness comes from the fact that she has defied social norms. Isabelle’s friends and family have repeatedly told her that she cannot join the rebellion because she’s a woman, yet she does precisely that and becomes incredibly successful.

Chapter 23 Quotes

💬 *I don't know the right thing to do anymore. I want to protect Sophie and keep her safe, but what good is safety if she has to grow up in a world where people disappear without a trace because they pray to a different God?*

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator) (speaker), Sophie Mauriac, Sarah de Champlain

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 339-340

Explanation and Analysis

This quote is a thought Vianne has shortly after Sarah de Champlain’s death. Vianne tries to figure out how she will tell her young daughter, Sophie, about the tragedy without frightening the child. As is the case throughout the novel,

Vianne wants to do “the right thing,” but her circumstances do not allow her to determine the right thing with any sense of certainty. Vianne wants to be honest with Sophie about Sarah’s death, but fears that doing so will cause Sophie to ask questions for which Vianne has no answer; Vianne herself cannot make sense of the horrors of war logically or philosophically, and so she fears that telling Sophie about Sarah’s death—but not being able to explain why it happened—would only make Sophie more confused and scared.

This moment is a turning point in the novel for Vianne’s character. Until now, she passively watched as the Nazis committed atrocity after atrocity, seemingly believing that she can shield herself and her family from the horrors of war if she just pretends they don’t. However, now she begins to think that inaction could be just as bad for her and her family as stepping out of line—after all, denying the reality of the horrors going on around her doesn’t make them any less real.

Chapter 24 Quotes

☞ “Ari,” she said quietly, taking his face in her hands. “Your maman is with the angels in Heaven. She won’t be coming back.”

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator) (speaker), Rachel de Champlain, Ari de Champlain, Marc de Champlain

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 362

Explanation and Analysis

Vianne takes in Rachel’s son Ari after the Nazis send Rachel to a concentration camp. Here, Vianne tells Ari that Rachel is dead because she wants him to accept his new identity fully (so that he doesn’t reveal the truth about his Jewish roots, which would put him in danger). This moment demonstrates how the war forces Vianne to do something bad in the moment to protect herself and her loved ones in the long run.

Here, Vianne knowingly inflicts psychological pain on Ari by telling him that his mother is dead—something she knows (or at least hopes) is a lie. Vianne inflicts this pain because she thinks it is the best way to ensure Ari’s safety. (If Ari were to know the truth and tell the wrong person that his mother was sent to a concentration camp, it could make them suspicious and put Ari, Vianne, and Vianne’s family in grave danger.) However, the difficulty lies in the fact that

nothing is guaranteed. Vianne could have just emotionally scarred Ari for no reason—the Nazis may learn the truth about Ari no matter what Vianne does to protect him. Vianne does not know; she can only use her judgment and pray for the best. This quote is especially tragic because it is true—or, at least, it becomes true not long after Vianne utters it, as Rachel and Marc, Ari’s parents, ultimately die in concentration camps.

Chapter 25 Quotes

☞ “Forgive my manners, Madame. But we have shown you all our best behaviors, and this is what we get from many of you French. Lies and betrayal and sabotage.”

Related Characters: Captain Beck (speaker), Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator), Rachel de Champlain, Sophie Mauriac, Ari de Champlain

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 370

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from a conversation between Vianne and Captain Beck after the RAF Pilot goes missing under Beck’s command. Beck is frustrated because he cannot find the pilot, whose disappearance he attributes to the French people’s “betrayal and sabotage.” This quote is important for Beck’s character because it reveals how differently he and Vianne see the world. Although Beck may be courteous, his compatriots surely are not, and it is laughable to suggest otherwise. The Nazis stole food and supplies from the French, murdered those who rebelled and persecuted every Jewish person in the country.

Perhaps Beck’s assertion is said in anger and not something he truly believes. Regardless, the fact that such a statement could leave his mouth shows that he and Vianne live in entirely separate plains of existence. For the majority of the novel, Beck acts like a good person. He helps Vianne and Sophie, tries to save Rachel, and even acquires forged papers for Ari. But even if Beck has treated Vianne kindly and takes issue with some of his compatriots’ more barbarous behavior, this quote shows that his allegiance to Germany takes precedence over all else.

Chapter 28 Quotes

☝☝ She was wiser than she'd been before. Now she knew how fragile life and love were. Maybe she would love him for only this day, or maybe for only the next week or maybe until she was an old, old woman. Maybe he would be the love of her life . . . or her love for the duration of this war . . . or maybe he would only be her first love. All she really knew was that in this terrible, frightening world, she had stumbled into something unexpected.

Related Characters: Isabelle Rossignol, Gaëtan

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 404

Explanation and Analysis

Isabelle considers her growing feelings for Gaëtan. As he nurses her back to health, they begin to fall in love. For much of the novel, Gaëtan and Isabelle resist the urge to fall for each other. Other characters repeatedly warn them that love is dangerous because of the hurt one feels after they lose their love. However, although love may be dangerous, in this passage, Isabelle suggests that it can also be a good thing, providing excitement and giving lovers an appreciation for the fragility of life.

This quotation marks a distinct change from the Isabelle seen at the beginning of the story. When Isabelle first meets Gaëtan, she immediately falls in love with him. At that point, her ideas about love are idealistic, and she cannot help but pretend she is like a character in a romantic novel. However, by this point in the story, Isabelle has lost some of her idealism. Here, she does not treat love as a transcendent force that will always triumph over war. Instead, she thinks of love as potentially transient and fallible and finds it meaningful precisely *because* it is not an omnipotent force. This passage shows how the war has merely transformed Isabelle's appreciation for love, not taken that appreciation away.

Chapter 33 Quotes

☝☝ It was all Vianne could do not to say, *I'm different now, Papa. I am helping to hide Jewish children*. She wanted to see herself reflected in his gaze, wanted just once to make him proud of her.

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator), Julien Rossignol

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 471

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from Julien and Vianne's only conversation in the novel. At this point in the story, Vianne feels that she has finally done something worthy of praise by saving the lives of many young Jewish children, smuggling them away to orphanages where they'll hopefully be safe for the remainder of the war. However, she knows that bragging about her accomplishments to Julien would be selfish, as telling Julien about her actions would make him complicit in them and so put his life in danger. As such, she ultimately denies herself the satisfaction of her father's approval, thereby sacrificing her emotional needs to ensure Julien's safety.

Vianne's restraint is a mark of maturation for a character who was an eager people-pleaser at the beginning of the novel. Here, Vianne is emotionally mature enough to recognize that the significance of her actions is much more important than her desire for Julien's approval.

☝☝ Vianne heard the confession that lay beneath. He was telling her his own story in the only way he could, cloaked in Isabelle's. He was saying that he had worried about his choice to join the army in the Great War, that he had agonized over what his fighting had done to his family. He knew how changed he'd been on his return, and instead of pain drawing him closer to his children and wife, it had separated them.

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator), Isabelle Rossignol, Julien Rossignol

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 472

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from a conversation between Vianne and Julien Rossignol the day before Julien turns himself in to save Isabelle's life. Julien uses the conversation to say goodbye to Vianne and ensure she will care for Isabelle, explaining that Isabelle's wartime activities will have traumatized her and that she'll need Vianne's help to heal. Though he doesn't say it, it's clear to Vianne that Julien is speaking from experience.

The conversation is a significant moment for both Vianne and Julien's characters. For the first time, Julien finds a way

to talk about how his service during World War I affected him by channeling his experiences through Isabelle. Julien cannot be entirely forthcoming because it's still too painful for him to confront the past directly, and so he makes a compromise, vulnerably opening up to Vianne about his past "the only way he [can], cloaked in Isabelle's ". Despite the indirect nature of the "confession," Vianne knows what Julien is talking about, and she feels close to her father for the first time in a long time. However, now, what is most important to both Vianne and Julien is that the cycle of pain and trauma does not repeat itself. They do not want Isabelle to return home from war and estrange herself from her loved ones, as Julien did so many years ago.

Chapter 37 Quotes

☞☞ "One boy with no memory of who he has may seem a small thing to lose, but to us, he is the future. We cannot let you raise him in a religion that is not yours and take him to synagogue when you remember. Ari needs to be who he is, and to be with his people. Surely his mother would want that."

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator), Rachel de Champlain, Ari de Champlain

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 533

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from an unnamed man who comes to speak with Vianne after World War II has ended. The man is a member of a Jewish group that is attempting to piece together Jewish families separated by the war. His mission is to reunite families and to ensure the survival of Jewish cultural and religious practices following the Holocaust. Here, the man emphasizes the cultural aspects of Judaism that he knows Vianne will be unable to provide for Ari. Although Vianne wants to be Ari's mother, the man suggests that she cannot fill this role without simultaneously stripping him of his heritage.

However, the idea of losing Ari is extremely painful to Vianne. He is the one positive that came out of her wartime experience, and now she risks losing him. This passage illustrates yet another difficult choice the war causing Vianne to make, forcing her to endure more loss and heartbreak for the sake of Ari's wellbeing and to preserve his ties to his Jewish roots. Ultimately, Vianne makes the selfless choice to let Ari go, hoping that her major sacrifice will ultimately benefit Ari and the broader Jewish community.

Chapter 38 Quotes

☞☞ *Don't forget me*, Isabelle thought. She wished she had the strength to say it out loud.

Related Characters: Isabelle Rossignol (speaker), Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator), Gaëtan, Julien Rossignol

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 551

Explanation and Analysis

This passage takes place during the novel's 1940s timeline, just after the war's end. Isabelle is in Gaëtan's arms and surrounded by her family. She knows that she will die soon. For much of her life, Isabelle has felt unloved. Her mother died while she was young, her father wanted nothing to do with her, and Vianne was too busy dealing with her own trauma to handle Isabelle's as well. However, during the war, Isabelle discovers love in all the places she always wanted it, as well as in a place she did not expect (Gaëtan). Isabelle fought the war with love in her heart, but now that the war is over and she is dying, she worries that it will all disappear. However, the novel's title and the meeting of *passeurs* in the novel's present (1995) that concludes the novel confirms that Isabelle has nothing to worry about. The book is a testament to the real-life women who inspired Isabelle to join the resistance despite people's insistence that being a woman meant she could participate in the war. Isabelle's final plea not to be forgotten implicitly urges readers to remember the real-life women who inspired Isabelle.

Chapter 39 Quotes

☞☞ "Did Dad know?" Julien asks.

"Your father . . ." I pause, draw in a breath. *Your father*. And there it is, the secret that made me bury it all.

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator) (speaker), Julien Rossignol, Julien Mauriac, Antoine Mauriac, Von Richter

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 563

Explanation and Analysis

This quote comes from a conversation between Vianne and Julien Mauriac at the French reunion for *passeurs*. As it turns out, Julien is not Antoine's biological child; in fact, Von

Richter Julien's father (Von Richter repeatedly raped Vianne while he was staying at her house). However, Vianne never tells Antoine, nor does she tell Julien, because the secret is too terrible and painful for Vianne to reveal. As such, dramatic irony is present when Julien asks about his father; although the reader knows the truth about his parentage, Julien does not. For a moment, Vianne considers telling Julien the truth, though her hesitancy suggests that she's conflicted about it.

This conversation with Julien closely parallels Vianne's earlier conversation with Julien Rossignol, her father. In that conversation, Vianne desperately wanted to tell her father about the Jewish children she rescued to gain his acceptance. Vianne wanted her father to understand her, just as she wants Julien to understand her in this moment. However, in both instances, Vianne decides against saying what she wants to say for the benefit of her loved ones. She's rather endure the pain of keeping a secret from her child than subject her child to the pain of knowing the traumatic origin of his existence.

☝ I smile at them, my two boys who should have broken me, but somehow saved me, each in his own way. Because of them, I know now what matters, and it is not what I have lost. It is my memories. Wounds heal. Love lasts. We remain.

Related Characters: Vianne Mauriac (The Narrator) (speaker), Rachel de Champlain, Julien Mauriac, Ari de Champlain, Von Richter

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 564

Explanation and Analysis

This quote concludes the novel. Vianne is still at the *passeurs* reunion, and she has just reunited with Ari de Champlain after many decades. Vianne considers Ari is the first her “two boys” as she took him in as her son after his mother, Vianne's best friend Rachel, was sent to a concentration camp during World War II. He “broke[]” her because he was taken away from her at a young age to live in America with his Jewish relatives. However, Ari also saved Vianne because he gave her something to fight for during the war.

Meanwhile, Julien broke Vianne because her pregnancy with him was the result of rape (Von Richter, the abusive Nazi officer who stayed with Vianne toward the end of the war, is Julien's father). However, Julien also fixed Vianne because he allowed her to have a fresh start after the war, giving her something to love after surviving years of trauma. Though Vianne is skeptical about love in the beginning of the novel, here she praises it as the lasting force in life. War is terrible, but it eventually ends. In contrast, love never dies, and it allows people to “remain” and persevere through hardship.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

CHAPTER 1

It is April 9, 1995, on the Oregon Coast, as an unnamed narrator contemplates the difference between war and love and decides, “in love we find out who we want to be; in war we find out who we are.” These concepts are important to the narrator; lately, she’s thought a lot about war and the people she knows who have died. The narrator herself is quickly approaching death. She’s aged rapidly in the past few months due to the death of her husband and a cancer diagnosis. The narrator wants to think that once she dies, she will be at peace with her loved ones, but she doesn’t think that will happen.

Currently, the narrator is preparing to move out of the house she’s lived in for almost 50 years. She is doing so to make things easier on her son, Julien, who is caring for her. Having to move doesn’t bother her. However, there is something in the attic that she wants to take with her. Cautiously, she makes her way up to her attic, where she finds an old trunk with travel stickers on it. There are a variety of mementos in the trunk, including postcards, books of poetry, and photographs. But the narrator seems particularly interested in a faded identity card from the war, which has a picture of a young woman and the name “Juliette Gervaise.”

As the narrator examines the trunk’s contents, Julien comes up and joins her in the attic. When he kneels beside her, the narrator can tell he’s been smoking, a habit he picked back up after her cancer diagnosis. The narrator says nothing about this behavior because Julien is a doctor and should know better. Julien is worried about his mother because she shouldn’t be up in the attic alone, and she’s begun to cry. When Julien asks her what’s wrong, all she can tell him is that she wants to take the old trunk with them.

Julien asks the narrator why the trunk is so important, but she refuses to answer. Instead, she tells him that moving the trunk is her “last request.” In response, Julien tells her that she will beat the cancer again because she’s already beaten it twice; however, they both know this isn’t the case. Then, Julien asks the narrator: “Who is Juliette Gervaise?” This question opens the floodgates of the narrator’s memory, and she begins thinking about her past.

The contrast the narrator creates between love and war suggests that love reveals one’s ideals, while war demonstrates one’s truths. Evidently, the narrator witnessed war firsthand, and it left a psychological scar. She is fatalistic rather than hopeful, perhaps due to her cancer diagnosis as well as her war experience. Here, the narrator’s identity remains a secret, building intrigue.



50 years before 1995 is 1945, the year World War II ended. Additionally, the name “Juliette Gervaise” is clearly French, suggesting that the narrator is from France or has connections to someone from France. These mementos mean a great deal to the narrator, as does the name “Juliette Gervaise.” These details provide hints about the narrator’s identity.



Julien smokes as a way to cope with his mother’s cancer diagnosis. It is an ironic habit to have picked up because cigarettes are known to cause cancer. Although Julien and his mother are close, something from the narrator’s past is creating a distance between them.



Julien’s question suggests that he doesn’t know much about his mother’s experience during the war. The memories that flood the narrator’s mind are the events that make up the majority of the novel. However, because most of the book is narrated from a third-person perspective, it is difficult to discern the narrator’s identity.



CHAPTER 2

It is August 1939 in France as Vianne Mauriac steps out of her kitchen and into her front yard on a beautiful summer day. Outside, the smell of flowers and the buzzing of bees mix with the laughter of Vianne's eight-year-old daughter, Sophie. Sophie is excited because the family is getting ready for their Saturday picnic. Antoine, Vianne's husband, goes outside, pulls Vianne close to him, and tells her he loves her. Vianne and Antoine are childhood sweethearts; they met on the playground when Vianne was a young, scared girl.

Vianne moved into the house she now stands next to when she was just 14 years old. At the time, she was a frightened, motherless child. Her mother had died just a few weeks before, and her father had already given up on being a good parent. Vianne was left with a Madame who raised her and her sister, Isabelle. At the time, she felt alone, and, in retrospect, she feels she should have done more to help her sister. However, when Vianne met Antoine, he pulled her out of her grief and isolation. At 16, Vianne became pregnant and then married Antoine at 17. However, she lost the child due to a miscarriage, sending her into another downward spiral.

However, on such a beautiful summer day, Vianne does not want to think of her past. Instead, she accompanies Sophie and Antoine through the nearby town of Carriveau. Carriveau is an ancient and beautiful city with cobblestone paths and skilled artisans. The Mauriacs make their way through the city and eventually arrive at their destination: a grassy spot by the river. Once there, the family has a wonderful day of feasting and enjoying each other's company.

Hours later, Sophie walks off to go fishing, and the day's tone quickly shifts. Antoine tells Vianne that Hitler will soon force France to go to war. In response, Vianne says that she doesn't want to talk about these matters on such a beautiful day and gets up to leave. Together, the family makes their way home and, for some time, the question of war disappears. At home, Sophie makes dinner and watches Antoine push Sophie on a swing. When dinner is ready, the family sits down and eats. Sophie talks and tells stories the whole time.

After dinner, Sophie tells Vianne that she thinks Antoine is thinking about the war again because he didn't laugh at any of her stories. Then, Sophie asks Vianne if war is coming. Vianne tells Sophie not to worry because Antoine will protect them no matter what. Vianne knows that this is poor advice. Her father told her something similar as a child before going off to war.

The reader is transported to an idyllic French setting filled with love and romance. There is an emphasis on the scene's natural beauty, and everyone present appears happy and healthy. However, August 1939 was just one month before the German invasion of Poland, which is when France entered World War II—meaning things will likely take a turn for the worse.



Although Vianne is happy in the present, she has a dark past. Her family is fractured, and she feels partially responsible. These family dynamics will be important as the novel moves forward because they shape how the central characters interact with one another. Vianne's miscarriage is also significant because it explains why Sophie, and perhaps children in general, are so important to her.



Carriveau is a fictional town that Hannah invented for the novel. However, the look and feel of the city is based on real French provincial towns. Again, the descriptions in this section detail an idyllic setting that will soon be ravaged by war.



Vianne doesn't want talk of war to sully her day—she knows that war will mean that Antoine must leave her and Sophie. Meanwhile, Sophie, who is just a child, has no sense of what is to come. She does not have experience with war, and she is too young to realize how radically it will affect her life.



Here, Sophie demonstrates that, although young, she is perceptive. Although her parents may try hiding the truth from her, Sophie understands something is wrong. Meanwhile, Vianne and Antoine do their best to protect their only child's innocence while they still can.



Once Sophie is tucked into bed, Vianne goes downstairs and sees Antoine smoking. Antoine reveals that he's received a letter telling him he must report for duty on Tuesday. Vianne is confused; France is not yet at war, and Antoine is only a postman. When she tries to tell him so, Antoine responds, "I am a soldier now, it seems."

Although Vianne knew that war was on the horizon, she didn't realize she had so little time. In a time of war, it would not be uncommon for someone like Antoine, who is merely a postman, to be recruited to serve on the front line. Antoine knows he has no choice in the matter and calmly accepts his fate.



CHAPTER 3

Vianne's earliest memories are of war. She remembers watching her mother cry as her father left to fight. She also recalls being cold and hungry. More than anything, she remembers how much the war changed her father. After the war, her father began drinking more and ignoring his family; he became stoic and always walked with a limp. Now, Vianne rarely reaches out to her father, and they don't have a real relationship. Vianne knows Isabelle still tries to make things work with their father, but she thinks it is a fool's errand.

World War I was a traumatic event for Vianne and her family. She worries that something similar will happen to her current family unit now that war is here again. In particular, she wonders what will happen to Antoine; she doesn't want the war to destroy him like it destroyed her father.



The night Antoine tells Vianne he is going off to war, they have sex. Afterward, Antoine tries to console Vianne; he knows she is afraid of war and assures her that France will be okay. The following day, Vianne and Sophie visit Rachel de Champlain, Vianne's best friend. Vianne met Rachel in the aftermath of her mother's death, and the women mean a great deal to each other. Vianne and Rachel speak privately about the war. Both are worried about how their husbands will fare. Like Antoine, Rachel does her best to cheer up Vianne.

Because Vianne and Antoine have been together since they were young, Antoine knows Vianne's fears and does his best to assuage them. Luckily, Vianne does have Rachel to help her while Antoine is away. Therefore, she has a support system, even when Antoine is not present.



The next day, Antoine and Vianne have a serious conversation about the coming weeks. Antoine suggests that Vianne take Sophie to Paris, where she could live with Julien Rossignol, her father. However, Vianne refuses—she wants to stay put. Antoine accepts Vianne's decision and tells her that he's emptied their bank account, so she'll have plenty of money to use while he's gone. This information makes Vianne nervous; she is not used to handling the family's finances.

Antoine worries about what will happen to Vianne if she doesn't have a man around to help keep her safe. While Vianne doesn't necessarily disagree, she does not feel comfortable living with her father. As such, she must take on responsibilities that traditionally belonged to men, such as handling the family's finances.



After this conversation, Vianne goes and gets Sophie. Sophie is sad that Antoine is leaving. She puts on a crown made of daisies he created for her the day of the picnic and then dutifully follows her mother. Together, Vianne, Antoine, and Sophie leave their home. Outside, Vianne spots three little crosses on the perimeter of their property. These crosses represent the three miscarriages Vianne suffered before giving birth to Sophie. This topic regularly brings Vianne great sadness, but today she doesn't want to think about it; it would be too much.

Sophie's crown of daisies represents her innocence and Antoine's love for her. Additionally, as it turns out, Vianne has even more trauma in her past than she first let on. She repeatedly failed to give birth to a healthy child until Sophie came along, making Sophie that much more precious in Vianne's mind. Here, Vianne has to repress her past trauma to avoid breaking down entirely.



The Mauriacs get into their automobile and then drive to the train station at Tours. While there, Vianne does her best not to think about what happened the last time she witnessed soldiers returning from war. However, she cannot help herself; she thinks about all the men she saw with burns and with broken and missing limbs. After arriving at the station, the family hasn't long to say their goodbyes. Antoine tells his wife and child he loves them and then quickly departs. Vianne is too choked up even to say goodbye.

At the time, World War I was responsible for more deaths and injuries than any other conflict in the Western world; practically everyone in France above a certain age would know someone who was either injured or killed in the war. Vianne tries to suppress these memories but cannot. She is too afraid that something similar will happen to Antoine.



CHAPTER 4

The perspective shifts to a picturesque medieval villa where Isabelle Rossignol is sitting in a dining room, eating. It is June of 1940 and Isabelle's teacher is at the front of the room explaining to Isabelle and her fellow students how to politely cut an orange. Isabelle attempts to follow her teacher's instructions but fails; she drops the orange on the floor and audibly swears. The teacher chastises Isabelle and, in response, Isabelle makes a snide comment about her teaching abilities. Fed up with Isabelle, the teacher orders her to find Madame Allard and "tell her that our experiment has come to an end."

The novel jumps ahead many months and introduces its second protagonist: Isabelle Rossignol. Isabelle is attending an etiquette school where she clearly doesn't belong. At the time, such training would have been typical for a woman of Isabelle's social class in France. However, Isabelle has no patience for it, and this shows that she doesn't care about upholding gender roles and other social norms.



Isabelle goes to Madame Allard's office, tells her about the incident with the orange, and relays her teacher's message. In response, Madame Allard reminds Isabelle of her school history. Apparently, Isabelle has been to several schools and was expelled from all of them. After repeating Isabelle's history, Madame Allard expels Isabelle again because she obviously is not interested in learning proper manners. Although Isabelle is shocked, she doesn't disagree with Madame Allard's assessment. She is much more interested in the war that is threatening France than she is in learning polite behavior.

Again, it's clear Isabelle does not belong in an etiquette school. One of the main themes in this novel is the defiance of traditional gender roles. Here, Isabelle engages in small rebellions against the role society has assigned her.



Isabelle tells Madame Allard that she is only in school in the first place because Julien Rossignol wants nothing to do with her. Madame Allard tells Isabelle that she should go easy on her father—it is not easy to be a widower. However, Isabelle feels that she's gone through just as much as her father has. Regardless of what Julien wants, Madame Allard plans to send Isabelle back to him. Isabelle worries about how her father will react.

Like Vianne, Isabelle has an uneasy relationship with her father. Although Isabelle has been through a great deal of pain, her assertion that she's been through just as much as her father will be tested throughout the novel. While her father is indeed largely to blame for Isabelle's troubled upbringing, he also survived World War I, which left many men traumatized and unable to care for their families.



Isabelle rides the train to Paris, unsure of what will happen when she gets there. She hopes that Julien Rossignol will welcome her with open arms, but she knows that is unlikely to happen. When the train comes to a stop, Isabelle exits and looks for her father. She finds him quickly and sees a look of irritation on his face. Immediately, Isabelle asks Julien if she can live with him and work at his bookstore. However, Julien just walks away with a look of disgust.

Not long after her return to Paris, Isabelle spends an afternoon lying in the grass, reading a book about Edith Cavell, a notable female hero of World War I. As Isabelle reads her book, her friend Christophe interrupts her to ask about what she's reading. This sparks a conversation about the different roles that men and women play during wartime. Christophe thinks that women should stay home while the men fight. However, Isabelle thinks that women have the right to be on the frontlines alongside men.

After her talk with Christophe, Isabelle returns to Julien Rossignol's bookstore. Not long after, Julien and Isabelle hear a loud noise and see crowds of people running in the streets of Paris. Julien and Isabelle realize that the Germans have arrived and so people are fleeing the city. Before long, an air raid siren sounds. Julien and Isabelle hide on the bottom floor of their apartment building. Eventually, the siren stops, and Julien tells Isabelle to return to her room and go to bed. Isabelle protests, but Julien insists. He knows that life is about to get a lot harder for both of them.

CHAPTER 5

Isabelle realizes that many of the public sentiments she's heard about the war are untrue. The Maginot Line did not hold, and now the Germans are moving deeper into France. Before the Germans arrive in Paris, Julien Rossignol decides to send Isabelle away to live with Vianne. He has her pack her things and leave with the Humberts, a family he is friends with. Isabelle doesn't want to leave Paris but ultimately does what she is told.

While Julien may love his daughter, he has a peculiar way of showing it. It is always worth mentioning that this is the second character named Julien in the novel. This suggests that the other Julien—the son of the unnamed narrator—is named after Julien Rossignol. Assuming this is the case, then it seems likely that the unnamed narrator is either Isabelle or Vianne.



Edith Cavell was indeed a real-life war hero who saved hundreds of lives in World War I. Isabelle looks up to Cavell and will cite her as her inspiration throughout the novel. Here, gender roles again come into play. Christophe has a traditional and limited view of how men and women behave during wartime, even though he is not currently fighting in the war.



The Germans entered Paris on June 14, 1940, and seized control. Leading up to this event, many people fled the city as they did not want to live under the Nazi regime. Julien already has an idea of what living under the Nazis might be like, and though he wants to protect Isabelle from that reality, he can't.



The Maginot Line is the border between France and Germany that France heavily fortified at the start of World War II. After the Germans broke through the Maginot Line, they quickly defeated French forces and occupied France. Because Julien doesn't want Isabelle to live under the Nazis, he sends her away to live with Vianne.



Isabelle and the Humberts try to drive out of the city, but their progress is slow going because there are so many people in the streets. Even when they do get to the countryside, the roads are flooded with people, all of whom are fleeing Paris. Eventually, the Humberts' car runs out of gas, and the group is left to travel the rest of the way on foot. However, Isabelle quickly loses the Humberts in the crowd. Alone and hungry, Isabelle wanders into some nearby woods because she smells smoke and meat. Eventually, she finds a young man named Gaëtan sitting by a fire. She approaches Gaëtan cautiously, and he offers her a seat.

Isabelle asks Gaëtan why he isn't a part of the war effort. Gaëtan explains that he was a prisoner until very recently. Apparently, the Parisian prison guards released all of their inmates before the Germans could take over, allowing Gaëtan his freedom. Now, Gaëtan is on his way to see his family before joining the war. Isabelle is envious that Gaëtan can become a soldier and she cannot. She expresses this sentiment to him, and he tells her that she is welcome to join him if she would like. This surprises Isabelle, who is used to being told she cannot be a soldier because she is a beautiful girl who should be kept away from violence. Isabelle tells Gaëtan that she will join him, but she needs to see Vianne first.

CHAPTER 6

The next morning, Isabelle wakes up and sparks a conversation with Gaëtan. She asks him why he was in jail, but he doesn't provide a direct answer. Instead, Gaëtan asks Isabelle what she thinks about communists. This question makes Isabelle assume Gaëtan was a political prisoner. Again, Gaëtan doesn't explicitly state why he was in jail. Instead, he tells Isabelle that someone like her could never understand what he's been through. Isabelle disagrees, telling Gaëtan that prisons come in more forms than one. Eventually, Gaëtan reveals that he was imprisoned for stealing. However, he doesn't elaborate on what he stole.

As their conversation ends, Isabelle and Gaëtan get up and begin their journey. Before long, they encounter a group of French soldiers who are in rough shape and traveling away from Paris. Gaëtan approaches the men and demands to know why they are retreating. The men reveal that no one is still fighting the Germans; instead, everyone is retreating. This news sends Gaëtan into a rage and Isabelle has to move him away from the French soldiers. Together, Isabelle and Gaëtan continue their journey, but Gaëtan's mood takes a turn for the worse. He barely speaks and is clearly upset by what he's heard.

Isabelle's trip out of the city almost seems more dangerous than if she had stayed, at least for the time being. This is the first time in the novel that Isabelle witnesses the desperation of the French people. Although the Rossignols are quite wealthy, Isabelle quickly becomes just as vulnerable as the rest of the crowd—the Humberts' car can only protect her for so long.



It's been common throughout history for prisons to release prisoners during wartime, often so that they can help the war effort. Indeed, Gaëtan plans to do just that. Gaëtan is the first person Isabelle meets who readily accepts her willingness to join the war effort, regardless of her gender. This immediately warms Isabelle to Gaëtan and excites her. Although Isabelle's bravery is admirable, it is also rather immature. She does not yet know the cost of war; her only experiences with it are the stories she's read in books.



The French communist party was banned at the start of World War I, and its members were threatened with incarceration and execution. Evidently, Gaëtan was involved with the party and went to jail because of it. Again, although Isabelle has suffered herself, her decision to compare her suffering to Gaëtan's does show her naivete somewhat—she's yet to realize the extent to which human beings can suffer under extreme conditions.



Notoriously, France quickly crumbled and surrendered after the Germans broke through the Maginot Line. Gaëtan is enraged that his country has already seemingly surrendered to the enemy before he even had a chance to fight.



By the third day of their journey, Isabelle is exhausted and in pain to the point that she can barely stay on her feet. As Isabelle and Gaëtan are walking, they hear planes flying over them. Moments later, the crowd they are walking amongst is bombed and machine gun fire roars all around them. Gaëtan shoves Isabelle to the ground and positions his body over hers to shield her. As Isabelle lays on the ground, she sees chaos everywhere. There are old people who are gravely wounded and children crying next to their dead mothers. In attempt to escape the carnage, Isabelle and Gaëtan run into a nearby church for cover.

Here, Gaëtan proves his bravery by potentially sacrificing his life for Isabelle. This is the first true horror that Isabelle and Gaëtan experience together. No one is safe in this war—including women and children.



CHAPTER 7

Back in Carriveau, Vianne is in a classroom with her students. Under every student's desk, there is a gas mask, and everyone is constantly thinking about the war, especially Vianne herself. She does her best to put on a brave face for the children, but it is difficult when war is all around them. Vianne is worried about Sophie, who looks frightened whenever the topic of war comes up. Like Vianne, Sophie is worried about Antoine and whether or not he is safe.

It's difficult for Vianne to continue denying the reality of war when signs of war are all around Carriveau. It's even impossible to hide the reality of war from children, as the presence of gas masks under the students' desks makes clear.



After school, Vianne finds Rachel—who also teaches at the school—and the two friends walk home together. On their way home, Vianne and Rachel spot a group of women who look ragged and exhausted. Upon seeing them, Rachel tells Vianne that she's heard that refugees have been spotted in Carriveau. Vianne is worried that Isabelle hasn't arrived in Carriveau yet. The group of women reminds Vianne that Isabelle's road to Carriveau is dangerous, and she worries that something may have happened to her. She expresses this fear to Rachel who tells her not to worry. After all, Isabelle is a resourceful girl who knows how to look after herself.

Vianne spends most of her time worrying—she has to worry about Antoine, Sophie, and now Isabelle. Luckily, Rachel is around to console her. Rachel insightfully reminds Vianne that Isabelle is a resourceful girl who knows how to manage on her own. That said, Vianne is not wrong to worry; Isabelle is in real danger, as the previous chapter makes clear.



In the evening, Vianne goes outside to do some gardening. While outside, the women she saw earlier come to her gate and ask for water. Vianne tells them they can come in, but the women refuse. They tell Vianne that they are out in front of the others. Vianne isn't sure what to make of this remark, but she goes inside and gets the women food and water.

Although she's scared, Vianne does her best to support those in need. However, the women's ominous remark suggests that Vianne is unprepared for what is to come.



When Vianne returns to the women, she sees that one of them is holding a deceased baby. The women thank Vianne for her kindness and then warn her to lock her doors and not let anyone in. Vianne does as she is told and before long a huge crowd of people come walking up the road. As they pass by, Vianne's house shakes, and she hears people outside in her garden. Vianne and Sophie wonder if Isabelle is in the crowd and pray that she is not.

The dead child is Vianne's first direct look at the price of war as an adult. It is a particularly striking image for Vianne because she knows what it is like to lose a child. Additionally, the people Vianne hears in her garden are likely stealing her food because they are starving after their long journey.



Unfortunately, Isabelle and Gaëtan are in the crowd. When they reach Vianne's home, Isabelle knocks on the door. However, no one answers. Because they cannot get inside, Isabelle and Gaëtan go to the backyard, where they plan to spend the night. Once there, Gaëtan tells Isabelle that she should stay with Vianne where she will be safe. In response, Isabelle says to Gaëtan that she doesn't care about her safety and that Vianne will not want her anyway. Instead, Isabelle wants to be like Edith Cavell and make a difference in the outcome of the war.

Isabelle begs Gaëtan to take her with him to war. Gaëtan flirts with Isabelle and tells her that he promises to take her if she will kiss him. Isabelle kisses Gaëtan and says that they are lucky to have run into each other. Gaëtan disagrees but says no more, and then the two of them go to bed.

The next morning, Vianne wakes up and goes outside to find her garden destroyed and Isabelle crying all by herself. Surprised, Vianne tends to her sister and takes her inside. For the time being, she does not press Isabelle on what is wrong. Isabelle bathes, eats, and then goes to bed. When she wakes up, Vianne hands Isabelle a note from Gaëtan that says, "You are not ready." Vianne tells Isabelle that she found the note stuck to her.

Vianne and Isabelle switch the subject to discuss updates on the war. Isabelle informs Vianne that she plans to leave Carriveau to join the war effort. Vianne protests, but Isabelle does not care. Together, Vianne and Isabelle listen to a news report on the radio, which reveals that France has surrendered to the Germans. Although the news deeply upsets Isabelle, Vianne assumes that the French government is doing the right thing. She tells Isabelle that she is wrong to be up in arms. As Isabelle is raging over the news of France's surrender, Sophie comes home. When Isabelle sees Sophie, she is shocked by how much Sophie has grown. Sophie and Isabelle immediately take a liking to each other.

CHAPTER 8

Since France surrendered to the Germans, food and resources are scarce. Vianne does her best to fix her damaged garden, but most of the food that was once there is now gone. While Vianne works in the garden, Isabelle stands nearby and angrily talks about the German forces. Vianne does her best to ignore Isabelle, but Sophie listens to her aunt and takes in what she says. Vianne worries that Sophie will learn all the wrong things from Isabelle.

Although Gaëtan initially encouraged Isabelle to fight for France, he has second thoughts. His experiences over the last few days have made him think that women have no place on the frontlines of a war. Additionally, he's come to like Isabelle and doesn't want to see her get hurt.



Gaëtan disagrees with Isabelle because he knows the price of falling in love with someone during wartime. He likes Isabelle, which means losing her would be painful.



Isabelle is hurt because she thought Gaëtan liked her, and now she just feels used. Although Isabelle's hurt is understandable, Gaëtan's note suggests that he likes Isabelle, which is precisely why he decided to leave her behind.



This is the first time in the novel that Vianne and Isabelle are in the same place at the same time. Although they are sisters, they could not be more unlike. Isabelle cannot wait to run off to war and fight back against the Germans. Meanwhile, Vianne is a pacifist who trusts her government to do the right thing. From a modern perspective, it would be easy to judge Vianne harshly. However, it is essential to remember that the French people did not yet know the full extent of the actions and intentions of the Nazis.



The fact that Vianne is already running short on food is a problem. The Germans would occupy France until 1944, and food was scarce for much of that time. While Vianne does her best to keep her head down, Isabelle seems to go out of her way to create problems. In this case, Isabelle is lucky she is a woman because a man would have been treated much harsher for similar offenses.



Later, Vianne, Isabelle, and Sophie walk into town. On their way to town, Isabelle purposely steps out into the road to get in the way of a group of German soldiers. Although she does so as an act of protest, her behavior only amuses the Germans. Before Isabelle can cause a problem, Vianne grabs her by the arm and pulls her out of the road. She asks Isabelle to be more careful for her own sake and for Sophie's.

Isabelle explains to Vianne that the Germans are in Carriveau, so they have access to the airfield. Isabelle thinks the war is far from over and that they should take Sophie away from Carriveau and into the free part of France as soon as possible. However, Vianne refuses. She thinks the war is already over, and she doesn't want to leave her home. She trusts the French government to iron everything out with the Germans.

The following evening, Isabelle begins preparing for the long war that she thinks is coming. She rounds up all of the expensive and important items in the household and hides them in a cellar beneath the family's barn. Isabelle's actions anger Vianne because Vianne asked her to go shopping and now the family is without food. Additionally, Vianne thinks Isabelle is being silly and that her actions are useless. After Vianne chastises Isabelle, Isabelle hears a message on the radio from General de Gaulle to the French people. General de Gaulle is a resistance figure, and he encourages the French to join his cause. This broadcast gives Isabelle hope; she is disappointed in the French government's reaction to the German occupation, and she is glad someone is fighting back.

The next day, everyone in Carriveau gathers in the town square to partake in a meeting that the Germans set up. Vianne, Isabelle, and Sophie attend the meeting together where they see Rachel and Sarah. Rachel greets Isabelle kindly and apologizes for the way she acted when they were kids. Isabelle accepts the apology and then the meeting begins. The Germans tell everyone that they need to turn in their radios, guns, and vehicles. Additionally, they institute a curfew that everyone must follow. The Germans claim that they want to live peacefully among the residents of Carriveau; however, they promise that all forms of resistance and rule breaking will be punished. Additionally, they reveal that the Frenchmen who have been captured during the war will not be allowed to come home. Instead, they must live in prisoner of war camps in Germany.

Again, Isabelle tries to rebel in any way she can. Although she sees her behavior as brave, it is also rather foolish. Vianne knows that Isabelle is putting everyone in danger, while Isabelle either seems not to know or not to care.



Here, the novel cleverly utilizes the dramatic irony that exists because of the contemporary reader's historical perspective. Contemporary readers will know that what Vianne says here is false. Historically, during the German occupation of France, the French government did a terrible job of protecting its citizens and effectively aided the Nazis in carrying out their abhorrent goals.



Although Vianne is angry with Isabelle, Isabelle's actions are undeniably sharp, and later Vianne will appreciate them. Isabelle feels like Vianne does not support her and that she is acting incredibly naive. Luckily, General de Gaulle's voice gives Isabelle hope. General Charles de Gaulle is an actual historical figure who was a leading figure in the French resistance and helped restore democracy to France following World War II. Eventually, de Gaulle became president of France from 1959 to 1969. He is largely a beloved figure in French history, although the end of his political career was met with some controversy.



Almost immediately, Isabelle's intuitions prove helpful. The Germans plan to rule over France like fascists, and Isabelle is right to rebel. Additionally, although not unheard of, it is rare that prisoners of war would not return home once their home country is no longer a threat to the war effort. However, the Germans decided to keep French prisoners of war in camps because they did not want them to return home and rebel. This is one of many ways the Nazis defied the status quo. It is also one of the reasons for the establishment of the Geneva Conventions following World War II.



On the way home from the meeting, Vianne's head is reeling. She worries that Antoine has been captured and will not be coming home anytime soon. However, when Isabelle begins speaking about resistance, Vianne chides her and tells her to keep her head down. She insists that the Frenchmen will be home soon and that they will know what to do. Until then, she plans to live her life as peacefully as she can under German rule. However, Rachel gives Vianne some pushback. Rachel tells her that Isabelle is probably right and that they should try to hide their gun and radio. Still, Vianne holds strong and insists that she will do what the Germans say until Antoine comes home.

Not long after Vianne arrives home, a German soldier knocks on her door. When Vianne opens the door, the German introduces himself; his name is Captain Beck, and he plans to billet in Vianne's home. Although Vianne is reluctant to let Captain Beck into her house, she knows she has no choice. Captain Beck sees the look on Vianne's face and promises her that he will act respectfully.

Vianne takes Captain Beck inside and shows him to his bedroom. Captain Beck thanks Vianne and once again promises to be an upstanding house guest. Vianne doesn't know what to make of Captain Beck, and she worries about how Isabelle will treat him. Sure enough, when Captain Beck introduces himself to Isabelle and tells her that she has beautiful hair, Isabelle does not reply in a polite manner. Instead, she takes some scissors and chops her hair off, neutering her beauty. Vianne witnesses this scene and immediately asks Captain Beck for his forgiveness.

Captain Beck forgives Isabelle but warns Vianne that such behavior will not be tolerated in the future. Captain Beck tells Vianne that she must make sure Isabelle behaves politely and follows the rules if she wants to be safe. Vianne agrees, and when Captain Beck is gone, she has a talk with Isabelle about her conduct. Although Isabelle is reluctant to obey the Germans and treat Captain Beck with respect, Vianne eventually convinces her that it is necessary. After all, if Isabelle slips up, she is putting the lives of the entire household in danger.

Unlike Isabelle, Vianne refuses to take on a masculine role any more than she has to. She holds on to hope that Antoine will be home soon so she will not have to make any tough decisions herself. Here and elsewhere, Vianne's actions are rooted in fear; she wants to do everything she can to protect Sophie, and she knows that rebellion could result in Sophie's death. However, as always, Rachel acts as the voice of reason and tells her that Isabelle is more correct than Vianne would like to believe.



Billeting is a common practice during wartime. A billet is a civilian household that a soldier takes over for the purpose of lodging. For most of modern history, billeting soldiers were expected to act respectfully, and it appears that Captain Beck plans to live up to that promise.



Vianne does not want Captain Beck in her house, but she has no choice in the matter. Vianne knows that he will butt heads with Isabelle because Isabelle won't stifle her rebelliousness in his presence. Vianne knows that Isabelle's behavior is dangerous, even if Captain Beck seems committed to behaving civilly.



Once again, Beck comes off as reasonable and inoffensive. However, just as Vianne feared, others have noticed and commented on Isabelle's bad behavior. Although Isabelle is right to distrust the Germans, she is not entirely in the right. Though brave, her actions are also selfish, and Vianne is right to worry about what could happen to her and Sophie as a result of Isabelle's behavior.



CHAPTER 9

After her talk with Isabelle, Vianne sits alone in her bedroom and tries to calm her nerves. As she does so, she can hear Isabelle angrily pacing in the other room. Vianne wants to talk to Isabelle about the past and apologize for her behavior, but she worries that could only make matters worse. Even in normal times, that would be a difficult conversation to have, and these are far from normal times. Vianne thinks about the past and how difficult life was in the wake of her mother's death. However, almost as soon as those thoughts come, Vianne pushes them away.

Vianne goes to the kitchen to make dinner and encounters Beck there. Beck tells Vianne about his family back home in Germany. His wife is pregnant, and he's excited to get back to her once the war is over. This new information makes Vianne feel better about Beck's presence. She realizes that the two of them are not that different; just like her, Beck wants the war to end as soon as possible so he can return to his family. Vianne asks Beck if he would like dinner and Beck politely accepts. He even brings a fancy bottle of wine to share with Vianne.

Before dinner begins, Isabelle comes into the room and starts grilling Beck about the bombing she witnessed in Tours. She wants to know if Beck played any part in the event, and she is quite aggressive in trying to figure this out. When she gets the chance, Vianne pulls Isabelle aside and reminds her to think about the danger she could put them all in if she refuses to behave.

Isabelle acknowledges Vianne's warning but does little to change her behavior. She does offer Beck a seat at the dinner table, but she is rude throughout the meal and leaves as soon as she can. When Isabelle leaves the table, Sophie excuses herself as well. This worries Vianne; she thinks Isabelle might instill behavior in Sophie that could get them all killed. She apologizes to Beck for Sophie and Isabelle's actions. Beck accepts the apology by saying that he has a young daughter whose temperament is similar to Isabelle's. This information once again helps put Vianne at ease. She feels more comfortable with Beck knowing that he has children and can understand Vianne's situation.

Following dinner, Vianne goes outside to get some air. Surprisingly, she finds Beck there; he tells her that he likes to stand underneath the night sky and look at the stars. Vianne asks Beck about what will become of the French prisoners of war. Beck tells her that he does not know all of the details. He thinks that some French soldiers will be allowed to come home, but many will not.

Vianne is in a difficult situation. She needs to keep Isabelle under control, but she has no genuine authority over her. In addition to these present difficulties, Vianne and Isabelle have yet to address the past traumas that drove them apart in the first place. The connection between the past and the present is a theme that recurs throughout the novel.



Beck's discussion of his family humanizes him in Vianne's eyes. She realizes that although he is the enemy, he is a person just like her who shares similar concerns. Additionally, it seems that Vianne is less worried that Beck will act sexually aggressive toward her because he has a wife at home.



Again, Isabelle refuses to behave. Just like at etiquette school, she refuses to submit to any authority figure. Vianne understandably views Isabelle's actions as needlessly perilous and does what she can to defuse the situation.



Still, Isabelle will not heed Vianne's advice. Luckily, Beck does not appear to be a tyrant. He further ingratiates himself with Vianne by telling her about his family. However, regardless of whether Beck is a good person, Vianne knows that he is far from her only problem and that Isabelle's actions will catch up to them sooner or later.



Again, the book portrays Beck as a human being rather than an evil Nazi. He admires nature and is sympathetic to Vianne's plight. Vianne seems to see Beck as a cog in a much larger machine.



In the middle of Vianne and Beck's conversation, Isabelle comes out and sees the two of them together. Isabelle makes a not-so-subtle comment about Vianne talking with the enemy, which makes Beck realize that he is not welcome. As such, he excuses himself and goes inside. Once Beck is gone, Isabelle informs Vianne that she is going to leave Carriveau and head to Paris. Isabelle hates living with Beck and thinks her presence will only cause problems. Ignoring the curfew, Isabelle heads to the train station. On her way, a German soldier spots her, chastises her for breaking the rules, and then orders her to return home. He also tells her that she needs a pass if she expects to be able to leave Carriveau.

Realizing that she will have to learn to live with Vianne, Sophie, and Beck, Isabelle does her best to do as her older sister says. Each day, Isabelle goes to town and stands in line for food. One day while in line, Isabelle spots a piece of chalk on the ground. She picks up the chalk, already knowing what she is going to do with it. Isabelle eventually makes it to the front of the food line where she receives a bad cut of ham. The Germans have kept all of the good meat for themselves, so the residents of Carriveau are only left with lower quality cuts.

Before heading home, Isabelle walks down an alley where she finds an anti-Semitic propaganda poster. Isabelle looks around her to make sure no one is watching and then draws a giant "V" (meaning "victory") on the poster as an act of rebellion. As soon as she's finished, a man grabs her and shoves her against the wall. Isabelle cannot see the man and cannot tell if he is a German. The man warns Isabelle that what she's just done is punishable by death.

CHAPTER 10

Vianne sits alone and knits while thinking about Antoine. She desperately wants him to come home because she misses him, and she knows that he could take control of the current situation. After finishing her knitting, Vianne goes outside with the intention of chopping wood. However, before she can get far, Beck comes out and offers to take over the task. Vianne tells him that he doesn't have to, but Beck insists; he wants to be a good houseguest and chopping wood is a man's job. Vianne accepts Beck's help, but doing so makes her uneasy.

When Isabelle spots Beck and Vianne together, it only makes matters worse. Isabelle already thinks that Vianne is too friendly with the enemy, and this sight confirms her worst suspicions. Isabelle refuses to submit to the Germans and continues to rebel. However, her encounter with the German soldier on the way to the train station finally forces her to accept that she is not entirely in control of her fate, and she is forced to turn back and live with Beck for the time being, whether she likes it or not. Again, Isabelle is perhaps lucky that she is a woman. If the German soldier had spotted a man doing something similar, his fate could have been much worse.



Ration lines became the norm for many occupied areas during World War II. As such, the French people were only allowed what the Germans would give them, which often wasn't much. Of course, such treatment only increases Isabelle's resentment. She picks up the chalk knowing that she will use it to engage in an act of rebellion.



Antisemitism is mainly in the background for the first part of the novel; it seems that because Isabelle and Vianne are not Jewish, the issue is not at the front of their minds. In this moment, Isabelle directly rebels against the Nazi ideology, and it seems her careless actions may have finally caught up to her.



Vianne wants Antoine to return so that she can return to her old role in the household. As she goes outside to chop wood, she realizes that, in some ways, she has a replacement for Antoine in the form of Beck. Although he is not the leader Vianne seeks, he is nonetheless a masculine presence who takes over some of the more male-oriented chores around the house.



Rachel arrives the Mauriac's residence to accompany Vianne and Sophie to school. Before they depart, Beck spots them, and Vianne introduces him to Rachel. On their way to school, Rachel comments on Beck's good looks, and Vianne tells her that she shouldn't speak of such things. In response, Rachel tells Vianne that she should consider herself lucky; many of the other Germans are much worse than Beck both in temperament and looks.

Here, Rachel alludes to a thought has already occurred to Vianne: Beck is an attractive man who essentially fulfills a husband-like role without sex. Rachel tries to get Vianne to look on the bright side, but where Rachel sees positives, Vianne only observes more problems.



In the meantime, Isabelle is being dragged along the back alleys of Paris after defacing the propaganda poster. She still doesn't know who has apprehended her or what is going to happen. She worries that the man is a German who will kill her for her actions. Eventually, Isabelle ends up in a room with a group of men. She doesn't think they are Nazis but does not know for sure. There, a man about why she defaced the poster. As she glances around the room, Isabelle realizes that none of the men look German, so she is likely safe to tell the truth.

This is a fast-paced sequence where Isabelle has to quickly determine whether she is amongst friends or foes. Knowing she could be in danger, Isabelle quickly analyzes the men around her and eventually surmises she is amongst friends.



Once the man realizes that Isabelle's "V" was an act of resistance, he asks her to join his cause. The man's name is Henri, and he is a supporter of General de Gaulle. Henri thinks Isabelle would be good for the cause—as a woman, she'll appear more inconspicuous. He tasks Isabelle with secretly handing out pamphlets around town, which serve as messages from de Gaulle to the resistance. Isabelle happily agrees to help. She is overjoyed to finally be part of something that can meaningfully fight back against the Nazis.

As it turns out, Isabelle's intuitions were once again correct. Furthermore, she luckily managed to stumble into the exact role she was looking for. Although she catches a lucky break here, Isabelle's life has only become more dangerous. She is now an active part of the resistance, a position that could result in her death.



Henri informs Isabelle that there are many other groups like his that are doing similar work. He also gives her a bunch of pamphlets to distribute, which Isabelle hides in her shopping basket. When Isabelle gets home, she goes to the cellar to put away the produce. Before she can go downstairs, Beck insists on carrying her basket for her. This makes Isabelle visibly nervous; she knows what could happen if Beck discovers the contents of the basket. Beck notices Isabelle's demeanor and asks her what is wrong. Isabelle tells him that she saw the Gestapo in town with their dogs, and the sight frightened her. Beck doesn't push Isabelle further, but it is unclear whether he believes her. Luckily, Beck never looks in the basket, and Isabelle is able to hide the pamphlets before going back upstairs.

Beck almost immediately catches Isabelle before she can distribute her first pamphlet. This makes Isabelle realize that she must be more careful around Beck and the other Nazis than in the past. If she is not, then her life—and the lives of Vianne and Sophie—could be in danger. However, once again, Isabelle does have the benefit of being relatively inconspicuous because of her gender.



The following day, Isabelle wakes up early in the morning to hand out the pamphlets. Doing so makes her feel strong and important—like she is doing something that actually matters. Afterward, she heads to town to stand in line for food. However, because Isabelle is up so early, she is the first one there. For her efforts, she is rewarded with a two-thirds cup of butter, which, to Isabelle, is a great reward.

Isabelle performs her first job and finally gets the sense of purpose she was looking for. It feels like the universe rewards her when she gets a relatively excellent item from the ration line.



CHAPTER 11

Winter is on its way, and food is already scarce. Vianne does what she can to prepare the few resources she has for the upcoming winter season. She plants as much food as she can and creates an enclosure where her chickens can live. As she performs this work, she thinks about Antoine. She wonders whether he is a prisoner of war, and, if so, how he is being treated.

A short while later, as Vianne and Sophie are walking home from school, they spot Isabelle in an alley. Vianne thinks Isabelle looks suspicious and worries about what she is up to. She knows that Isabelle has been sneaking out of the house at odd hours and thinks it is because she is trying to meet up with a boy. When Sophie sees Isabelle, she runs up to her to say hello. As she does so, she puts her hand on the basket Isabelle is carrying. Without thinking, Isabelle's slaps Sophie's hand away so that she doesn't open the basket. Isabelle's actions shock both Vianne and Sophie. Realizing what she's done, Isabelle quickly apologizes.

Together, Isabelle, Sophie, and Vianne walk through town. As they do so, Vianne tries not to think about how much Carriveau has changed for the worse. While in town, they run into Beck, who tells Vianne that he won't be around for dinner. Vianne feels the eyes of her countrymen on her as she speaks to Beck. She is ashamed of the disapproval she knows she is receiving. However, Beck does provide her with some useful, albeit depressing, information. He gives Vianne a list of the prisoners of war from Carriveau, along with some postcards. Unfortunately, Antoine's name is on the list.

Isabelle knows how much this information upsets Vianne, and she does her best to comfort her older sister. Vianne tells Isabelle that she hates being on her own and doesn't know if she can survive. In response, Isabelle reminds Vianne that the two of them have been on their own since their mother's death. However, while that may be true for Isabelle, it is not true for Vianne. Vianne met Antoine when she was 14 and has had him by her side ever since. Isabelle tells Vianne that despite Antoine's absence, she must be strong for Sophie's sake.

Vianne knows that winter will make her present hardships even worse. She would do anything to get Antoine home so that he could help guide her through such difficult times.



Although Vianne does not trust her sister, she never imagines just how rebellious Isabelle actually is. Instead, she assumes Isabelle is caught up with typical teenage concerns. Based on Isabelle's reaction to Sophie, Vianne's suspicion that something is up with Isabelle only grows. Presumably, Isabelle has more pamphlets in the basket and doesn't want Sophie to see.



Vianne once again finds herself in a difficult position. She doesn't want to feel like she is betraying France, but she also knows she must treat Beck respectfully. However, the townsfolk are not entirely wrong. They assume that Vianne is getting something out of her cozy relationship to Beck, and they are correct. Vianne's kindness pays off as she finally learns Antoine's fate. Unfortunately, he will not be coming home, which means winter will be that much more difficult for Vianne, Isabelle, and Sophie.



Vianne's reliance on Antoine from a young age means she is thoroughly unprepared for the difficulties she now faces. Meanwhile, Isabelle has been more or less on her own for a long time, which explains why she acts so independently. Essentially, the two sisters are on the opposite ends of a spectrum: one is too self-reliant, while the other isn't self-reliant enough.



After Vianne gathers herself, she goes to Rachel's house with the list of names. Unfortunately, Rachel's husband is also on the list, and although Vianne doesn't want to be the one to break the bad news, she knows she has to. Rachel takes the news as best as she possibly can. A few days later, Vianne calls a meeting in her classroom with the other wives whose husbands are on Beck's list. She informs them that their husbands will not be coming home and then hands out the postcards that Beck gave her.

However, the other women do not take kindly to Vianne's actions. They think she has purposely cozied up to Beck to get favors. Rachel defends Vianne from these charges and tells the women that they should be grateful for her help. After all, everyone has had to make sacrifices in the war and compromise their morals. Although the women do not apologize to Vianne, they do write messages on the postcards and hand them to her.

After the meeting, Vianne heads home and finds Beck there. She gives Beck the postcards and asks if he will mail them for her. Beck agrees to mail the cards, but only on one condition: he wants Vianne to make a list of all of the Jews, homosexuals, communists, Freemasons and Jehovah's Witnesses at her school. This request worries Vianne, and at first, she refuses. However, Beck tempts Vianne by telling her that she could send a care package to Antoine if she makes the list.

Vianne doesn't feel right about making the list, but she decides to do so anyway. She rationalizes her actions by telling herself that the information she is providing is easy to find anyway. When she finishes writing down all of the names, she hands the list to Beck. Beck inspects the list and then tells her that she forgot a name: Rachel's. Rachel is Jewish, which, apparently, Beck has already figured out. Feigning ignorance, Vianne acknowledges Beck's comment and then writes down Rachel's name.

CHAPTER 12

It is now November of 1940. The cold weather has officially arrived, and Vianne does everything she can to keep warm. As the weather gets worse and the war drags on, Vianne worries about what she is going to do. The money Antoine left her is running low and soon will be gone. One day, early in the morning, while Vianne knits a scarf for Sophie, Isabelle comes in from outdoors. Vianne asks Isabelle if she's been meeting up with a boy, and Isabelle says no. Isabelle pretends that she is just coming in from feeding the chickens. Vianne doesn't believe Isabelle, but there is nothing she can do.

It is understandable that Vianne doesn't want to be the bearer of bad news—and admirable that she decides to be anyway. This is the first of several difficult conversations that Vianne has with Rachel, and their ability to have such conversations is a testament to their enduring friendship.



The women's response to Vianne is calloused but understandable. To them, Vianne is too close with the same enemy that is holding their husbands hostage.



This section marks a fundamental character shift for Beck. Previously, he seemed like a fundamentally good person on the wrong side of the war. However, here, he demonstrates his capacity to act callously and manipulatively toward Vianne, even if he's just following orders. It is important to note that at this time, Vianne (and possibly Beck) would not know the purpose of such a list. However, both Beck and Vianne know that, at the very least, the list would be detrimental to the people on it.



Although Vianne is not wrong—such information would not be hard to find for the most part—it is difficult to know whether this alone justifies her actions. In particular, writing down Rachel's name seems like a horrible betrayal, even though Beck already knew she was of Jewish descent anyway.



Time jumps ahead again, and conditions have only gotten worse. Vianne is understandably worried about her situation; she knows it is not sustainable. Meanwhile, Isabelle continues to engage in acts of rebellion right under Beck's nose. Vianne still has not caught on to what Isabelle is doing, which is probably for the better—she would only worry more if she knew the truth.



Vianne gets up to look at the pantry. At this point, it is almost empty, but she makes do with what she has. When Vianne gives Sophie her breakfast, Sophie complains about how the Germans are using up all the food. Just as those words leave her mouth, Beck walks into the room. Not wanting to cause problems, Vianne chastises Sophie for speaking in such a way. However, Beck doesn't seem to mind. He tells Sophie that the Germans take as much as they give, and then he hands her a chocolate bar. Sophie eats the chocolate, ravenously. After, Vianne tells Sophie that she should have saved some for later.

Vianne makes her way to school. Not long after the start of her lessons, some German soldiers appear and fire everyone on the list that Vianne made for Beck. This sudden change of events deeply disturbs Vianne, and she feels guilty for what she's done. At midday, she cannot take it anymore and decides to walk into town to find Beck.

Beck's office is elaborate. It is replete with Nazi imagery, and Vianne spots piles of food in one corner. When Vianne tells Beck what has happened and asks him to explain himself, Beck tells her he was only following orders. He promises that he did not know what the list was going to be used for. Before the conversation can go further, Beck asks Vianne to leave his office. He doesn't think anything good can come from the two of them being seen together. Vianne does as he asks.

When Vianne leaves Beck's office, she notices German soldiers looking at her. She doesn't put too much thought into their glances; she assumes they think that she is romantically involved with Beck. However, Isabelle also spots her and demands to know what she was doing. Vianne tells Isabelle the truth about the list and what happened at the school. Isabelle is disgusted by her sister's actions and tells her to stop doing favors for the Nazis. Vianne agrees and then sends Isabelle to go get Sarah and Sophie from school.

Next, Vianne heads to her local church to speak with Mother Superior Marie-Therese to seek advice. Vianne is honest with Mother Superior about what she's done. She is worried that her actions are unforgivable because she has hurt many people, including her best friend, Rachel. Mother Superior calms Vianne's nerves: she tells Vianne that the moral fault rests with the Germans and that they would have found the names one way or another. Vianne thinks that she should behave more like Isabelle, but Mother Superior disagrees. Mother Superior says that Isabelle has not yet been tested by the war, but she will be soon enough—just like everyone else.

No matter what happens, Vianne refuses to complain to Beck; she fears that if she does, it will only make matters worse. However, she cannot stop Sophie—still a young child—from doing exactly that. Luckily, Beck takes Sophie's comment lightly and even offers her a gift. Although it is a nice gesture, Vianne does not know if she can trust Beck after the incident with the list.



Here, for the first time, Vianne sees the result of her actions. Because she helped Beck, many of her colleagues were hurt. Of course, this includes Rachel, who is Vianne's best friend.



Finally, Vianne stands up to Beck. However, Beck does not have any good answers. It is possible that he did not know what his higher-ups would use the list for. On the other hand, the elaborate nature of his office suggests that he has a relatively high rank and could possess such knowledge. As such, Vianne feels she can trust him even less than she did before.



Again, the novel brings the idea of a sexual relationship between Vianne and Beck to the reader's attention. Even if there is romantic tension between them, though, neither has acted on it. When Isabelle learns what Vianne has done, their relationship erodes even further. Isabelle already does not respect her sister's pacificism, and, in this case, she directly aided the enemy.



Vianne feels genuine guilt over her actions, especially because she's hurt Rachel. Although Marie-Therese tries to calm Vianne's nerves, it is difficult for Vianne—and perhaps the reader—to come away feeling okay about what Vianne did. Although the Nazis would have fired Rachel anyway, Vianne's actions still feel like a betrayal, albeit a relatively small one in the grand scheme of things.



After her talk at the church, Vianne heads to Rachel's house. She knows she must tell her friend the truth, no matter how painful it is. When Vianne enters Rachel's home, her friend is clearly already upset. Vianne sits her down and tells her the truth about the list and then apologizes. In doing so, she only gives the fact and does not make excuses for herself. After Vianne is finished, Rachel angrily leaves the room without saying anything. Vianne is left to sit at Rachel's table and think about the consequences of her actions.

This is a significant moment for Vianne. Although she has done wrong, she owns up to it immediately and without making excuses. And though she knows her conversation with Rachel will be a difficult, she goes through with it anyway. It would be understandable if Rachel did not want to associate with Vianne anymore, and Vianne knows that going into the conversation.



After some time, Rachel returns. Although she is still angry, she forgives Vianne and warns her to be more careful in the future. Rachel knows that the whole town is aware of her Judaism, so the information wouldn't have been kept from the Nazis anyway. However, she advises Vianne to be careful around Beck; no matter how kind and handsome he is, he is not to be trusted.

This section shows the strength of Rachel's character. Although she could treat Vianne harshly, instead she forgives her and offers advice. Admittedly, it is not advice that Vianne needs at this point—she already does not trust Beck.



Winter rages on and the weather is especially brutal. Still, no matter how cold it gets, Isabelle hands out pamphlets for the resistance. Unfortunately, the Nazis are aware of the pamphlets and have started looking for whoever is handing them out. In town, Isabelle sees posters with warning messages about aiding the resistance. Apparently, the Nazis will execute anyone who undermines the Nazi agenda.

Isabelle's willingness to go out early in the morning in the middle of winter demonstrates how much she cares about the resistance effort. However, now that the Nazis know about her pamphlets, she is in greater danger every time she goes out.



While in town, Isabelle spots a bicycle sitting by itself. Although it is risky, Isabelle decides to steal the bike and ride it to Henri's hideout. Henri tells her that he can paint the bike in exchange for a kiss. This reminds Isabelle of the pact she made with Gaëtan, back when life was less complicated. Isabelle agrees to Henri's deal and gives him a kiss.

Isabelle continues to behave recklessly. Each of her small rebellions could result in death, but she goes through with them anyway. But, like Vianne, she does not yet realize the total weight of her actions.



CHAPTER 13

It is now April of 1941, and the weather has greatly improved. Isabelle is outside, lying in a field near Vianne's home. Vianne walks up to Isabelle and gives her a note from Henri, which reads, "the curtains are open." Isabelle recognizes the message as a summons from Henri. Isabelle gets up and heads into town, eventually making it to Henri's hideout.

Although life is never easy under Nazi rule, the spring weather helps make life a bit less harsh. With the change of season also come new orders for Isabelle. Isabelle heads to Henri's hideout, wondering what he has in mind.



Once there, Henri tells Isabelle that he has a mission for her. He wants her to take a letter and deliver it to a resistance figure in Paris. After she arrives, Henri wants her to stay in Paris and act as a point of contact for the resistance. He tells Isabelle that this will be a dangerous mission and that she will have to lie to everyone she holds dear, including Sophie and Vianne.

Isabelle has proven herself and is finally receiving a promotion of sorts. For the first time, the resistance trusts her with a larger (and more dangerous) mission. Luckily, Isabelle won't have much of a problem lying to Sophie and Vianne—she's been doing it for months.



Isabelle is hesitant. Although she wants to help the resistance, she knows that the only way she can stay in Paris is if she lives with Julien Rossignol. She knows that Julien will try to send her away as soon as she arrives. Isabelle expresses this concern to Henri, who tells her that she must convince her father to let her stay. That is the only way this plan works. After giving it some thought, Isabelle agrees to deliver the message and act as a point of contact for the resistance.

Isabelle's relationship with her father is complicated, and she doesn't know if she can mend it. However, she ultimately decides to try for the movement's greater good.



In the meantime, Vianne is at home, thinking about the note she gave to Isabelle. She assumes the note is from a boy with whom Isabelle is carrying on some sort of secret romance. This thought angers Vianne. If true, then Isabelle is putting her own life, as well as the lives of others, in danger for a silly teenage romance. Vianne thinks Isabelle needs to grow up and accept the fact that her actions have consequences.

Vianne has not yet realized her sister's true purpose. Although Vianne has good reason not to trust Isabelle, her judgments are slightly unfair, especially considering her own wrongdoing. Luckily, Vianne's ignorance works to Isabelle's benefit.



As Vianne thinks about what to do with Isabelle, Beck shows up with a group of German soldiers. Together, they begin destroying the stone wall around Vianne's house. Beck explains to Vianne that he is only following orders. Vianne can tell that it pains him to destroy the wall. Later, Isabelle arrives home and asks Beck about why he destroyed the wall. Beck explains that the Germans want to be able to see into the house whenever they desire so they can keep an eye out for whoever has been delivering anti-German propaganda.

Again, whether or not Beck agrees with the orders of his superiors, he still stands by while someone carries them out. This behavior only creates more resentment in Isabelle and more distrust in Vianne. Nonetheless, Beck is still a somewhat sympathetic character. He seems genuinely conflicted about destroying the wall and wouldn't do it if he didn't have to.



In the middle of her conversation with Beck, Isabelle informs him that she wants to go to Paris to live with Julien Rossignol. She lies and says that he is sick and needs someone to care for him. She then asks Beck if he will give her a pass so that she can take the train to go to her father. Beck promises to get her one. Later, when Beck is gone, Vianne asks Isabelle about their father's health. Isabelle admits to lying but then tells another lie. She claims that she's been sneaking out to see a boy who is now going to Paris. She tells Vianne that she wants to go to Paris to be with this boy. Vianne immediately believes Isabelle because the story matches what she has thought all along. Isabelle is disappointed that her sister thinks so little of her.

Here, Isabelle lies to get what she wants. In another show of kindness, Beck promises to get her a train pass. Beck probably thinks that, if nothing else, it is safer for everyone involved to have Isabelle out of the house. Meanwhile, Isabelle is simultaneously glad and upset that Vianne believes her lie. The lie is a test that Vianne simultaneously passes and fails, but as it turns out, Vianne thinks of Isabelle exactly the way Isabelle predicted.



CHAPTER 14

The perspective shifts forward to April 1995. The unnamed narrator is sitting in a car that is driving along the Oregon Coast. Her seatbelt is making her uncomfortable. She thinks about how her generation was never concerned with objects like seatbelts because they didn't expect to be shielded from the dangers of the world. She recalls all the dangers she experienced while driving when she was younger; she knew the risks and took them anyway.

This is the first time the novel returns to the 1995 plot, but the book still withholds the identity of the narrator. This passage gives more insight into her past, though: it seems that she's been in a lot of dangerous situations in her life and doesn't feel that she needs something as simple as a seatbelt to keep her safe.



The narrator is in the car because her son, Julien, is taking her to her new home in a retirement community. When they arrive at the retirement community, Julien shows the narrator to her new room. He also tells her that she is always welcome to come live with him if she does not like it here. The narrator refuses, thinking that the retirement community will suffice. She knows her death is coming, and she is aware of how much it will hurt Julien.

Julien gives the narrator her mail, which includes a letter from Paris. The letter is an invitation to a gathering of *passeurs*—people who saved others during World War II. The narrator does not want to go to the gathering. If she does, she knows she will have to think about all of the terrible things she had to do in order to survive. She also mentions a man she killed during wartime, although she does not specify the man's identity.

CHAPTER 15

It's 1941, and Isabelle is on her way to Paris. Vianne, meanwhile, is alone with Sophie and Beck. One day, Beck brings Vianne a fish he caught and presents it to her as a gift. Vianne is unsure whether she should take it. She doesn't want to owe Beck another favor. Seeing that Vianne is hesitant, Beck assures her that he got the fish by legitimate means. Eventually, Vianne accepts the fish and begins prepping it for dinner.

When Vianne finishes cooking, she brings the fish to the table and sees that Beck is sitting in the same chair that Antoine always used. When Beck sees that the fish is ready, he offers Vianne an expensive bottle of wine, which she accepts. As Sophie, Beck, and Vianne eat together, Vianne notices that Beck is talking more than normal. She realizes that this might be because Isabelle is gone so there is less tension in the house.

Meanwhile, Isabelle arrives in Paris with her bicycle. When she gets off the train, she bikes to Julien Rossignol's store. Isabelle reaches the store and finds it in chaos; it looks like it is closed down and has not been tended to as of late. Concerned, Isabelle heads to her father's apartment, only to find out that he is not there, either. Not knowing where else to go, Isabelle makes herself comfortable and decides to wait for her father to come home. While she waits, she thinks about the best way to convince Julien to let her stay.

This passage gives more insight into the narrator's personality. She seems to care a lot about other people and doesn't want to burden her son or anyone else—this is why she insists that the retirement community will suffice as a nice and quiet place to die. She thinks about her death often but is not scared of it; if anything, she worries about how it will impact her loved ones.



Here, more details come out about the narrator's past. Apparently, she killed a man in the war and witnessed other terrible events. Assuming the narrator is either Vianne or Isabelle, then at least one of them will kill someone before the story ends.



Vianne has to reevaluate what she thinks about Beck constantly. Although she wants to like and appreciate him, she can't get over the incident with the list, and she doesn't want to have to perform more uncomfortable favors for Beck in the future.



Again, Beck is seemingly filling Antoine's role, which Vianne notices but does not remark upon. Without Isabelle, the Mauriacs and Beck almost behave like a typical, happy family.



Julien's life has radically changed since Isabelle went away. It seems he is no longer tending to the store he once loved, and this underscores the devastating effects of war.



Later, Julien Rossignol comes home and sees Isabelle. Immediately, he is angry. When Isabelle tells him that she would like to live with him, Julien tells her that she shouldn't have left Vianne and Sophie alone with a Nazi. He tells Isabelle that she must go back to Carriveau immediately. However, Isabelle refuses. She tells Julien that Paris is her home, and she plans to live there no matter what he says.

The conversation turns to Julien Rossignol's current job. Since he is not running the bookstore anymore, Isabelle wants to know what he is doing. Julien tells Isabelle that he is working for the Germans at the Hotel de Crillon. This news deeply angers Isabelle. In her eyes, yet another one of her family members is aiding and abetting the Nazis. She tells Julien that he is cowardly. In response, Julien tells her that she cannot judge him because she doesn't know the full details of his past. Additionally, he says that if Isabelle wants to stay in Paris, then she must follow all of his rules. Also, she must find a job. Although she is disappointed with her father, Isabelle promises to do what he says.

After speaking with Julien Rossignol, Isabelle goes and looks at her old room. Everything is just as she left it, although it clearly hasn't been tended to in a while. Next door, Isabelle can hear Julien drinking and swearing. Isabelle knows that Julien is not happy that she is here, but she is proud of herself for standing her ground. While listening to her father next door, Isabelle reflects on her relationship him. She feels as though he resents her no matter what she does.

Moments later, Julien Rossignol knocks on Isabelle's door and tells her he is leaving. While he is gone, he wants her to pick up his daily rations. Isabelle agrees to do as Julien says. After Julien leaves, Isabelle realizes that she needs to complete the mission she was sent to Paris to do. She gets dressed and then leaves with a handbag, which contains the secret message.

Next, Isabelle walks to the agreed-upon meeting place. Isabelle is nervous; she knows that any mistake could result in her death. She sits down on a bench, just as she was told to do. Right after she sits down, a woman comes and sits down next to her. Isabelle, says, "Do you think I'll need an umbrella today?" This phrase is a secret code, which the woman sitting next to Isabelle responds to correctly. Isabelle realizes that she has found the right woman, so she attempts to give her the secret message. However, the woman stops her and says that they should go to a café before anything is exchanged.

Julien's response is exactly what Isabelle expected. But Isabelle doesn't tell her father the truth and instead lets him think poorly of her, just like she did with Vianne. Isabelle's behavior here shows that she is maturing; she has more discretion and no longer says whatever is on her mind.



As it turns out, Isabelle left one Nazi-supporting household for another. She is deeply ashamed of her family and cannot understand why they do not resist authority as she does. It's especially hard for her to accept this behavior from Julien, who fought the Germans in World War I. In Isabelle's mind, he is supporting the people who crushed his spirit and destroyed their family. Nonetheless, Isabelle knows that she has to make it work with her father; she has no other choice.



Julien's demons have not gone away; he still drinks and has a foul temper. However, Isabelle has changed; she's matured, and for the first time, she does not let her father stand in the way of what she wants to do. Unfortunately, their relationship remains broken.



Julien and Vianne treat Isabelle the same way; she is their errand girl who must stay out of trouble. Isabelle is happy to perform this role, however, because it gets her out of the house where she can help the French rebellion.



This is the most dangerous mission Isabelle has taken on yet, and she is inexperienced. However, she seems to have identified the right woman, and the fact that the conversation takes place in code gives her further protection. Isabelle slips up by trying to hand off the secret message publicly. However, her interlocuter ensures that doesn't happen as yet another security measure.



Isabelle and her new colleague get up and go to a nearby café. There, Isabelle gives the woman the secret message. The woman thanks Isabelle and warns her that she must be wary of French people who are working for the Germans. She tells Isabelle that she shouldn't trust anyone, even her own father. Additionally, she informs Isabelle that the other members of the resistance group want to meet her. She gives her a place and a time when that can happen. Satisfied with her success, Isabelle gets up and leaves the café. She feels like she is doing something meaningful to fight back against the Nazis.

Yet again, Isabelle is warned not to trust anyone. Indeed, throughout World War II, many French citizens and members of law enforcement worked for the Germans—it was the only way to survive for some people.



CHAPTER 16

Life is less stressful for Vianne now that Isabelle is in Paris. However, she feels lonelier than ever, and she is worried about what will happen once her money is gone. Soon, she will have to rely on only her teaching salary, which is not enough to get by. One day, Vianne takes Sophie into town for their daily rations where they see a “No Jews Allowed” sign hanging over the butcher’s shop. Sophie asks Vianne to explain the sign, but Vianne doesn’t answer her. When Vianne gets to the front of the line, she sees that the normal shop owner, Madame Fournier, is not handing out the rations. Madame Fournier is Jewish, and so another woman has replaced her.

Although some of Vianne’s problems have disappeared, more always pop up. Additionally, German displays of antisemitism are growing more blatant. Sophie, who grew up around Jewish people, does not understand antisemitism or its significance to the Nazis. Vianne doesn’t know how to explain such a concept to her daughter, so for now, she says nothing.



When Vianne and Sophie return home, Sophie is angry with her mother. She doesn’t understand how someone could take over Madame Fournier’s shop and is mad at Vianne for not doing anything about it. Vianne tries to reason with Sophie. She reminds her that French people are often executed for standing up to the Germans. Sophie realizes that her mother is right and then says that she misses Antoine. To cheer Sophie up, Vianne decides that it would be a good day to make pickles. She sends Sophie to the garden to gather cucumbers. While Sophie harvests food from the garden, Vianne worries about how they will survive the upcoming winter.

Because Sophie does not understand the gravity of the situation, her mother’s passivity frustrates her. She knows Isabelle would have stood up to the Germans and is ashamed of her mother for not doing the same. Like Isabelle, Sophie doesn’t yet understand the consequences of rebellion. Instead, Vianne tries to calm her daughter down by suggesting a fun activity that will distract them from the horrors of their current situation.



Inside, Vianne sees Beck reading in the living room. When Beck spots Vianne, he immediately notices that she is upset. He asks her if she is having a hard time because Isabelle is gone, and he notes that he regularly hears her walking around at night. In response, Vianne tells him that if he hears her walking around, then he must not be sleeping well either. Beck admits that this is the case; he also misses his family and does not like that the war has gone on for so long.

This interaction between Vianne and Beck humanizes them to each other. They share similar problems and concerns, even though they are on different sides of the war. Although Vianne does not fully trust Beck, she does not think he is fundamentally bad and is glad they share the same struggles.



Luckily, Beck has some good news for Vianne. He has gotten his hands on a letter from Antoine, which he gives her. The letter is short and reassuring. Antoine says that he is doing alright and only asks that Vianne send him his gloves because winter will be coming soon. The letter makes Vianne overjoyed, and she reads it repeatedly.

Back in Paris, Isabelle is preparing herself for her first meeting with her fellow resistance members. She does everything she can to make herself inconspicuous. She dresses up like a schoolgirl and plans to tell anyone who questions her that she is going to meet a boy. After leaving Julien's apartment, Isabelle goes to the agreed-upon meeting place. There, a man approaches her and speaks to her in code. Isabelle responds appropriately, and the man leads her down several streets. He asks her to close her eyes so she won't know exactly where they are going. Isabelle does as the man asks.

Eventually, Isabelle ends up in a poorly lit room where several people have gathered. As Isabelle looks around, she sees a man named Levy who used to regularly shop at Julien Rossignol's bookstore. Also in the room is Anouk, the woman to whom Isabelle previously delivered the secret message. Levy knows Isabelle's childhood reputation and warns her that she could get herself and others killed if she joins the resistance group. In response, Isabelle tells Levy that she is perfect for the cause because no one would expect her.

Isabelle's reasoning is sound. After a short discussion, the others admit her into the group. Levy warns Isabelle that she cannot tell anyone what she is doing. Then, Anouk gives her a package to deliver. As Anouk explains what Isabelle needs to do with the package, an RAF pilot is escorted through the room. Isabelle knows they would all be killed if the Germans discovered they were hiding the pilot. Because Isabelle speaks English, she is able to help the pilot communicate with her French colleagues. She promises the pilot that the resistance will do everything it can to help him, which seems to put him at ease. Afterward, the pilot is taken to a room in the back of the building.

Isabelle, Anouk, and Levy return to their conversation about Isabelle's new position in the resistance. Levy asks Isabelle how they can contact her in the future. In response, Isabelle tells him that she is going to reopen her father's bookstore. That way, the resistance can come and find her at any point in the day without standing out. Additionally, Isabelle tells Levy that her father is working with the Nazis. Levy nods like he already knows, and the two of them agree that Julien Rossignol's position is a sad state of affairs.

Antoine's letter is the first good news that Vianne has had in a long time. However, one wonders whether Antoine is truthful in what he says. The Nazis were notorious for censoring letters, and even if they haven't censored Antoine's letter, it's possible he may not want to tell Vianne the truth anyway.



Again, Isabelle uses her gender to her advantage, emphasizing her youth and femininity to ensure her safety.



Finally, Isabelle gets a good look at some of her coconspirators, and, as it turns out, she sees some familiar faces. Although Levy is wary of Isabelle, Isabelle is right to point out that because she is a young woman, she can be a valuable asset to the resistance—her previous experience has shown this to be true.



An RAF pilot is a "Royal Air Force" Pilot, a member of the British air force. During World War II, enemy troops regularly shot down and captured pilots. In this case, the resistance captured the pilot before the Germans could, and as such, they are looking for a way to get him home and back in action. Historically, similar operations occurred throughout France and other Nazi-occupied countries like Italy.



Isabelle's idea is brilliant; opening the bookstore allows the resistance constant access to her without raising suspicion. The only difficulty will be convincing Julien of the plan without letting him in on what she is up to. After all, his current position means he might be willing to turn his daughter in to the Nazis.



Levy and Anouk reiterate that Isabelle's life will be extremely dangerous from now on. Anouk warns Isabelle about the special punishments that exist for women whom the Nazis catch. Although Anouk does not specify, Isabelle senses what she has in mind. Additionally, the others tell Isabelle that if the Nazis catch her, then she must do her best to not give away any vital information for at least two days. This will give the other resistance members a chance to hide and change their center of operations.

When Isabelle goes home, she tells Julien Rossignol that she plans to reopen his shop. At first, Julien is angry, but Isabelle reminds him that she promised to get a day job. She thinks she will have no problem selling books to the Germans and bringing in some additional money. Julien agrees to let her reopen the shop on the condition that she does not open a room in the back of the store. Apparently, there is something important in the room, which he does not want touched. Isabelle agrees to his terms, but not before insinuating that he uses the backroom to have sex with women. Disgusted, Julien tells Isabelle that he is glad her mother isn't alive to see how she behaves.

The "special punishments" that Anouk alludes to almost certainly entail sexual abuse. Although being a woman in the does have some benefits—enemies are less likely to suspect women of resistance activity, for instance—there are also many pitfalls, as Anouk suggests here. Although two days do not seem like a long time, the Nazis are not above physical, emotional, and sexual torture, and Anouk knows this.



Isabelle's plan is great because it satisfies her father's demands and those of the resistance. However, it's clear that Julien is hiding something from Isabelle. Whatever Julien is hiding, it is not what Isabelle insinuates. However, her insinuation only further damages their crumbling relationship.



CHAPTER 17

In Carriveau, Vianne is leading her students through a normal day of lessons. Suddenly, Nazi soldiers enter the school to arrest a male teacher for distributing propaganda. Concerned for her colleague, Vianne attempts to question the Nazi leading the teacher away. In response, the Nazi turns his gaze on Vianne and asks her if she is colluding with the other teacher. Vianne tells him she is not. The Nazi does not arrest Vianne, but he does fire her from teaching, simply because she asked questions. The decision comes as a shock to Vianne, and she doesn't know what she will do without her job.

Vianne goes home and, for a moment, considers writing to Antoine to tell him what is going on. However, she realizes that doing so would be selfish; Antoine is in no position to help her, and she would only be making his situation worse. Not long after, Beck arrives at the house and informs Vianne that he will be away for a few weeks because he is going home to visit his family. Beck is excited to go home but admits to Vianne that he is not the same person he was when the war started. Vianne understands what he means.

This is an important moment for Vianne's character development; she's gradually less content to submit to authority. At this point in the novel, the Nazis have made clear what happens to people who distribute propaganda: they die. Vianne knows this and does what she can to help her colleague. It is a bold act that could result in her death if she is not careful. Although the Nazi does not go that far, he does fire Vianne, essentially severing the last bit of income she has left.



Vianne is in a difficult position; she has no one to support her, and now even Beck is leaving. Although Beck and Vianne have regularly discussed their shared troubles, Beck's departure demonstrates their different situations. Beck gets a chance to see his family; Vianne does not. Nevertheless, Vianne still sympathizes with Beck.



Beck sees that Vianne is upset and asks her what is wrong. Vianne explains that she lost her job at the school. Beck does his best to comfort her, and for a moment, their relationship looks like that of a husband and wife. However, both of them recognize that what they are doing is wrong, and they attempt to disengage. Additionally, Beck promises to take care of Vianne and Sophie through the winter by making sure they have food.

Meanwhile, in Paris, Isabelle has reopened the bookstore. German soldiers regularly stop by to flirt with Isabelle. Isabelle flirts back to keep herself on their good side. One day, while Isabelle is working the counter, Anouk enters the shop and delivers a secret message hidden in a book. The exchange is subtle, and the German soldiers don't notice it. After delivering the message, Anouk leaves, and Isabelle begins to close up shop.

On her way home from work, Isabelle finds an RAF pilot in hiding. Carefully, she approaches him and tells him to meet her in an hour so she can bring him to safety. The pilot does as he is told, and Isabelle takes him to Julien Rossignol's apartment. Then, she hides him in her wardrobe, where Julien will not think to look for him. Before Julien can come home, Isabelle takes the pilot's clothes and throws them into the river so that he won't be identified.

When Isabelle returns to the apartment, she finds that Julien Rossignol is home from work. As such, for the meantime she cannot do anything further to help the pilot. Julien questions Isabelle about where she has been, and Isabelle makes an excuse about working late at the bookstore. Shortly after, Julien hears a noise coming from somewhere in the apartment and begins searching for its source. Isabelle is terrified that Julien will find the pilot, so she does her best to throw him off the scent. Eventually, Julien calms down and stops his search. Isabelle tells him that he is too afraid of everything. In response, Julien tells his daughter that she is not scared enough.

CHAPTER 18

After Julien is in bed, Isabelle opens the wardrobe to speak to the pilot. The pilot tells her that his name is MacLeish. Isabelle promises that she will find a way to get MacLeish back to Britain as long as he does what she says. MacLeish tells Isabelle that she is brave. Isabelle replies that people more often categorize her as foolish. Isabelle gives MacLeish a bucket he can use as a toilet for the night and promises to get him out of the wardrobe as soon as Julien leaves for work the following day.

Again, Beck takes on Antoine's role, and here, for the first time, something genuinely romantic occurs between them. However, neither one acts on their feelings. Still, regardless of how they try to suppress it, the dynamic exists. When Beck returns, he will continue to serve as the man of the house, and he says as much.



As Isabelle expected, the bookstore is a perfect cover for her true plans. Isabelle's beauty transfixes the German soldiers, so they are too distracted to notice what goes on right in front of them.



Isabelle's actions here are brave but dangerous. If anyone sees her with the RAF pilot, including her father, her life could be in danger. Nevertheless, Isabelle decides to do what is right and quickly snaps into action.



Just as Isabelle feared, Julien almost catches the RAF pilot. However, perhaps because he is drunk, Julien stops looking before he can find anything. Clearly, Julien is paranoid, although it is not clear why. After all, he already works for the Nazis, so what should he have to fear? It's increasingly clear that there's something Julien isn't telling Isabelle.



Finally, Isabelle gets a chance to interact with the pilot and form a plan. Like the other men in Isabelle's life, Isabelle's beauty immediately strikes the pilot, and he cannot help but flirt with her. Although flattered, Isabelle cannot shake the dangerous nature of the situation. She knows she must keep MacLeish as quiet as possible, which means he cannot even leave the wardrobe to use the bathroom.



The next morning, once Julien Rossignol is gone, Isabelle goes and steals some of his clothes for MacLeish. MacLeish puts on the clothes, although they do not fit him well. Isabelle is concerned that MacLeish's appearance will give them away, but MacLeish promises her that they will be fine. After all, he managed to stay hidden while wearing a pilot's uniform.

Before leaving the apartment, Isabelle and MacLeish formulate a plan. Isabelle tells MacLeish to leave the apartment first and then follow a block behind her. She wants to ensure that nobody spots them together if MacLeish gets caught and questioned. MacLeish agrees to the plan, and then they put it into action. Although Isabelle is nervous, the plan goes smoothly, and she manages to get MacLeish all the way to the resistance hideout.

When Isabelle and MacLeish enter the hideout, Levy and Anouk chastise Isabelle for being so careless. Isabelle apologizes and then explains that MacLeish needs help getting back to England. Levy and Anouk explain that they currently have no way to get any fighter pilots across the border. Although they considered sending them via the Pyrenees, the route seems impossible. In response, Isabelle tells them the Pyrenees route is possible and that she would like to be the one to lead the pilots over it. She thinks she would be perfect because no one would suspect her.

Just then, a man walks in from the back room, and Isabelle sees that it is Gaëtan. Although Isabelle wants to hate him because he left her with Vianne, she immediately falls in love with him again at first sight. Levy tells Gaëtan about Isabelle's plan, and eventually they decide to go forward with it. Later, Isabelle and Gaëtan get some time alone to speak. Isabelle is upset that he did not reveal himself to her earlier. Gaëtan apologizes but also tells Isabelle that he is the one who recommended that she come to Paris.

After her talk with Gaëtan, Isabelle heads home. There, she finds Julien Rossignol, who reveals that he knows Isabelle hid MacLeish in his apartment. Additionally, he tells her that he knows all about her work with the resistance and her upcoming mission in the Pyrenees. Isabelle is shocked and cannot figure out how her father learned about her work with the resistance.

Isabelle's plan is not perfect, but at this point, she has no other choice. Her father may notice that some of his clothes are missing, but Isabelle will have to explain that away later.



Luckily, Isabelle's plan goes off without a hitch as she and MacLeish safely reach resistance headquarters. However, Isabelle's plan was reckless, and she is unsure how her fellow resistance members will greet her.



Just as Isabelle expected, Levy and Anouk deride her bravery and instead treat it as foolishness. Although Levy and Anouk are happy she saved the RAF pilot, her actions could have cost them all their lives. Furthermore, another RAF pilot is just another problem for the resistance. However, Isabelle has other ideas. This passage is a significant moment for her character because it is the first time she actively engages in scheming alongside the resistance.



As his note suggested, Gaëtan never lost interest in Isabelle. He simply thought that, for the time being, it would be better if Isabelle didn't join the resistance. However, he obviously believes in Isabelle, which is why he recommended she come to Paris.



Isabelle has been careless, but not so careless that Julien would know all the details of her work. Could it be that Julien, too, is involved with the resistance?



Then, Julien Rossignol reveals that he has been working with the resistance all along. His work for the Nazis is only a cover he uses so that he can access their resources to forge papers. In fact, Julien wrote all the pamphlets that Isabelle delivered in Carriveau. Additionally, Julien tells Isabelle that he has a connection, Micheline Babineau, who can help her with her upcoming trip through the mountains. Isabelle is overjoyed to learn that her father is on her side. Meanwhile, Julien fears for his daughter's safety.

This moment is the first significant plot twist in the novel. Not only was Julien not working for the Nazis, but he has been working alongside Isabelle the whole time—she just didn't know it.



CHAPTER 19

While walking around Paris, Isabelle sees a notice that warns against aiding enemy airmen. Apparently, anyone who does so will be killed. Isabelle thinks about how she is fortunate to be a woman. No one suspects anything of her, which allows her to move around in shadows, unseen. At this point, Isabelle has been given a false identity—Juliette Gervais—as well as a codename: **the Nightingale**.

Isabelle regularly sees signs that tell her to do the exact opposite of what she's currently doing. Luckily, Isabelle manages to get away with more than the average resistance member because she is a woman and nobody suspects her. Additionally, this passage reintroduces the name "Juliette Gervais," a name first mentioned at the beginning of the novel. Although this detail does not confirm that Isabelle and the narrator are the same person, it does tilt the reader in that direction. Also, this passage is the first direct mention of the book's title: The Nightingale. Literary tradition portrays nightingales as noble but tragic birds. This could suggest that Isabelle's story will end tragically.



Isabelle boards a train headed for Spain. Separately, several pilots also get on the train. All of them have been given false identities and were taught how to not draw attention to themselves. Isabelle watches the pilots nervously whenever she gets the chance, and all of them do exactly what they were told. For her part, Isabelle spends the train ride flirting with German soldiers so they will not suspect that she is doing anything illegal. Isabelle gets dirty looks from French people for her behavior, but she does her best to ignore them.

Isabelle's mission shares similarities with real historical accounts. Indeed, the book is based on true accounts of pilots who escaped via the Pyrenees. Here, as always, Isabelle utilizes her femininity to remain inconspicuous. She knows her countrymen and countrywomen will not receive her behavior well, but she appease the German soldiers to maintain her cover.



Eventually, the train stops in the mountains where Isabelle and the pilots get off. There, Isabelle finds Madame Babineau and speaks to her about her mission. At first, Isabelle is cautious not to reveal too much about herself or the pilots. Eventually, however, she decides she has no choice but to trust Madame Babineau and tells her the whole truth. Madame Babineau tells Isabelle that she knows someone who can guide her through the mountains.

Several times throughout the novel, Isabelle has to risk telling the truth to save lives. She does something similar when she gets caught defacing the propaganda poster earlier in the story. Luckily, in both cases, Isabelle's intuitions are correct, and she saves many lives as a result.



However, when Isabelle steps out of the room where she and Madame Babineau are speaking, she is immediately shoved up against a wall. A man with foul breath questions her aggressively about her mission. Unsure whether or not the man is her enemy, Isabelle refuses to give up any information. Eventually, the man lets her go and then introduces himself as Eduardo. Madame Babineau tells Isabelle that Eduardo will be her guide through the Pyrenees.

After eating dinner, Isabelle goes to bed, only for Madame Babineau to wake her up in the middle of the night. Madame Babineau gives Isabelle coffee and then readies her for her journey through the mountains. The journey itself is just as terrible as Isabelle was warned it could be. The weather is terrible, and Isabelle does everything she can to keep up morale.

Eventually, Isabelle, Eduardo, and the pilots get to the Spanish border. However, to get to safety, they must cross a perilous-looking rope bridge. To give the men confidence, Isabelle lies and says that she's used the bridge many times. Her lie helps, and all the men cross the bridge safely. When they reach Spain, Eduardo compliments Isabelle on her performance and promises to help her again whenever she needs him. Then, Isabelle and the pilots find the nearest consulate and report what they've done. When they arrive, the man Isabelle speaks to can hardly believe that she is telling the truth.

CHAPTER 20

Luckily, Isabelle does not have to cross the mountains to get back to France. Instead, she is able to take a train. Doing so doesn't attract attention, and Isabelle has no problem making it back to Paris. On the train ride home, Isabelle is proud of herself. She feels that she has finally matured and done something meaningful with her life. Back in Paris, Isabelle thinks that Gaëtan is following her, although she is never able to spot him. She loves Gaëtan and wants to be with him, but she knows that love could get her killed.

Meanwhile, back in Carriveau, Vianne is having a difficult winter. She has almost run out of food, and there is no wood left to burn for warmth. Beck has been away, so Vianne has no guarantee that she will have resources to take care of Sophie. Although Beck's presence can be uncomfortable, Vianne prefers it when he is around. Desperate, Vianne takes her mother's pearls from Isabelle's secret stash and pawns them off so she can buy food. At this point, Vianne realizes that Isabelle was completely right when she decided to make the stash under the barn. She is angry with herself for being so hard on her sister.

Just when Isabelle thinks she is safe, she is suddenly thrust right back into danger. However, she refuses to give herself up. But, as it turns out, Eduardo's behavior is simply a test, and Isabelle passed because she did not give up any information.



As the group's leader, Isabelle acts stronger than she actually feels inside. In this moment, she becomes a leader of men, a title few women could claim in the 1940s.



Here, Isabelle uses the men's casual misogyny to help save their lives. She suggests that if a woman could cross the bridge many times, they should have no problem doing it once. Her trick works and impresses Eduardo, who swears his loyalty to her mission. The mission's extreme nature is apparent to the man at the consulate, and it is only at this point that Isabelle realizes the extent of her achievement.



The novel glosses over the details that allow Isabelle to travel freely back to France. However, her connections with the resistance and her gender make it possible. Isabelle correctly identifies her trip as a crucial step in her maturation process. Additionally, her reunion with Gaëtan is yet another step in her coming-of-age journey. Now that she is a fully grown woman, she is looking for romance.



Isabelle feels good about herself while Vianne continues to struggle for survival. Although Beck promised to take care of Vianne and Sophie, there is only so much he can do while he's away. Although Isabelle is not around to see it, Vianne finally begins to forgive her sister for her reckless behavior.



One day, Vianne wakes up and feels ill. Nonetheless, she decides to take Sophie to church, where they hear a sermon about community and resilience. On the way home from church, Vianne's illness overtakes her, and she falls to the ground outside of her home. Moments later, Beck arrives and takes Vianne into the house. Then, he orders Sophie to fetch Rachel. Beck realizes that Vianne is sick because she has been giving all of her food to Sophie. Together, Beck and Rachel convince Vianne to eat so that she will survive. Vianne's illness makes her sleep for a few days. However, while she is asleep, Beck stays by her side and takes care of her.

Vianne pushes herself to her physical limits until she literally collapses. Luckily, Beck returns just in time to help Vianne. Otherwise, who knows what would have become of her and Sophie. Although he is not perfect, Beck's actions suggest that he may be what he claimed to be all along: a good man on the wrong side of the war.



In Paris, Isabelle continues helping airmen escape to Spain. The airmen regularly flirt with her; she is a sight for sore eyes, especially for the men who do not have a wife back home. Isabelle speaks with the airmen to verify their identities and to discuss the escape route. The men find that Isabelle's presence is a great boost for morale.

Isabelle is the first female face that many of the RAF pilots have seen in months. Her feminine energy helps them survive what is otherwise the most unpleasant situation of their lives.



Spring finally arrives, and Vianne spends a good deal of time in the garden. Although the weather is better, the Nazis have only grown worse. Not long after the start of spring, Sarah shows up at Vianne's house and asks her if she will talk to Rachel. Sarah knows something is wrong, but she is not sure what. Vianne heads to Rachel's house immediately to check on her friend.

As always, Vianne stops what she is doing and immediately moves to help her best friend. Throughout the novel, Rachel exhibits strength, meaning that something must be deeply wrong if Sarah is summoning Vianne for help.



Vianne arrives at Rachel's house to find her friend distraught. Rachel explains that she is upset because she was given yellow stars that she and her children are expected to wear because they are Jewish. Rachel doesn't want to explain to Sarah why she must wear the star, but she knows she has to. She calls Sarah into the room, and Sophie comes in with her. Rachel then tells Sarah that she must wear the yellow star from now on. Not wanting her friend to feel singled out, Sophie offers to wear a star as well. However, Rachel tells Sophie that she cannot. Watching this interaction fills Vianne with sadness.

The Nazis' antisemitism intensifies and creates more serious repercussions for the Jewish people of Carriveau. The stars single out Jewish people so the Nazis can identify them at a moment's notice. Rachel worries about the implications of the star but knows she must force Sarah to wear one anyway; the war leaves her with no other option but to put her child in danger.



CHAPTER 21

Summer arrives, and with it comes incredibly hot temperatures. The heat makes Sophie sick, and she runs a high fever. Vianne is upset that she doesn't have medicine to help Sophie and doesn't know where to get any. Sophie's cries draw Beck's attention. He comes into Sophie's room and gives Vianne a bottle of antibiotics to help treat Sophie's illness. Vianne knows that the antibiotics will cost her something in the future but feels that she has to accept Beck's offer.

Although Vianne doesn't want to rely on Beck, she realizes that there is nothing else she can do. Vianne cares more about Sophie's life than anything else in the world. Meanwhile, Beck continues to act as a provider for the Mauriacs. He gets Sophie the medicine she needs and nurses her back to health.



Meanwhile, Isabelle continues her resistance efforts. After yet another successful trip across the Pyrenees, she arrives at the Spanish consulate. Unfortunately, this time one of the airmen did not make it across the border without being arrested because he failed to follow Isabelle's orders. Apparently, he did not respect her enough because she is a woman. Nonetheless, Isabelle's contact in Spain is impressed. Over the past several months, Isabelle has escorted 87 men across the border. Isabelle is warned that she is doing too much and that the Nazis are looking for her. Of course, they do not know Isabelle's real name; they only know her as **the Nightingale**. Although Isabelle knows that Ian is right, she rejects his warning and plans to continue her missions.

Despite the sense of accomplishment that she feels every time she completes a mission, Isabelle is not completely happy. She misses Vianne and Sophie and has regrets about how she treated Vianne when staying in her home. Unfortunately, Isabelle cannot visit Vianne and Sophie because doing so would put them both in harm's way.

When Isabelle returns to Paris, Anouk approaches her and tells her about a new job. Apparently, the Germans are looking for French women to help them with a secret clerical job. By pulling some strings, Levy managed to get Isabelle a position. He wants her to go and figure out what the Germans are working on. That night, Isabelle heads to German headquarters to perform her new job. On the way there, a German soldier stops her. However, he lets her go once she explains where she is headed.

When Isabelle arrives at the German headquarters, she is handed a box of cards, each of which contains a name. Her job is to separate the names into two piles: one pile for foreign-born Jewish people and one pile for Jewish people born in France. Shocked, Isabelle begins sorting the names. However, before long, she comes across a card with Levy's name on it. The sight startles her, and she accidentally spills her box of cards. As she picks up her spilled cards, she slyly pockets Levy's card so that the Germans won't have it.

After hiding Levy's card, Isabelle leaves without completing her job. She heads straight for Julien Rossignol's apartment, where the two of them discuss the purpose of the cards. Later that night, someone slides a pamphlet under their door. The pamphlet tells them that the Germans are planning to send all of the Jewish people not born in France to labor camps. This news frightens Isabelle and Julien, and they decide that they need to help their Jewish neighbors hide. Isabelle does her best to help but can only do so much. She doesn't want to draw too much attention to herself and out herself as **the Nightingale**.

Isabelle's numbers are impressive; she saves dozens of lives in a relatively short time. However, Isabelle's success only adds to her risk. But Isabelle doesn't care how risky a mission is—the only thing that matters to her is saving lives. While Isabelle's bravery is commendable, it is also dangerous. Clever though she may be, the Nazis will eventually find the Nightingale if she takes on enough missions. The one thing that works in Isabelle's favor is her gender; the Nazis assume "the Nightingale" is a man.



Vianne and Isabelle both regret how they treated each other. In retrospect, both realize that they were partially in the wrong; Isabelle should have been more cautious, and Vianne should have been more understanding.



Isabelle is always willing to complete whatever task the resistance gives her. And once more, Isabelle's gender works in her favor, making her the perfect candidate for this job.



The German project is just as bad as the resistance expected: it looks like the persecution of Jewish people is about to get much worse. Even Levy is unsafe, although Isabelle tries to protect him by taking his card.



Again, it is essential to remember that the French knew nothing about death camps at this point in the war. Although Isabelle and Julien suspect that the Nazis are up to something terrible, they could never imagine the horrors of Hitler's plan. As always, Isabelle and Julien do the right thing and try to protect those around them. However, there is only so much they can do in the face of overwhelming evil.



CHAPTER 22

Isabelle goes outside to witness what the Germans are doing to the Jewish people of Paris. She watches as the Germans load countless people onto buses, many of whom are women and children. When she asks a nearby French policeman what is happening, the officer warns her to go away and stay low. Apparently, the Nazis have threatened to kill anyone who escapes or tries to help Jewish people in any manner.

In Carriveau, Vianne and Sophie stand in line for rations. After waiting for some time, they get a pittance of cheese and bread, half of which they give to Rachel and Sarah. While Vianne is dropping off the food at Rachel's house, Beck shows up with a warning. He tells Vianne and Rachel that Rachel should make sure she is not at home the following morning. Beck does not elaborate, but he does let Rachel know that her children will be okay because they were born in France. After handing out the warning, Beck leaves. Rachel asks Vianne if they can trust Beck, and Vianne thinks that they can. Vianne decides that it is best to hide Rachel in the secret spot Isabelle made in the barn.

That evening, Vianne gives Sophie a sedative to ensure that she stays asleep. When Vianne goes downstairs, she finds Beck staring at a picture of his family. Clearly, there is a lot on his mind, and he admits to Vianne that he wonders how his family will think of him when the war is over. Vianne tells Beck that she thinks the same thing about how Antoine will view her. Before Vianne can leave to help Rachel, Beck gives her some advice on the safest route out of town.

Vianne meets Rachel at her house, along with Sarah and Ari. Together, they walk through the woods on the path that Beck suggested. Eventually, they reach a checkpoint where a line of people are waiting to walk through a guarded gate. Vianne says goodbye to Rachel, and then Rachel gets in line. Moments later, some sort of disturbance occurs, and a Nazi guard starts indiscriminately firing his machine gun into the crowd. One of the bullets hits Sarah, and she falls to the ground.

Rachel and Vianne recover Sarah's body and head back in the direction of Vianne's home. However, it immediately becomes clear that Sarah is not going to make it. Rachel says goodbye to her daughter and feels the crushing grief of her loss. Vianne knows her friend is still in danger and convinces her to carry on for Ari's sake. Vianne hides Rachel and Ari in Isabelle's secret spot and then goes back to find Sarah's body. Afterward, she buries Sarah next to the other crosses on her property.

This is the novel's first portrayal of the mass deportation of Jewish people, likely to concentration camps. Although modern readers know the grim fate that awaits them, in this scene, no one knows what is happening.



Vianne and Sophie are always underfed, even in the summer months. And Vianne and Sophie are especially hungry because they give half of their food to the de Champlains. In the scene at Rachel's house, Beck reveals his true colors. Although he is a Nazi, he is not heartless and does not want to see Rachel and her children get hurt. Although Beck may not know the details of Hitler's plan, he knows enough to be worried for Rachel's sake. Of course, if any Germans learned he had warned Rachel, Beck's actions could cost him his life.



Beck uses the picture of his family to comfort him. He knows the Nazis are carrying out evil acts, but he must follow orders if he ever wants to return to his wife and child. Beck's position is not enviable, even if it is preferable to that of Vianne or Rachel.



With Beck's help, Vianne helps the de Champlains escape Carriveau, presumably to get them to the Free Zone of France. Sarah's seeming death is the first death that has affected Vianne personally. It remains to be seen if it will frighten her back into submission or reinvigorate her urge to fight back.



Sarah's death is the first significant death in the book. It is especially heartbreaking because Sarah is only a child whose death was obviously avoidable. Vianne knows the pain of losing a child and understands what Rachel feels. As such, she takes it upon herself to be strong, leads Rachel back to safety, and buries Sarah.



CHAPTER 23

After Vianne finishes burying Sarah, she is emotionally and physically exhausted. She wishes that Antoine was by her side so that he could help her make decisions. She no longer trusts herself to keep her loved ones safe in a world that is so cruel and violent. Vianne returns to her home, where she finds Beck, who has waited up for her. Beck seems worried, though he is happy to see Vianne return home safely.

The following day, Vianne and Sophie go into town to run their usual errands. While they are there, Vianne doesn't do anything to let Sophie know that something is wrong. She wants to give her daughter one more morning of innocence before she reveals what happened the night before. Shortly after Vianne and Sophie arrive home, Sophie asks Vianne if she can go spend time with Sarah. At this point, Vianne realizes that she cannot hide the truth from her daughter any longer and tells her what happened. Sarah is devastated and angry when she learns the news. Vianne suggests that they tie some **cloth** around a tree branch right next to where they placed some yarn in honor of Antoine. However, she knows that this gesture will do little to ease Sophie's suffering.

After her talk with Sophie, Vianne goes to the barn and helps Rachel out of the cellar. Rachel needs to use the bathroom, and Vianne thinks that the coast is clear. However, before Rachel can get to safety, French policemen arrest her and put her into a car. Vianne follows the car into town, refusing to leave Rachel's side. After what happened the night before, Vianne can no longer afford to play it safe.

The car takes Rachel to the train station where she is to be sent away. At the train station, Vianne spots Beck clutching a whip. The sight disgusts her. Rachel asks Vianne to take Ari so that he doesn't have to go wherever Rachel is being sent. Vianne knows that taking Ari is the right thing to do, so she agrees. Moments later, Rachel is gone, and Vianne heads home with Ari in her arms. When she arrives, she explains to Sophie what has happened. She also tells her that Ari will stay with them from then on.

Although Beck tries to protect Vianne and her friends, his actions cannot save Sarah. This failure makes Vianne realize how much she needs Antoine. She doesn't know how to live in a world with no love and an extraordinary amount of hate.



Vianne wants to hide the brutal truth from Sophie but knows she cannot do so forever. The events of this scene force Sophie to grow up more than Vianne wants to admit. The tree branch with the cloth in Vianne's yard symbolizes what she lost in the war.



Vianne and Rachel are careful, but they're not careful enough. Notably, it is a French policeman who comes for Rachel, not a German officer. This is because most French law enforcement followed German orders at this time. This moment is a significant turning point for Vianne. Until now, she has kept her head down as much as possible. However, doing so has done her little good, and she realizes that this is a moment where she needs to stand up to the Nazis.



Beck's whip makes him look like someone who is herding animals. Although he may not like his position, he still holds it and so commits morally reprehensible actions, and the thought of this disgusts Vianne. Ultimately, Vianne does the only thing she can do: let Rachel go and take care of Ari. This is the only act of rebellion she can muster.



That evening, Vianne takes some **lace** from her dress and ties it to a tree branch in honor of Rachel. Soon after, Beck shows up, and Vianne treats him callously. Beck tells Vianne that the war has put him in uncomfortable positions as well. He also reminds her that he did his best to save Rachel. Additionally, Beck informs Vianne that they will need to do something about Ari. If they don't, then he will most likely be deported as well. Vianne believes that Beck wants to help her, and for a moment, the two of them seem like they are on the verge of sharing a kiss. However, before anything can happen, Vianne pushes Beck away from her.

Already, Vianne must add more cloth to her tree as she experiences her second loss in as many days. Beck is still a sympathetic character. His complicity bothers Vianne, but as Beck points out, it bothers him too; he is doing what he can to survive, just like her. Again, romantic feelings pass between Beck and Vianne, but they shut these feelings down before they can get too serious.



CHAPTER 24

Summer ends and fall arrives. In Paris, Isabelle is walking to the train station when an air raid siren blares overhead. For a moment, everything goes black, and Isabelle hears screams all around her. However, nothing happens for several minutes, and then the lights come back on. When Isabelle steps toward the train, a German soldier approaches her and questions her. However, before long, he sends her on her way.

Paris is in a state of constant chaos. Between deportations, air raid sirens, and other disturbances, there is rarely a moment when Isabelle is not on edge. Nonetheless, she goes about her business as calmly as possible.



Isabelle meets Anouk in a bistro to deliver her a message. After Isabelle delivers the message, Anouk tells Isabelle that there is an upcoming meeting in Carriveau, and Gaëtan will be there. Isabelle tries to hide her feelings for Gaëtan, but Anouk tells her that she is not fooling anyone. Although love can be dangerous in wartime, Anouk thinks it is a positive thing because it is a reminder of why fighting the good fight is necessary.

Here, one of the book's central themes comes to the forefront: love. Love is a dangerous thing during wartime because of what one can lose. This is a lesson that Vianne already knows—but one that Isabelle is just beginning to learn. Anouk points out the bright side of love, but there is a downside as well.



Isabelle travels to Carriveau for the resistance meeting; there, Henri greets her kindly. Henri tells Isabelle that he's been worried for her safety because the Nazis have recently begun arresting women involved in resistance efforts. Additionally, the name "**the Nightingale**" is known everywhere, and the Nazis are doing everything they can to find him or her. Also, Henri informs Isabelle that Vianne was fired for speaking up to a Nazi officer. Even worse, rumors are swirling around town that Vianne and Beck have started a romance.

Finally, the Nazis discover that women are part of the war effort, making Isabelle's life much more dangerous. Still, the Nazis likely think they are searching for a man. In this passage, Isabelle also learns about Vianne's bravery, which makes her see her sister in a new light.



Meanwhile, Vianne is doing her best to care for Ari, but it's difficult because she cannot take him outside of the house when he has no papers. As Vianne makes dinner, Beck comes home and gives her a gift: a fake birth certificate for Ari with the name Daniel on it. Vianne is grateful to Beck. Even though she wants to pretend that there is nothing between them, she knows that he's taken a giant risk by doing her this favor.

Here Beck makes it clear that he is on Vianne's side. The birth certificate will undoubtedly cost Beck his life if the Nazis discover he gave it to Vianne. Vianne no longer worries that Beck will try to take advantage of her. He has done too much to aid her for his actions to be some sort of trick.



That evening, Vianne tells Ari his new name and tries to get him to play along. Although Vianne feels terrible about it, she realizes that the only way to get Ari to comply is to tell him that Rachel is dead and that she is his new mother. Upon hearing Vianne's lie, Ari cries. However, eventually Vianne gets him to learn his new name.

Vianne tries to act like Ari's new name is all a game, but she needs him to take the name seriously. As such, she tells a terrible but necessary lie. It is a hurtful lie, but it is the only way to keep Ari safe. It is yet another problematic moral decision that the war forces Vianne to make.



CHAPTER 25

On her way to a resistance meeting, Isabelle sees the Allied forces bomb the airfield. She watches as an American fighter pilot goes down, and she takes it upon herself to rescue him. Isabelle quickly locates the pilot and tells him that she intends to rescue him. However, before she can do anything, she hears a group of people coming from behind her. Luckily, the noise belongs to other resistance members who have come to help the pilot as well.

As always, Isabelle jumps into action without thinking of the consequences. She demonstrates great bravery but also extraordinary recklessness. Although her friends show up to help her, the noises she hears could have easily been the enemy. If this was the case, then Isabelle could have lost her life.



Isabelle realizes that they are near Vianne's home, so she decides to take the pilot to her secret hideout in the barn. Because the pilot is badly wounded, she sends Gaëtan and Henri to go get a doctor. Isabelle manages to get the pilot to the barn and then sits there with him in the dark. However, before long, the pilot dies.

Here, Isabelle makes yet another reckless decision. She knows Vianne would never allow the pilot near her home because of what could happen to Sophie if anyone found out. To make matters worse, the pilot dies almost immediately, meaning Isabelle's risk was all for nothing.



The next day, Beck talks to Vianne about the American plane that the Germans shot down. He is irritated because he was tasked with finding the pilot, but he hasn't been able to do so. He begins insulting the French and says that he doesn't understand why they will not help the Nazis when the Nazis have been so kind to them. Vianne doesn't bother to argue with him, and before long, Beck leaves.

Although he has built a lot of goodwill, Beck is less sympathetic than usual in this passage—there is no standard by which the Nazis treated the French people well. Even if Beck himself has been kind, his compatriots have been far from it, and he too is complicit in their inhumane operations.



When Vianne steps outside, she notices that the barn door is open more than it should be. Vianne wonders if Rachel has escaped and managed to hide in the barn. However, when she goes to check and see, all she finds is Isabelle with the dead pilot. Isabelle promises that she will be gone as soon as possible, but Vianne is furious anyway. She thinks that, as usual, Isabelle has put Vianne's life and Sophie's in danger without thinking.

Vianne goes to the barn hoping for a miracle but only finds more trouble. In an instant, all of the goodwill that Isabelle had built up in Vianne's mind vanishes. Instead, Vianne's anger at her sister returns. Once again, she thinks of Isabelle as someone who acts before she thinks and endangers those she loves.



Vianne goes back inside and tries to find ways to occupy her time that don't cause her extra stress. She knows how bad it would be for everyone involved if the pilot was found on her property. She even considers telling Beck the truth. Hours later, Beck returns, more frustrated than ever. He still hasn't found the pilot and the higher-ups in the German army are taking out their frustrations on him.

It doesn't take Beck long to realize that Vianne is agitated about something. Suddenly, he becomes suspicious and begins searching the property for the pilot. Soon, he makes his way to the barn with Vianne following close behind. Beck lifts the cover to Isabelle's hiding spot with a gun in his hand, but as he does so Vianne hits him in the head with a shovel. Simultaneously a gunshot goes off, and a bullet hits Beck in the chest. He falls over dead as Isabelle makes her way out of the hiding spot.

Vianne is distraught over killing Beck. Despite everything, she thinks Beck was a good man, and she is angry with Isabelle for making her kill him. In an attempt to make her sister feel better, Isabelle tells Vianne that it is likely the bullet that killed Beck, not the hit with the shovel. However, Vianne feels guilty, nonetheless.

Before Vianne and Isabelle can figure out what to do next, Henri and Gaëtan arrive with a coffin. Henri promises to get rid of both bodies, but even so the problem of Beck's disappearance remains. Vianne decides that it is best to stay put and pretend that she has no idea what happened to Beck. Her only other choice would be to go into hiding, which would only put her and Sophie in more danger.

As Vianne, Isabelle, and Henri iron out their plan, Isabelle falls to the ground. Although she did not realize it until now, Beck apparently shot her at the same time that she shot him. Vianne tends to the wound and suggests that Isabelle stay with her. However, Henri and Gaëtan have a different plan in mind. They promise Vianne to take good care of Isabelle and then take her away in the coffin they brought with them.

At this point, there is nothing Vianne can do to get out of the bind Isabelle's recklessness has put her in—she must wait and hope that the situation plays itself out without Beck discovering the truth. Vianne does not want to lie to Beck, but Isabelle has left her with no choice. Beck is more stressed than ever because he faces the wrath of the higher-ups in the Nazi party.



Beck has lived with Vianne for a long time, so he quickly realizes something is wrong. Most likely, Beck feels betrayed by Vianne. He has treated her well and even risked his life for her, but she still lies to him. This section ends with a sudden burst of violence from both Vianne and Isabelle. Neither of them wants to hurt Beck, but they have no choice.



Although Beck was not perfect, Vianne still believed he was a fundamentally good person. Her statement here is reminiscent of the one the unnamed narrator made earlier in the novel. Vianne regrets killing Beck, and it would be understandable if this incident haunted her later in life. However, an elderly Isabelle could say the same thing. After all, it is unclear which one of the sisters landed the killing blow. As such, the narrator's identity remains unknown.



The good news is that Isabelle and Vianne have the support of the rebellion to back them up. Although Beck's disappearance will be suspicious, no one will have any reason to suspect Vianne.



Apparently, the incident is even worse than it initially appeared. Isabelle finally receives a severe injury as a result of her actions. In an instant, Vianne forgets her anger at her sister and only cares for her safety. This shows that although their relationship is imperfect, Vianne still deeply loves Isabelle.



CHAPTER 26

It's 1995 on the Oregon Coast. There, the unnamed narrator is sitting and looking at her invitation for the *passeurs* reunion. Next to her, the phone rings. The narrator picks it up and hears a voice speaking in French. The person on the other end of the line asks if the narrator will be coming to the reunion. The narrator responds by saying that the other *passeurs* will want to see Juliette Gervais, who has not existed for a long time. Nevertheless, after she hangs up the phone, the narrator decides that she will go to Paris after all. She begins packing her things and then sends a message to Julien letting him know where she will be. The narrator figures that Julien will worry because he thinks she is old and weak.

Again, the book doesn't reveal the unnamed narrator's identity. The narrator's words are too ambiguous to know if she is Vianne or Isabelle. She says that Juliette Gervais has not existed for a long time. Given that Juliette Gervais was Isabelle's codename during the war, the narrator's statement could mean that Isabelle is dead, or it could mean that she no longer uses that name. In the latter case, Juliette would be symbolically dead rather than literally dead.



CHAPTER 27

Vianne travels with Gaëtan as far as the border, but once there she can go no further. Before she leaves Isabelle in Gaëtan's care, the two of them have a conversation. Gaëtan admits that he loves Isabelle, although he doesn't want Isabelle to know that. Additionally, Vianne expresses that she wishes she hadn't fought so much with her younger sister. At this point, all that matters to Vianne is Isabelle's health and safety. She tells Gaëtan to take good care of Isabelle and to warn her that she needs to start being more careful.

Here the novel once again addresses the theme of love and war. Gaëtan knows the negative cost of falling in love during wartime and that if he lets Isabelle into his life romantically, losing her will hurt so much more. Meanwhile, past regrets plague Vianne. She still never has had the chance to tell Isabelle how much she loves her. Instead, every time she sees Isabelle, they end up fighting.



Meanwhile, Isabelle dreams of fire accompanied by the sad song of a **nightingale**. She also sees a prince in a forest, as well as a wolf. For a moment, Isabelle thinks she feels Gaëtan's presence and starts to awaken from her slumber. However, she realizes that this cannot be because she is perpetually alone. This false realization sends her back into deep sleep.

In her dreams, Isabelle hears the bird, which symbolizes herself. The nightingale's sad song foreshadows something tragic in Isabelle's future, as nightingales are associated with tragedy in the literary tradition. However, at least for the moment, Isabelle is not alone. Instead, she is with someone who loves her deeply, which is more than can be said for many people during this tragic time in history.



Back in Carriveau, Vianne contemplates Beck's death. She now knows what it feels like to take a man's life, and it has left her traumatized. Vianne knows that she could have simply chosen to betray Isabelle, but she couldn't bring herself to make that choice. As Vianne contemplates her actions, Sophie walks in. Vianne reminds Sophie that if the Nazis come for Vianne, then she is to wait three days before going to a convent for safety.

In some ways, Vianne's situation is the opposite of her sister's. Although Beck was not her lover, he fulfilled a similar role in her life as Gaëtan does in Isabelle's. Here, Vianne realizes that in war, she must sometimes make impossible choices. Neither choice is morally correct, so she must use her intuition to determine the best outcome, even if neither is ideal.



Right after her conversation with Sophie, Vianne hears a loud knock at the door. She opens it to find two Nazi soldiers who have come to question her about Beck. Vianne tells them that she has not seen Beck lately and simply assumed that he was away on official business. The soldiers hear noises upstairs and ask who is there. Vianne explains that her children are upstairs and tells the soldiers that they can go up if they wish. However, she warns them that Ari is sick and implies that he might be contagious. One of the soldiers goes upstairs anyway but comes back down before long.

The other soldier, Von Richter, tells Vianne that she is required to come into town for questioning. Vianne does as he asks. Ultimately, the questioning is not too harsh. Von Richter warns Vianne not to lie to him, but Vianne does so anyway, and Von Richter seems to believe her lies. Additionally, Von Richter informs Vianne that he will be coming to live with her now that Beck is gone.

Vianne leaves Von Richter's office and starts to make her way home. However, almost immediately, she spots a French policeman trying to arrest Madame Fournier and her son. Vianne tries to intervene, but it quickly becomes apparent that there is nothing she can do. The scene is especially upsetting to Vianne because it means that the Nazis are now coming for Jewish people who were born in France, like Ari.

At home, Vianne tells Sophie about Von Richter. Vianne warns Sophie that Von Richter is not as kind as Beck and that she must stay clear of him as much as possible. Additionally, she warns Sophie to be extra careful not to reveal Ari's true identity. To do so would mean the death of their entire family. Just as Vianne finishes up her warnings to Sophie, Von Richter arrives.

CHAPTER 28

Isabelle finally wakes up from her strange dreams to find Gaëtan by her side. All her memories come flooding back to her, and she immediately wants to know if Vianne is okay. Gaëtan assures Isabelle that Vianne is fine. Isabelle wishes there was some immediate way to patch things up with her sister. She assumes that Vianne is still angry with her for bringing danger into her home. She also talks to Gaëtan about how hard it must have been for Vianne to kill Beck.

Not long after Beck's disappearance, Vianne is already in trouble. Although it is unlikely that the Nazis will be able to prove anything, at the very least, Vianne is now under their watchful eye. This presents a particular danger for Ari, which is why Vianne tries to keep the soldiers away from him.



Von Richter is a much more intimidating figure than Beck, and Vianne knows that she could lose her life if she crosses him.



Everywhere she goes, Vianne spots injustice all around her. At this point, the Nazis are rounding up any Jewish people they can find. Although Vianne still does not know what is happening in the Nazi camps, she knows that the lives of her Jewish friends and family are in grave danger.



Here, Vianne must once again break bad news to Sophie. At this point, Sophie is used to hearing bad news and does her best to take it in stride. Although Vianne has tried to shelter Sophie, she knows that that is no longer an option with Von Richter in the house.



Isabelle survives primarily because of Gaëtan's help. In her mind, she has already forgiven Vianne for everything and only wants to know whether she's okay. Isabelle realizes now how reckless her actions were and wishes she could take them back. She also recognizes just how much her sister loves her because of what she was willing to do on her behalf.



Turning her attention to Gaëtan, Isabelle says that love is the only thing that helps her continue fighting. She tells Gaëtan that she wants to be with him, no matter what the cost. She doesn't want to die knowing that they could have been together but weren't because of fear. In response, Gaëtan tells Isabelle that they cannot be together. Isabelle asks him if he would say the same thing if they were not at war. To this question, Gaëtan has no response. Gaëtan's lack of an answer confirms his love for Isabelle, even if he doesn't say anything out loud.

Meanwhile, Beck and Isabelle haunt Vianne's dreams. She feels guilty over her relationships with both parties and, for the time being, she cannot do anything to resolve these feelings. At this point, Vianne sleeps in Beck's old room because Von Richter took over her room upstairs. When Vianne gets up in the morning, she sees Von Richter drinking coffee, a luxury only the Germans have access to. Unlike Beck, Von Richter never shares his privileges with Vianne and Sophie. When Von Richter sees Vianne, he tells her that he will be having guests for dinner and that she must cook for them. Additionally, he warns her to keep Ari away from him and his dinner guests so that they don't get sick. Vianne promises to do as Von Richter wishes, and then she goes back into her room until he leaves.

Meanwhile, Isabelle sits alone and realizes that she is fearful of losing Gaëtan. She knows that either of them could die at any moment, and the realization overwhelms her despite—or perhaps because of—everything that Isabelle has been through. Not wanting to repress her feelings any longer, Isabelle approaches Gaëtan wearing only a towel. Isabelle tells Gaëtan her intentions and then drops her towel. They have sex for the first time.

CHAPTER 29

While Isabelle recovers, she and Gaëtan have sex repeatedly, knowing that they will have to go back to war soon. Despite her fierce love for Gaëtan, Isabelle realizes that she does not know that much about him, especially what his life was like before the war. Nonetheless, Isabelle feels incredibly lucky to have found Gaëtan and tells him so. Gaëtan thinks that they are actually incredibly unlucky to have found each other, but Isabelle refuses to think that way.

Again, Hannah juxtaposes love and war. Love is undoubtedly a positive force, but Gaëtan also fears it. He knows that losing Isabelle would devastate him and that he would be unable to go on fighting. Gaëtan's fear compounds because he knows at least one of them is likely to die before the end of the war because their involvement in the resistance puts them in such dangerous situations.



Previously, Isabelle had few regrets because she was too young to have any. However, her recent experiences have led her to reconsider her actions and how they can create unintended consequences for others. Meanwhile, Vianne's situation has only gotten worse. She already had a hard enough time caring for Sophie and Ari with Beck's help. Now she has no support and is constantly under the watchful eye of a truly evil man.



Despite Gaëtan's initial resistance to the idea, he and Isabelle finally act on their feelings for one another. In this scene, Isabelle once again flouts her traditional gender role and serves as the pursuer in the situation.



Isabelle and Gaëtan's time together is meaningful because they know what they will soon have to return to their work with the resistance. The question of whether Isabelle and Gaëtan are lucky to have their love for each other—or unlucky, since they could so easily lose that love if one of them dies—is important to remember as the novel nears its end.



Meanwhile, in Carriveau, Vianne is getting ready for her worst winter yet. She brings Sophie and Ari into town to get rations, and when she reaches the front of the line, someone asks her about Ari. Vianne lies and says that Ari (whom she calls Daniel) is one of Antoine's cousins who she adopted. She also gets asked about Beck, but she doesn't give up any information. She simply says that he disappeared.

After receiving her rations, Vianne attempts to head home but cannot because the Nazis have barricaded the streets so they can round up more Jewish people. Vianne passes by a scared woman who begs her to take her baby so that he won't share her fate. Vianne makes a split-second decision and takes the child. She decides that she can no longer stand idly by while tragedies happen.

Vianne takes the child home with her and thinks about what to do with him. Sophie tells Vianne that she is frightened; she knows that Von Richter will do something terrible if he finds out what Vianne has done. Vianne agrees but tells her daughter that saving the child was the right thing to do. When Von Richter sees the child, he asks why Vianne has him. Vianne lies and says that the child's mother died from tuberculosis and so he has nowhere to go. In response, Von Richter orders Vianne to take the child to an orphanage. Additionally, he tells her that he will be leaving the following day because the Germans are seizing control of the Free Zone in France.

When Von Richter leaves, Vianne leaves too. Before she goes, she tells Sophie what she is doing. Sophie is proud of Vianne for her bravery and is glad that she is doing the right thing. Vianne brings the child to Mother Superior and asks if there is any way to help him. Mother Superior tells Vianne that she can get the child Baptismal certificates but not identity papers. This is good enough for Vianne, who promises to get the identity papers herself. Mother Superior tells Vianne that this first child she brought is only the beginning; she wants Vianne to keep bringing her children who are fleeing persecution. Additionally, Mother Superior gives Vianne a job teaching at the orphanage, which Vianne can use as cover while also earning some money.

Still, Vianne's life continues its downward spiral. Winter is always the most challenging month for her family, and this winter will be the worst yet. Also, though Vianne does her best to spread lies about Ari, she knows that some people in town know the truth. As such, she can never truly feel safe with Von Richter around.



This moment marks a significant shift in Vianne's character. Throughout the novel, she's loved children, but now she acts on that love and makes the risky decision to take the child rather than watch the Nazis take the child away. With this, Vianne becomes an active member of the rebellion, just like Isabelle.



Vianne knows that if Von Richter discovers the truth, he will hurt her and her children. Vianne cannot let that happen, but she refuses to let the baby boy meet the cruel fate the Germans have in store for him. Luckily, Vianne is used to lying, and Von Richter does not seem to suspect her when she makes up a story about the child. Additionally, Vianne receives a rare stroke of luck because Von Richter is leaving the following day, giving her time to figure out next steps.



Vianne finally feels like she is doing something her daughter can be proud of. Ironically, that same action is putting Sophie in grave danger. Sophie likely realizes this but does not care; she admires her mother for doing the right thing. Vianne takes the child to the only place she knows to go: the church. Indeed, her instincts were right; Mother Superior has a plan in mind, and Vianne is a central part of it. In Italy and France, churches were commonly involved in resistance efforts during World War II.



CHAPTER 30

Isabelle and Gaëtan travel to Bayonne and openly behave as a couple on vacation so as not to attract attention from the German soldiers. At one point, they reach a roadblock where they learn that the Nazis are taking over the Free Zone. Luckily, Isabelle and Gaëtan make it through the roadblock without much issue, but they know that Isabelle's life has just become more dangerous. If the Nazis are taking over the Free Zone, then it will be easier for them to patrol Isabelle's route through the Pyrenees.

Isabelle and Gaëtan make it to Madame Babineau's cottage. There, they find three pilots waiting for **the Nightingale** to escort them. Madame Babineau catches Isabelle up to speed and hands her a letter from Henri that gives a status update on Vianne. After observing Isabelle and Gaëtan's body language, Madame Babineau quickly realizes that they are in love and tells them to be careful—she knows that love is dangerous in a time like this. In the evening, Gaëtan breaks some bad news to Isabelle. He tells her that he will be leaving to join a militant group where he will be setting explosives. Although he thinks that this is the right thing to do, he is sad that he won't see Isabelle again for quite some time, if ever. Isabelle understands and tells Gaëtan to do what he has to do.

In Carriveau, Vianne tracks down Henri and asks him if he can get identity papers for the child she rescued. Henri tells Vianne that he can help her and that she reminds him of Isabelle. In response, Vianne says that she is not brave like Isabelle. However, Henri disagrees and says that Isabelle would be proud of her.

Several days later, Vianne goes into town to collect the identity papers from Henri. Henri hides the papers in a loaf of bread so that no one will see them. He also tells Vianne to come back any time she needs more papers. Vianne promises that she will and then walks home. On her way, she runs into Von Richter, who insists on carrying her breadbasket for her. Vianne is worried about what will happen if Von Richter finds the papers, so she starts coughing and pretends to be ill. Not wanting to get sick, Von Richter rudely gives the basket back to Vianne and makes her carry it herself. Additionally, Von Richter informs Vianne that he will not be eating dinner with her.

Because Von Richter is not around, Vianne uses the evening to fill in the identity papers. Additionally, she creates a record where she can keep track of all the children who were separated from their parents during the war. She knows that such a file will be important when the war is over if the children ever hope to be reunited with their parents.

Again, Isabelle's risk factor increases, which only worries Gaëtan more. He has finally consummated his relationship with Isabelle, and now it feels like she could be taken away from him at any moment. However, Isabelle knows the risks and does nothing to change her behavior.



Because Isabelle was out of commission for a while, several pilots are already waiting for her when she returns to Madame Babineau's cottage. Madame Babineau gives Isabelle and Gaëtan the same advice that others have given them before: love can cause more harm than good during wartime. Most likely, Gaëtan knew that he would be leaving to join the militant group, which is why he was hesitant to act on his feelings for Isabelle.



Vianne knows Henri because he was there the night Beck died. Although that was a tragic night for Vianne, she now has an ally who can help her with her new operation. Also, Henri kindly gives Vianne some words of encouragement she desperately needs.



Vianne's actions here are not unlike Isabelle's at the beginning of the book. Her new job is regularly going into town and collecting illicit papers for the good of the resistance. However, in this case, Vianne is distributing new identities to Jewish children who desperately need them to stay alive rather than distributing pamphlets. Luckily, Von Richter is too self-absorbed to catch on to what Vianne is doing.



Again, Von Richter's absence proves useful for Vianne, and she uses the time wisely. In this scene, Vianne expresses a similar level of foresight as Isabelle. Her list is an excellent idea that will indeed be necessary once the war ends.



CHAPTER 31

The narrator returns to 1995 in Oregon. Currently, the unnamed narrator is sitting in an airport, waiting for her plane to France. She strikes up a conversation with a young, tattooed girl sitting next to her. The narrator tells the girl that she is either running away from something or finally returning to what she ran away from; she is not sure which. In response, the tattooed girl says that she is running away as well.

Just before the narrator's plane starts boarding, Julien shows up and tells his mother that he is going to Paris with her. At this point, the narrator realizes there is nothing she can do to stop him. Together, they board the plane, and Julien helps his mother with her luggage. Although she is glad for her son's help, the narrator feels that she must always appear strong in front of him because that is a mother's job. As Julien sits down next to his mother on the plane, he asks her what she is hiding from him. He knows that there is something that she wants to tell him but won't. The narrator tells Julien that she doesn't want to talk about it yet.

The narrator's identity remains unclear. Because Isabelle and Vianne have such traumatic pasts, it is unclear which of them would be running away from something. Both options are equally plausible.



Here, the narrator realizes she can no longer hide her identity from her son; even if she can't tell him herself, their trip to Paris will bring whatever details she's hiding to the surface. Her love for Julien further complicates her journey toward coming to terms with her past.



CHAPTER 32

The perspective shifts back to 1944. Isabelle is in Paris with Julien Rossignol. When Isabelle looks at her father, she realizes that he's aged greatly in the past few years. Julien is worried about Isabelle, and he asks her to take a break from transporting pilots—he worries that she is taking too many trips and will be caught soon. Isabelle deflects her father's fears, arguing that he would never give a man the same advice. Julien asks Isabelle if she wants to stay with him, but Isabelle declines, thinking it would be too great a risk. He also asks for an update on Vianne. Isabelle tells him what she knows and promises him that she has people watching Vianne and Sophie.

That night, Isabelle has a secret rendezvous with Gaëtan, whom she has not seen in some time. Gaëtan is part of a guerilla group known as the Maquis. Isabelle only gets to see Gaëtan briefly so that she can hand him a message, but it is nonetheless a meaningful exchange. Isabelle knows that Gaëtan is afraid to express his feelings for her because it is increasingly likely that one of them will die soon. Nonetheless, Isabelle knows that he loves her.

In this scene, Isabelle notices the physical effects of the war on her father's face. Though Julien's fears are understandable, Isabelle refuses to back down, suggesting that Julien is more afraid for her because she's a woman. This notion may or may not be accurate, but that doesn't mean that the danger is any less real.



If only for a brief moment, Isabelle and Gaëtan's brief reunion gives Isabelle the strength to go on. It's not much, but it's all she can ask for at this point in the war.



Meanwhile, in Carriveau, Vianne has continued to help Jewish children escape Nazi persecution. She has hidden 13 children at the orphanage. One day, Von Richter interrupts Vianne while she is teaching. Von Richter questions her about her affiliation with Henri, who has apparently been arrested for aiding the enemy. Vianne admits that she knows Henri but claims that he is only a casual acquaintance. Von Richter presses Vianne; apparently, she's been seen with Henri several times in public. However, Vianne manages to keep her cool and successfully lie to Von Richter's face.

Von Richter warns Vianne that he will hurt her and her children if he finds out she is lying. Von Richter's threat is too much for Vianne, and for a moment she shows weakness. She begs Von Richter to leave her children alone. Vianne's reaction brings joy to Von Richter. Although she has remained stoic for months, Von Richter finally exposed some weakness in Vianne that he can exploit in the future. Vianne knows she has made a mistake but cannot do anything about it.

Around the same time, Isabelle is on her way to Madame Babineau's to lead yet another mission through the mountains. She arrives with a heavy heart and wants to tell Madame Babineau all her problems, but she knows she can't do such a thing during wartime. Instead, she puts on a brave face and tells Madame Babineau that she is ready to go. However, before Isabelle can go anywhere, a car appears outside Madame Babineau's cabin, and Nazi soldier stream out of it. They pin everyone in the cabin up against the wall and arrest them.

CHAPTER 33

Isabelle wakes up and finds that she is being imprisoned by the Gestapo. Upon assessing her situation, she recalls what she was told earlier—that is, she needs to hold up under interrogation for 48 hours. Right after she regains consciousness, the German authorities interrogate Isabelle about **the Nightingale's** identity. They claim to know that Isabelle works for the Nightingale and want the truth. When Isabelle says that she does not know anything, the authorities beat her.

However, no matter how many times the German authorities hit Isabelle, she doesn't give up any important information. Instead, she continues to claim that her name is Juliette Gervaise and that she doesn't know what they are talking about. To stay strong, Isabelle thinks about her family and how much she loves them. In particular, she thinks about Vianne and wishes that the two of them had left on better terms.

Like her sister, Vianne turns into quite the war hero. She is responsible for saving many lives in a way that suits her motherly instinct. Although she does not possess Isabelle's style of bravery, she has a form of courage that is all her own. However, Von Richter never stops being suspicious of Vianne, and the fact that his suspicions are correct only makes him more terrifying.



Von Richter has no problem making threats to get what he wants. Vianne knows that he is serious but continues to lie to him anyway. However, things take a turn for the worse when Von Richter discovers Vianne's weakness: children. Now, Von Richter knows how to get to Vianne if he needs to gain some advantage.



Isabelle has avoided detection thus far, but as the Nazis show up and take Isabelle prisoner, it seems that she's finally facing the consequences of her resistance efforts.



The following 48 hours will be a true test of Isabelle's will. She knows she must hold up even in the face of sadistic torture. From the start, Isabelle refuses to give in. Additionally, there is an added layer of irony to the torture scenes because the Nazis do not realize they are torturing the person they are looking for—but they don't realize it, since they don't believe a woman is capable of carrying out the Nightingale's missions.



Although Isabelle could rightfully be called reckless, she is not selfish, as Vianne suggests at the beginning of the novel. Here, she undergoes horrible torture and keeps her mouth shut because she wants to make sure that her friends are safe and that she does not compromise the resistance effort.



In Carriveau, Vianne witnesses a horrific scene. All around town, the Nazis have hung bodies from streetlamps to warn French civilians about rebelling. Vianne has heard that it is not uncommon for the Nazis to execute French civilians en masse for even the smallest act of rebellion. As Vianne walks around town, someone grabs her and pulls her into an alleyway. At first, she is frightened, but then she realizes that her pursuer is Julien Rossignol. Julien asks Vianne for a safe place to talk, and so they head to Rachel's house.

Once they are in Rachel's home, Julien Rossignol informs Vianne about Isabelle's situation. When Vianne asks how she can help her sister, Julien tells her that she must remain in Carriveau and protect Sophie. Vianne wants to show her father that she is just as brave as Isabelle. However, to do so would mean telling him about the children she's been hiding, which would seem disingenuous and pathetic. Instead, she listens to Julien tell her about how she will need to treat Isabelle once she returns home. Julien knows that Isabelle will be fragile and need all the support in the world. As he says this, Vianne realizes that he is speaking from experience.

Additionally, Vianne deduces that Julien Rossignol plans to sacrifice himself in order to save Isabelle. She can tell he has already made up his mind and does not try to talk him out of it. Instead, she tells her father that she loves him and gives him a big hug. Then she rips a piece of cloth from his sleeve, which she plans to tie to her tree. After, Vianne and Julien exchange "I love you," and then Julien leaves. Vianne knows that it will be the last time she sees her father alive.

Vianne returns home and finds Von Richter there with an evil look on his face. He reveals that he knows Ari is not Vianne's son and then asks her what she is willing to sacrifice in order to keep him. Vianne tells Von Richter that she will do anything to keep Ari safe. This answer satisfies Von Richter; he then undresses Vianne and rapes her.

CHAPTER 34

The Gestapo continue to torture Isabelle because she will not give them the answers they are looking for. She repeatedly claims that she does not have any information relating to **the Nightingale**. For a moment, the torture stops, and then the Germans bring in Julien Rossignol, who is in chains. Julien tells the Germans that he is the Nightingale; evidently, he has turned himself in in exchange for Isabelle's life.

Executions are becoming more and more common as the Nazis grow desperate. Everything depicted in this part of the book has its roots in history. Indeed, desperation drove the Nazis to greater and greater crimes against humanity. The longer the war went on, the more savage the Nazis became. Additionally, this is the first time in the novel that Vianne and her father directly interact with each other.



Vianne wants her father to be proud of her, but she knows that she cannot be proud of herself if she tells him the truth. As such, she does the mature thing and decides not to say anything. Meanwhile, Julien talks about Isabelle's experiences and the horrors that she will likely witness as a result of her current position. Julien now identifies with his youngest daughter in a way he presumably wishes he did not. Despite everything, the war brings Julien, Isabelle, and Vianne closer together than ever before.



Now, Julien's reason for visiting is clear. Although he was not the best father when his daughters were growing up, Julien sees an opportunity to redeem himself. Realizing there is nothing else she can do, Vianne lets her father carry out his plan.



When she returns home, Vianne's already traumatic day goes from bad to worse. This section demonstrates just how evil Von Richter can be. During World War II, there were many situations like Vianne's where soldiers would billet and then sexually assault their hostesses.



No matter what, Isabelle does not give in. Of course, she has added incentive because telling the Germans that she is the Nightingale might only worsen their torture. However, in the ultimate act of redemption, Julien takes on his daughter's moniker and sacrifices himself so the Germans might spare her.



Not wanting Julien to die for her sake, Isabelle tells the Germans that he is lying and that she is the real **Nightingale**. However, because she is a woman, the Germans do not believe her. Isabelle begs Julien not to go through with his plan, but he tells her that it is already done. In this moment, Isabelle sees the man she knew before he went off to war. Although he is a broken man now, he still loves his daughters with all of his heart, and this is his way of proving it. In a moment that is both painful and tragic, the Germans take Julien outside and then execute him; Isabelle bears witness to it all.

The night after Vianne is raped, she travels to where the Germans have imprisoned Isabelle and tries to save her. She hopes that she may be able to help Julien as well, but the first thing she sees when she arrives is Julien's dead body. Isabelle gets her papers back and is allowed to see Vianne for a moment. Isabelle wants to tell Vianne all the thoughts she's had over the past few years but knows that she doesn't have time. Instead, she simply asks Vianne to leave and save herself.

After her brief reunion with Vianne, Isabelle is forced to board a train headed for a concentration camp. On the train, she finds Madame Babineau and is glad to be reunited, despite the circumstances. No longer feeling the need to hide, Isabelle and Madame Babineau tell each other their real names. Madame Babineau tells Isabelle that she knew Isabelle was Julien's daughter all along; she just didn't say anything.

Madame Babineau knew Isabelle's parents before and after World War I. She explains to Isabelle how thoroughly the war devastated Julien. Having gone through traumatic experiences herself, Isabelle is beginning to understand why her father acted the way he did. Additionally, she finally understands fear, just as Vianne always wanted her to. However, despite everything, she is confident in her actions and would not change a thing. When the train arrives at the concentration camp, Isabelle does her best to keep her morale high and persevere.

CHAPTER 35

August of 1944 arrives, and Von Richter continues to abuse Vianne. One night, after Von Richter rapes her, Vianne lets her mind wander to Isabelle and Antoine. She wonders if they are still alive and prays that they will come back to her. Vianne desperately needs support, as Von Richter has only grown more brutal as time goes by. His mood always aligns with how well the Germans are doing in the war, and by this time, it looks like they are going to lose.

Not wanting to lose her father, Isabelle tells the Germans the truth. However, they have no reason to believe her. All along, the Germans have assumed that the Nightingale was a man, and they have no reason to change that opinion now. This moment epitomizes the cruel nature of Isabelle's position in the war. She is the perfect person to act as an undercover agent. However, she is too perfect; even when she wants to tell the truth she cannot, and this costs Julien his life.



Vianne hopes she can save Isabelle, but Isabelle is not so lucky. If anything, Vianne's trip only further traumatizes her because she catches sight of Julien's dead body. At this point, Isabelle is on her own. She does not know what the Germans will do with her, but she knows it will not be pleasant.



Unfortunately, contemporary readers know exactly what is in store for Isabelle; she will go to a Nazi concentration camp where the Nazis will torture and dehumanize her, and perhaps even kill her. The only positive aspect of Isabelle's situation is that she has a friend with her to keep her spirits up.



Despite everything, Isabelle cannot help but be proud of her accomplishments. Even though she had to make great sacrifices, she saved dozens of people's lives and fought against a genuine force of evil. As Isabelle approaches the concentration camp, she does not plan on giving up. Instead, she plans on fighting to the bitter end.



While Isabelle endures physical and mental torture in the concentration camp, Vianne goes through something similar in her own home. Von Richter continues to display brutish behavior that she must put up with if she wants her children to remain safe. Here Von Richter represents the most depraved part of the Nazi party. In fact, he acts as its literal embodiment, as his moods shift depending on how the Germans are doing in the war.



Vianne walks into the kitchen and sees that Sophie is still awake. Sophie tells her mother that she knows what is going on between Vianne and Von Richter. Vianne tries to explain everything away, but Sophie tells her that she is not stupid. Vianne realizes that she should have known better than to try to hide anything from Sophie at this point. Although she has repeatedly tried to save her daughter's innocence, she has failed at every turn. Sophie tells Vianne that if Isabelle were here, then she would have murdered Von Richter. In response, Vianne can only say that she is not as strong as Isabelle.

The next day, the weather is beautiful, so Vianne decides to take her class swimming. When Vianne announces her idea, the entire class immediately seems to forget about the war because they are so excited. Vianne realizes that the war has become normal for young children, which is a devastating thought. Shortly after, Vianne finds herself feeling sick out of nowhere and she vomits. After a few moments, she comes to the sickening realization that she is pregnant.

A week later, Von Richter tells Vianne that the Germans are leaving Carriveau. He claims that the war is not over and that he is going to reinforce other German troops. Before he leaves, Von Richter calls Vianne a "whore" and tells her that she will never forget what he has done to her, even though he plans to immediately discard her from his memory. Vianne knows that, given her pregnancy, this cruel statement is even more true than Von Richter realizes.

When the Germans leave, life starts to return to normal in Carriveau, even though the war is not yet over. However, Vianne is incapable of relaxing. Although she promises Sophie that Antoine and Isabelle will be home soon, she has a hard time believing it herself. Additionally, she worries about what Antoine will think of her when he discovers that she is pregnant. Sophie knows about the pregnancy and asks Vianne what she plans to tell Antoine. Sophie strongly implies that Vianne shouldn't say anything so that they can go back to their regular lives.

Right after Vianne's conversation with Sophie, she walks outside and sees Antoine walking toward her. Vianne is overjoyed to see her husband, even though she also feels a deep sense of shame about her pregnancy. Vianne, Sophie, and Antoine, have a tender reunion, and even Ari comes outside to join them.

No matter what Vianne does, she cannot shield Sophie from the horror of Von Richter. For a long time, Sophie has been more perceptive than her mother has given her credit for. Perhaps this is wishful thinking on Vianne's part, but nonetheless, she must now accept that the war stole Sophie's childhood.



Despite her horrific situation, Vianne still does her best to find the positives in life, which is why she decides to take the children swimming. However, even on a beautiful day, Vianne cannot be happy. Instead, she must face the fact that she is now pregnant with her rapist's child.



Finally, there is some good news. Although Von Richter pretends that the Germans might still win the war, it is clear that that will not happen. However, before he leaves Vianne, he shames Vianne for the repeated sexual assaults he committed against her, further demonstrating his cruelty.



Although Von Richter's departure solves some of Vianne's problems, others remain. Most notably, she has to figure out what to do about her pregnancy. She hopes and prays for Antoine's safety but does not know how he will react when he returns to find her with a child that is not his. Sophie is not unaware of her mother's situation and offers advice. It may not be good advice, but it is the only thing she can think of to do to allow their lives to return to normal.



Vianne's reunion with her husband is bittersweet. Although it is the best thing that has happened to her since the beginning of the war, she does not know if their lives can return to being the same as before.



Later, at the dinner table, Vianne and Sophie immediately notice that Antoine is a changed man. Vianne thinks that even his voice is different; it seems to be filled with loss. After dinner, Antoine explains that he managed to escape the Germans by simply running away. He was worried that if he stayed in his POW camp, the Germans would beat him to death. With nothing left to lose, Antoine managed to escape on foot.

Antoine moves close to Vianne and tries to undress her. However, Antoine's touch brings tears to Vianne's eyes as she recalls what she has endured for the past few years. Vianne considers telling Antoine the truth but ultimately decides that it would be better if she didn't. Instead, she decides to have sex with Antoine that night so that she can pretend the baby forming inside of her is his. Two months later, Vianne tells Antoine she is pregnant. Antoine is sure that they won't lose the child and calls its conception a miracle. Vianne doesn't know for sure, but she wonders whether Antoine has figured out the truth. Either way, he seems content to let the past stay in the past.

Vianne worries that Antoine's experience in the war will affect him as it affected her father. Both she and Antoine will have to overcome the various traumas they suffered and endured over the last several years if they hope to move forward.



Vianne has not had a sexual encounter in years that was not sexual assault. Antoine cannot possibly know this, and Vianne does not tell him. At this moment, Vianne has to choose: should she tell Antoine the truth or have sex with him and then pretend that it was Antoine, not Von Richter, who got her pregnant? Once more, the horror of war forces her to make an impossible decision.



CHAPTER 36

In February of 1945, Isabelle is still working in a concentration camp. The weather is brutal, and on this particular day, she and Madame Babineau are put on a road crew. The road crew is perhaps the most brutal job in the camp, as the women are strapped up to a steel wheel and whipped as they move through the snow. Isabelle forces herself to just keep moving, even though every step is an exercise in pain. After their work is done, Madame Babineau tells Isabelle not to cry—if she does, she will give up hope and die. But Isabelle is already ill and doesn't know how much longer she can last. However, she knows that the war is coming to an end, and she sees the light at the end of the tunnel.

Shortly after their work on the road crew, Isabelle and Madame Babineau are moved to another concentration camp. When Isabelle gets off of the train, she sees Anouk, who calls out to her. Anouk explains that the Germans are executing everyone in the camps to cover up their tracks. She also tells Isabelle that Gaëtan, Henri, and Paul were arrested, and that Henri was executed. Before she can learn anymore, the authorities separate Isabelle from Anouk. They both say goodbye to each other as the authorities pull them apart.

Although the Germans left France by the end of 1944, the war wouldn't end until 1945. This means that many of the prisoners held in Nazi labor camps were still enslaved there for several months after the liberation of France. Prisoners endured wretched conditions; the Nazis barely fed their prisoners, nor did they give them medical attention.



Here, Isabelle learns of the tragic fates that her friends and loved ones have met. However, at least it is possible that Gaëtan is still alive, which gives Isabelle some hope.



CHAPTER 37

Vianne travels to Paris in hopes that she will find Isabelle but has no luck. She goes to Julien's apartment, only to find that no one has lived in it for a long time. She also travels to a hotel where concentration camp survivors are gathering. All around, people are looking for their family members, and many of them are not having much luck. Vianne finds a Red Cross worker and asks him if he can look up some names for her. She also tells him that she has the names of the many children she saved throughout the war. The worker takes Vianne into a back room, and Vianne gives him the list with the children's names on it. The man looks at Vianne with a great sense of admiration.

Next, the man looks up Rachel, Marc, and Isabelle. Unfortunately, he has no good news. Both Rachel and Marc died in concentration camps, and there is no record of Isabelle's existence. The man tells Vianne that he is sorry for her loss and that she should go home and wait for Isabelle to find her way back. On the way back to Carriveau, Vianne tells Sophie that Ari is officially her brother. She also explains that the child she is carrying will be raised with a sense of love and hope, regardless of who its father is. That, according to Vianne, is the only way forward.

In the meantime, Isabelle and Madame Babineau hear something going on in their camp. When they go and examine the cause of the disturbance, they realize that the Nazis have left the camp. Isabelle and Madame Babineau rejoice as they realize that they have survived. As they celebrate, American tanks come rolling into the camp.

Vianne continues to wait for Isabelle. One day, not long after Vianne's trip to Paris, Antoine takes Vianne outside and presents her with a surprise. Ari and Sophie have prepared a play with the help of Antoine, which they plan to put on for Vianne. Vianne watches the play and cannot help but take immense joy in what she sees.

While the play is going on, a car arrives, and two men get out. The men speak with Antoine, who then calls over Vianne. Antoine has a serious look on his face and Vianne can tell that she will not like what she is about to hear. The men explain that they are part of a Jewish organization that seeks to reconnect Jewish people with family they lost during the war. Although Ari's parents did not survive, Ari has Jewish relatives in America who want to take him in.

Vianne cannot locate Isabelle because she does not know which camp the Nazis sent Isabelle to. At this point in history, American troops had liberated some of the Nazi camps; however, others were still in operation. Following World War II, it was difficult for many people—especially Jewish people—to reunite with their families because so many died in the camps. It was difficult to know who was alive and dead and where everyone ended up.



Here, Vianne experiences another terrible loss. Rachel and Marc died in their respective camps, meaning that the Nazis took away two more people she loved. As such, Vianne plans to raise Ari like her son. She believes that Rachel would want it that way. She hopes love will conquer war but wonders if that thought is naive.



Despite all her hardships, Isabelle perseveres until the end of the war. Although the Nazis may have tried to break her spirit, they were not successful.



Ari and Sophie's play is reminiscent of a moment from the beginning of the novel where the Mauriacs have a family picnic. It is an idyllic scene but also one that is infused with a deep sense of melancholy.



Unfortunately, the play cannot finish because Vianne and Antoine are interrupted by even more bad news. Ari is one of the few good things that came out of the war, and it seems like now Vianne is about to lose him too.



This news is devastating to Vianne; she cannot fathom giving up Ari. However, the men convince her that it is the right thing to do. Millions of Jewish people were killed during the Holocaust, and the men want to make sure that Ari is raised Jewish so that their culture doesn't die out. Vianne knows what she has to do, and she knows how much it will hurt. She calls Ari to her and explains to him that although she loves him very much, he will have to go and live with his relatives in America. Vianne promises Ari that he will have a great time in America and that there is no need to get upset. Nonetheless, when Ari leaves, he immediately begins bawling. Vianne thinks that giving up Ari was the hardest thing she's ever had to do.

Although Vianne does not want to give up Ari, she realizes why she must. As the men say, the Nazis massacred millions of Jewish people during the Holocaust, and it is vital to salvage what remains of Jewish culture. However, to Vianne, giving up Ari feels like losing yet another child; it is almost more than she can bear, but she decides to do it anyway. This decision is the last impossible choice that Vianne has to make, and the most difficult.



CHAPTER 38

Isabelle and Madame Babineau make it to the Red Cross station in Paris. Madame Babineau walks Isabelle to the train station and sends her on her way to Carriveau. Isabelle is still quite ill, and she's no longer person she was when the war began; she wonders how she will be able to move forward.

Finally, Isabelle is on her way home. However, she returns a changed woman. Isabelle is ill from her treatment in the concentration camp, and her mind and body are shattered. Like Vianne, she does not know how to return to normal.



Isabelle arrives in Carriveau to find Vianne waiting for her. Vianne hugs Isabelle and for the first time she truly feels like she has survived the war. Vianne takes Isabelle home and cares for her. Isabelle apologizes for the events that led to Beck's death, and Vianne apologizes for the many times she thinks she has failed Isabelle. Both sisters decide to start fresh and leave the past behind. They also compliment each other on their bravery. Both women have a sense of what the other has gone through, which makes them deeply respect each other.

In a touching scene, the novel's two protagonists reunite. Finally, the sisters get to say everything they've always wanted to say to each other. The war helped them appreciate each other's strengths and realize they must forgive each other's flaws.



Unfortunately, Isabelle is not doing well. She is regularly coughing up blood and doesn't seem to be getting better. A few days after her return, Isabelle goes outside barefoot in the snow and watches the Allied troops drive through Carriveau. For some reason, she thinks that Gaëtan is on his way to find her. When Vianne sees Isabelle out in the snow, she pulls her inside and does her best to warm her back up. But Isabelle only seems to be getting worse and increasingly delirious.

Isabelle's behavior is strange given her weakened mental and physical state. However, it is fitting that Isabelle can watch the Allied troops drive into the town she so bravely defended. Really, the only thing Isabelle wants at this point is to reunite with Gaëtan, though it doesn't seem like she will survive with or without him.



Once Isabelle is back in bed, Vianne reads a letter Julien gave to her before he died. The letter expresses Julien's love for his daughters and his sorrow that he could not be a better father to them. Isabelle says that she has been searching for her father's approval for her entire life, but now that she has it, all she can feel is loss.

Isabelle's reaction to Julien's letter demonstrates how the war simultaneously brought the family together and ripped them apart. Indeed, it would be hard to feel anything other than loss, given the context in which Julien wrote the letter.



The following week, Gaëtan arrives in Carriveau and goes to see Isabelle. Isabelle worries that Gaëtan will not think she is pretty because of what she endured in the concentration camps. However, as soon as she lays eyes on him, all her worries fade, and they embrace each other. While in Gaëtan's arms, Isabelle thinks to herself, "don't forget me."

Before Isabelle's death, she finally receives the visit she has been waiting for. She reunites with her lover one last time, and although the reunion is brief, it means everything. Isabelle's greatest fear is that people will forget her, but the novel's title suggests that she does not need to worry about this.



CHAPTER 39

It is now 1995, and the still unnamed narrator has just arrived in France with Julien. She mentally prepares herself for what she is about to experience and what her son is about to learn. On the way to the reunion, the narrator takes Julien to a macaroon vendor. She buys two macaroons and hands one to Julien. Julien eats the macaroon and is stunned by how good it tastes. The narrator recalls that macaroons were her mother's favorite treat, and it brings her happiness to see Julien enjoy one.

Evidently, Julien has never been to Paris before because his mother did not take him as a child. However, his first experience in Paris starts on the right foot as his mother treats him to one of her mother's favorite treats. In this bittersweet moment, the narrator shows Julien a meaningful part of the culture she left behind.



The narrator and Julien walk the streets of Paris, eventually arriving at the building where the reunion is being held. The narrator admits to Julien that she is afraid to go inside. However, she knows she must. Together, Julien and the narrator enter the building. When she enters, the narrator goes to a table to pick up a nametag. While at the table, she sees another name she recognizes. The sight of the name deeply touches her, but she does not say why. She picks up this nametag along with her own.

At this point, Julien still does not know anything about the meeting he is about to attend. However, the narrator knows he is about to see his mother in an entirely different light—and his mother doesn't know if she is ready. The name tag the narrator spots is presumably someone the reader is familiar with, although she still needs to specify who that person is.



After getting her name tag, a woman the narrator does not know comes up to her and escorts her to her seat. As she enters the room where the other members of the reunion are sitting, everyone stops speaking and looks at her. At the front of the room is a man with a microphone who informs everyone that a special guest has just arrived. Then, he asks the narrator to come to the front of the room to say a few words. The narrator is embarrassed; she does not want to speak to everyone but knows that she must.

The other conference members treat the narrator as a guest of honor, suggesting that she undertook heroic feats during the war.



The narrator walks to the front of the room, picks up the microphone and then begins a speech about her sister, Isabelle. She reminisces about the last days of Isabelle's life. Apparently, Isabelle did not survive long after Gaëtan's return—she died in his arms shortly after their reunion. As the narrator (Vianne) talks about Isabelle, she looks down at the second nametag that she picked up. The nametag has Sophie's name on it. Sophie, however, died of cancer several years ago.

Finally, readers learn that the unnamed narrator is Vianne, who survived the years following the war even though her sister Isabelle did not. Even more tragic, Sophie, the person Vianne loves most in the world, also did not outlive her. As the symbolism of its title would suggest, then, The Nightingale is ultimately a tragedy.



While speaking, Vianne looks up and sees Julien in the back of the room with a surprised look on his face. She also looks around at the crowd and realizes that she is speaking to the families of the pilots that Isabelle saved. When she finishes her speech, Vianne receives thunderous applause and a standing ovation.

After her speech, Vianne interacts with some members of the audience, all of whom come up and thank her. One of the audience members is Gaëtan, who is happy to reunite with Vianne. He introduces Vianne to his daughter, Isabelle. Julien witnesses this interaction with a startled look on his face. He asks Vianne why she never told him about Isabelle's role in the war.

Before Vianne can say much to Julien, another familiar face approaches her: Ari. Ari is overjoyed to see Vianne, and he tells her that he has never forgotten what she and Sophie did for him. Vianne introduces Ari and Julien to each other and explains who Ari is. Julien is astounded by his mother's bravery, a feeling that is only amplified when Ari reveals that Vianne saved many children, not just him. However, there is one secret that Julien does not learn, which Vianne plans to keep—he does not know who his real father is. In the aftermath of the war, Julien's birth helped Vianne to move on with her life. She does not want to spoil everything now by dredging up the past.

Decades after the war, Vianne finally understands her sister's accomplishments. Hundreds of people are alive today because of Isabelle's actions. Although she lived a short life herself, Isabelle deeply affected the lives of many others.



As the novel ends, Vianne reunites with people from her past. Although Isabelle did not survive, Gaëtan did and is still alive many years later. Evidently, Julien knows almost nothing about his aunt; all of this information is new to him. Vianne's secrecy underscores how profoundly the war affected her—the things that happened to her are too traumatic for her to discuss them with others, even her own son.



Even more touching than Vianne's reunion with Gaëtan is her reunion with Ari. Vianne did not expect to see Ari and is overjoyed when she is finally reunites with the man who was her son for several years. However, although Julien learns a lot about his mother's past, Vianne doesn't tell him that Von Richter is his real father. She keeps this trauma to herself so as not to pass it on to future generations. Her secrecy also suggests that the love she has for her son far outweighs the hate that von Richter imposed upon her.





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